

THE DOLL MAKER FILES



NINE ROOMS

YEHOR SELIN

THE DOLL MAKER FILES

NINE ROOMS

Yehor Selin

Contents

The Locked Izakaya	5
The Department	13
Nakamura Aoi	26
Ito Kazuo	43
Sato-san	58
Kingyo, Broken Glass	68
The Detention Center, Again	77
The One Who Came Three Times	86
Endo, the Basement	94
The Room — The Pier	104
Reisen-ji	113
Kenji Yamada	127
The Room — The Clinic	137
Four Firms, One Post Box	147
The first personal message	161
The Highway	177
Ashibetsu-yama, empty	187
Ogawa	205

Kingyo, at night	221
Endo, the grave	224
Toshi goes free	231
Hokkaido, snow, 2022	240
The road to Shiribetsu	248
Nine doors	258
Still waiting	276
The forest	288
The air	306
THE LAST ROOM	311
About the Author	312



PROLOGUE

The Locked Izakaya

A kitchen whose owner had not brewed coffee for two months.

Yukio Kurosawa's kitchen held the smell that holds in kitchens of people who drink coffee once a day and never rinse the pot after.

He knew this. He made coffee every morning and washed the dripper after. But over the last six weeks the dripper had stood more often than it had been used; the filter hung in it wet, then dry, then wet again; and a film of old grounds clung to the walls of the moka pot, which he had not brewed in for a long time — it had stood there since the days he lived in the prefectural dormitory — and the tin on the shelf that had once held beans had been empty for twelve days.

He knew this, and this morning at six he decided not to make any at all.

He stood at the kitchen window, in his socks, and looked out at Maruyama Park. The snow lay thin, dark at the edges of the paths. A crow sat on the nearest lamppost. It watched him the way it always watched him. He did not nod.

Then he stepped away from the window.

On the kitchen sill, next to the bronze ashtray he never filled at home, stood two identical white porcelain figures. Without faces. One was his own, from Hachirodate, from Toshi's plot; he had taken it himself after the arrest, and it had stood there ever since. The other was from Kamishiroi, from the shelf above the altar — Ogawa had let him take it after the firemen carried the altar up out of the basement. The two figures stood side by side, and the morning light fell on them the same way.

He dressed.

The same coat — black wool, mid-thigh. Dark gray scarf. Leather shoes, soles resoled twice. The paths of Maruyama crunched under them with the same dry crunch as two winters ago, and last winter. The city had changed nothing beneath him.

He did not turn toward headquarters.



He reached Susukino in forty minutes on foot. He did not take the subway. The subway was for the times something was burning.

The alley off Minami 4-jo 6-chome kept its silence at this hour. An automatic ramen brazier a block up stood dark, the shutters down. Two thin cats by the dumpster watched him longer than they needed to, then parted.

The doors of the *izakaya* Kingyo were closed. The sign — not taken down, the old red fish on wood — held on the nails he and

Sato-san had driven in together in the autumn of 2019, when a typhoon had torn it off. A handwritten note on the door: "しばらく休みます" (*Closed for a while*). Sato's hand. A second line beneath it in another hand, clerical, added later: "*Return key to Minami precinct — 011-XXX.*" The building manager had added that some three weeks ago, when she understood the tenant was not coming back.

Kurosawa stood at the door.

He had come here twice in the first month after he was discharged from the hospital. Both times he had stood and read the note. Both times he had walked away.

Today it had been two months.

Two hours earlier, in his mailbox downstairs, there had been a yellow slip notifying him of a registered letter — as of the first of the following month, the landlord was terminating the lease on the *izakaya* premises, since the rent had not been paid and the tenant was unreachable at any of the contacts provided. Below, the standard paragraph about vacating the premises by the fifteenth.

He put the slip into his coat pocket. Not into his notebook. Into the pocket, next to his lighter.

The window at Kingyo was old, double-glazed, put in back in the nineties. On the inside, a paper concertina screen behind which nothing could be seen. To the left of the door, brickwork, three courses down from the frame.

He took off his scarf. Wrapped it twice around his right hand and tucked the end into his palm.

He struck once with his elbow. The glass held.

Struck a second time. The inner pane cracked on the diagonal from the upper right corner.

The third — and the outer went to cobweb.

He wrapped the scarf tighter and knocked the central shard through with the heel of his hand. Three layers of glass fell inward onto the wooden sill and past the sill, onto the floor, in small pieces, like ice off a roof.

He did not hurry.

He pushed his hand through the opening and found the inner latch. It gave at once; it was an old latch that Sato had loved because *"it knows my fingers."*

The door opened inward.

He stepped into Kingyo the way one steps into another man's room while he sleeps.



Inside, it held the smell that holds in the kitchens of people who have kept a kitchen for forty years and, for two months, have not.

Soy that had settled into the board and had not been rinsed off with hot water. A thin film of oil at the base of the gas stove. Rust from a tap that dripped rarely and slowly and left a ring on the bottom of the sink. A faint cat-smell — not the animal, but the smell that starts up in an empty kitchen in the second month. And over all of it — Peace tobacco, old, not fresh, that had soaked into the ceiling wood over the years and had not left it.

He stood at the threshold and did not move.

The counter was clean. Eight seats. The stools — three black, five brown — stood straight, tucked under the edge of the counter the

way Sato tucked them before closing. Three glasses on the upper shelf above the counter, upside down, bottoms up, the way they were set out to dry. Behind the counter, on a wooden peg — the white cook's shirt. It was not on the peg. The peg was empty.

He registered this the way one registers a missing signature on a report.

He walked behind the counter.

On the work surface behind the counter, a small pack of Peace without filters. He knew this pack. He knew where Sato kept it — on the wooden shelf between the brazier and the socket for the refrigerator. He opened the lid with one finger. Counted.

Fourteen cigarettes. Two empty slots on the right.

Sato opened a new pack on Tuesday evening. Thursday morning, when Kurosawa came in for tea before his shift, the pack usually held thirteen. On Friday, nine. On Sunday, three.

Fourteen meant a pack from which two had been smoked. Which meant the beginning of Wednesday. Which meant, roughly, when Sato had last locked Kingyo.

He put the pack back exactly in the corner from which he had taken it.

The kettle by the brazier was cold. A thin ring of scale on the bottom. It had not held water for a long time.

He went round the counter the other way, to the register.

The register — old, mechanical, with levers — stood on a low wooden cabinet by the entrance, where it always stood. The glass top clean; someone (Sato) had wiped it a last time. Beside it on the cabinet: the brown leather order pad, a pencil with a blunt point, a magnet for receipts, a change dish with one five-yen coin and one

one-yen coin.

And an envelope.

Cream. Heavy stock. No address, no writing. It lay exactly in the middle of the cabinet, clean, as if just brought in. No dust on the envelope. No dust around the envelope either. Someone had wiped the cabinet with a cloth under it when they set it down.

Kurosawa did not pick up the envelope at once.

He stood over it for half a minute.

Someone had been here. Not a week ago and not two. Recent. Perhaps yesterday.

The glass — the glass he had just broken — was still settling on the sill behind his back with a small sound.

Then he lifted the envelope by an edge between two fingers. The flap did not hold on its own — the paper still remembered the hand that had closed it.

Inside lay one thing.

A newspaper clipping folded in two. The print matte, the paper aged over time to that dry gray shade that comes to newsprint over ten or fifteen years. The headline short. The defendant's name. The venue. Tokyo, winter.

In the lower right corner, a photograph of a young Inspector Yukio Kurosawa, just off the courthouse steps. Black coat. The face of a man who had not slept for three nights.

Around the face, a neat circle. Red felt-tip. One motion, carried through.

He held the clipping between two fingers. He braced his other hand on the corner of the cabinet.

He knew this clipping. Not from the newspaper. From memory — and now no longer from memory. From the envelope Ogawa had silently set on his desk a year and a half ago, after the Toshi case, and said: "*This was left in my mailbox. Not yours. That matters.*"

That envelope — Ogawa's — was now in headquarters archives, in the safe, in the file "*Kamishiroi. Physical evidence. Copies.*" The original — under seal.

And this — was here.

The second.

Which meant: the Doll Maker knew Sato would not come back to Kingyo. Which meant: the Doll Maker had set the envelope on the register after Sato locked Kingyo from the inside — that is, on Monday evening, that is, together with Sato, that is, perhaps by his own hand on Sato's shoulder.

Kurosawa slowly folded the envelope back around the clipping. He put it into the inside pocket of his coat — not into his notebook, into the same pocket that held the yellow lease-termination slip.

Two things side by side, in a coat.

He stepped out from behind the counter. Walked to the door. Turned once — toward the empty peg where the cook's shirt was not — and closed the door behind him.

The glass under his feet crunched the same way — the pieces that had fallen inside and the pieces that had fallen out.

On the threshold he stood another half minute.

Then he took the pack of Peace he carried with him from his pocket and smoked one — standing with his back to the sign, his face to the alley — long and slow, down to the filter, as always.

The sky above Susukino was coming up gray.

He crushed the butt against his sole and put it in a small tin in his pocket. He let the scarf down from his cut hand and wound it around his throat.

He walked toward headquarters.

Behind him remained a broken window, an empty *izakaya*, an empty peg, and a register cabinet wiped clean beneath an envelope that no longer lay on it.

Sato had not come back.

Kurosawa had known that already. Now he knew that he was not coming back — and that a clipping with a red circle was on its way not to one man, but to two.



CHAPTER ONE

The Department

The chief was putting him forward, out loud. Two men behind glass were counting how long it would take.

The Hokkaido Prefectural Police Headquarters stood on the corner of the same intersection it had stood on ten and twenty years ago: concrete, glass, a portico too wide, under which in winter a wedge of snow always drifted in from the side where the wind always came.

Kurosawa entered at eight forty-seven.

The guard behind the partition — Mori, the same one — had his collar unbuttoned to the second button and nodded. It was clear he felt a little ashamed of that second button.

"Kurosawa-*keibubo*."

He had not gotten used to the suffix. *Keibu* he had carried for six years. *Keibubo* — a supervisory grade, the lieutenant-width gap between him and Ogawa — had been nailed to him four weeks ago, along with a warm note from the prefectural chief in which the word *methodical* was underlined twice and the word *result* did not appear.

"Mori-san."

The elevator went up slowly, as always. It smelled of wet cloth from somebody's coat. On the wall inside — a new poster, white on blue, with a red circle in the middle: "*Prevention of Chain-Collision Accidents on Mountain Routes in Winter.*" Kurosawa looked at the red circle longer than he meant to.

The elevator chimed on the fourth floor.



The Missing Persons unit held the same faintly stifling warmth as last winter, and the winter before. The heating drove hard along the ceiling. Down along the baseboard a thin band of cold from the concrete slab held. Three desks in one room. Ogawa's glass partition to the right. The calendar on the wall crooked on one pin — a new one, January, with a photograph of a red bridge under snow, the same bridge that had hung there two years ago.

Sasaki was already at her computer. She had come in at seven, if habit still held.

"Good morning, Kurosawa-*keibubo*."

"Good morning."

She looked at his face once — a short, careful glance. Not at the scar over the eyebrow — she had stopped looking at that back in November — but at the way he set his right hand on the corner of the desk. She knew this motion. He made it when he was returning

to neutral gestures after something he did not intend to recount.

Sasaki opened her mouth, thought better of it, closed it.

He hung his coat on a peg. Tucked the scarf into a pocket; the scarf had fine cuts on the inner side, and the wool held them neatly and did not shed. He took out a small metal thermos, unscrewed the cap, poured. His second coffee of the day. He drank standing.

Behind the glass partition Ogawa looked up, knocked a knuckle on the glass and jerked his chin — over here.

Kurosawa went in.



Ogawa was fifty-six. The last six weeks had added one extra fold from nose to corner of mouth, left side. He had a habit of keeping that fold ironed out by conversation — when the conversation was there, it disappeared — but at nine that morning he was not ironing it out.

"Sit."

"I'll stand."

"Sit down, Kurosawa."

He sat.

Ogawa looked at him longer than he needed to before saying the next line. Beyond Ogawa, past the glass of his office, in the outer room, through the far interior blinds — movement. Two men. One short, in a gray suit. The other taller, in black. They stood and watched this way.

Kurosawa did not turn his head.

"Behind the partition — two guests from Tokyo," Ogawa said evenly. "You don't notice them yet. I don't introduce you yet."

"NPA or Ministry?"

"Both."

Ogawa allowed himself a short pause. Then he opened a thin gray folder on the desk, spread it with two fingers, turned the first page. He did not need to look at it. He looked at the ceiling.

"Over the last six weeks in Hokkaido — three reports that don't pass through the usual filters. Sato Eiji, *izakaya* in Susukino — that one you already know. Nakamura Aoi, thirty-one, Kita 24-jo — the report came in this morning, the mother called from Niigata at six forty. The third — Ito Kazuo, fifty-two, an intercity coach driver, Asahikawa–Sapporo; the report was taken at the Asahikawa station yesterday evening. They look different. Different districts, different ages, different genders. By protocol, three separate cases."

"By protocol, three separate departments."

"By protocol — yes."

Ogawa closed the folder.

"Off protocol — all three will be on your desk by noon."

Kurosawa did not move. He only turned the thermos with his right palm onto the ring of damp it had left on the desk pad, so the ring would not go into the wood.

"Ogawa-san."

"I know what you want to say."

"No. You don't."

"Then say it."

"I'm not ready to lead a group."

"You already lead it. Since last Monday. You just haven't said so out loud."

Ogawa ran a hand down his cheek.

"Kurosawa. At the general briefing at ten I'll say three things. First — that from the first of the month a working group is being formed within Missing Persons under the internal name *serial disappearances*. Second — that you are at its head, group leader, with full authority to interrogate and to initiate unscheduled operational actions, reporting to me personally. Third — that Sasaki-*juns*a-bucho works with you as a second officer in the group, not as escort, not as stenographer, but as a second officer with the right to independent action under your coordination."

"Forensics?"

"Endo-san handles forensics on a separate line. Technical forensics — separate. I'll speak to that separately, once we have a budget."

"Prosecutor?"

"Fujiwara knows. He is not delighted. He does not like you. But he does not like anyone, and that is stable."

Kurosawa looked at the folder.

"Those two behind the glass — will they be at the briefing?"

"They'll stand by the far wall. Silent."

"Which of them will say goodbye to me first — them or the prefectural chief?"

Ogawa looked at him for a long time.

"Kurosawa. This is not a joke."

"No. It's a serious question."

Ogawa leaned back in his chair. Folded his arms across his belly, the way he always did when he was thinking out loud.

"First — me. If it comes to it. You don't need to know that, but I'm telling you, because you have to lead this with your eyes open. From where I sit — you have four to fourteen months. If you show me a map in four months, they will widen you. If you show me a face in fourteen, they won't touch you until pension. If neither — you will be quietly transferred to Kushiro."

"Kushiro is not the worst town."

"Not the worst. But not Maruyama."

Ogawa looked somewhere past him.

"Go."

Kurosawa stood up. At the office door — he turned.

"Ogawa-san. Thank you for not asking whether I'm ready."

"I didn't ask, because I know the answer."

"Yes."

Ogawa looked at the calendar on the far wall. He said nothing more.



Outside the office, the two men from Tokyo were no longer standing by the far blinds. They had shifted to the narrow sector between the copier and the printer — a place from which they were not immediately visible. The one in the gray suit inclined his head slightly toward Kurosawa. The one in black — did not.

Kurosawa crossed to his desk. Sasaki, at her own, did not look at him directly, but her fingers on the keyboard paused for a second. Then moved again.

He sat. Opened the first page of the day.

"Sasaki."

"Yes."

"In five minutes — at my desk. Bring your folder. And your thermos."

"Thermos?"

"We'll go after the briefing. Kita 24-jo."

"Nakamura."

"Yes."

She nodded.

He did not look at her as he spoke. He looked at the calendar with the red bridge and thought about how the town on the calendar was Otaru, as always on the January page.

Otaru was where Sato had been born.



The briefing took nine minutes.

In the large room on the second floor there were twenty-three officers. Two from Forensics, three from Organized Crime, twelve from various district stations, two from Traffic, four of his own. The two guests stood by the far wall, as Ogawa had said. Silent.

Ogawa spoke evenly. He announced the group. He announced the name. He announced Sasaki. He did not name the three who would be on Kurosawa's desk by noon. He said only: "*Serial*

disappearances of adults, different profiles, common methodology. Kurosawa-keibuhō leads."

Kurosawa stood by the window, hands behind his back. He did not speak.

One of the younger investigators in the second row — Tachibana from Toyohira — when Ogawa had finished, raised a hand. Asked about jurisdiction. Ogawa answered. Another, from Traffic, asked about access to the JR databases and the bus companies. Ogawa answered. The third question — quiet, from the back — was formed by the man in the gray suit. Not everyone could hear him.

"You speak of a series. Do you have grounds for calling this a series rather than simply three coincidences in a month?"

The voice was level. Tokyo standard, no admixture. He did not give his name.

Ogawa looked at him. Not at Kurosawa.

"Kurosawa-keibuhō."

Kurosawa lifted his hand from the sill. Turned.

"Three individuals," he said. "Sato Eiji, Nakamura Aoi, Ito Kazuo. Each of them has kept, for more than half a lifetime, one old piece of text in open access — a blog, a diary, a forum. Each of those texts contains one personal detail unknown to the subject's immediate circle. In all three texts, by our preliminary data, one micro-edit has been made in the last three weeks — a space, a punctuation mark, an invisible unicode character. That is the signature of a methodology known to us. That is the grounds."

He spoke evenly, without pauses. It was untrue by exactly one detail: he had data on Sato, he had a suspicion on Aoi (Ogawa had just handed him the folder in which Sasaki was to verify precisely

that detail), and he had only the report on Ito, without any preliminary reading of the digital trace. Three out of three, he had only for one.

But he said it the way people say things when three of three are confirmed. And he knew the man in the gray suit would not hear the difference. Not in this room.

The man in gray nodded once. Did not say thank you.

The one in black was writing in small pencil on an uncovered form.

Ogawa closed the briefing.

Twenty-three men dispersed slowly. Kurosawa remained standing. Sasaki, in the second-to-last row, did not move either.

The two from Tokyo went out last. The one in gray — at the door — stopped for a second. Did not turn. Then went out.

Ogawa came over to Kurosawa.

"You didn't have data on Ito."

"I didn't."

"You said you did."

"I said there were grounds."

Ogawa almost smiled at the corner of his mouth.

"Kurosawa. From this minute — every 'there are grounds' you speak in their hearing, I want on paper by evening."

"It will be."

"Who was he?"

"The one in gray?"

"Yes."

Kurosawa was silent.

"Tanaka," said Ogawa. "Tanaka Ryosuke. NPA, Interprefectural Crimes Division. Forty-eight. Careerist. Does not like Hokkaido. Does not like unorthodox methods. Does not like me personally, going back to the time I blocked him from a Sapporo posting twelve years ago. He is here officially as an observer on the topic '*Methodological support for regional units handling serial cases.*' In reality — to watch you."

"For how long?"

"As long as he can hold out here without normal Japanese food. In our canteen we have one *yamidzu* and *ton-jiru*. He likes sushi rolls with tuna. In Sapporo there are no sushi rolls with tuna."

"Not much of a profile."

"It's what I have. Go."



Sasaki was standing by her desk when Kurosawa came back into the unit.

The thermos in her hand was new — not the black one from last year, but gray, metal, larger.

"Kurosawa-*keibubo*."

"Yes."

"You told him we had data on Ito."

"I said there were grounds."

"I heard you say it."

"You are right. I said we had. We don't."

"Are we going to Asahikawa?"

"No. Kita 24-jo first. On Ito we'll go through the Asahikawa district station, I'll call from the car. We'll have the wife by evening."

"All right."

She did not move. She was looking at the floor under his desk.

"What is it?"

"Late last night I went into the archive and pulled Sato-san's blog. Livedoor. The one about tofu."

"I know."

"I found an entry from the twelfth of June, two thousand and eight. I read it through."

"And?"

"There is one invisible character between paragraphs. Unicode U+200B. It is definitely there."

"That's confirmation. That's good."

"That's not why I'm telling you now."

He looked at her.

"Then why?"

Sasaki lifted her eyes.

"I checked my mixi. Private. My younger sister has her own."

"Nao."

"Yes."

She said nothing more. She held the thermos in her hand and did not set it on the desk.

Kurosawa looked at her for one second. Then looked away.

"Let's go."

He pulled on his coat. From the inside pocket he took the yellow lease-termination slip for Kingyo, put it in the top drawer of his desk, and locked the drawer. He left the cream envelope in the coat.

Behind the glass partition Ogawa was saying something into the phone. One of the two men from Tokyo — the one in gray — had returned to the outer room, was standing by the far wall and watching. Kurosawa and Sasaki walked past him to the doors. Tanaka did not nod. Kurosawa did not nod either.

The elevator went down slowly.

He was thinking about how ten minutes ago he had said the word *methodology* aloud without the right to it before either the prosecutor or his own conscience. He had done that before only with Ogawa, and Ogawa had a habit of covering that imprecision from behind, the way one covers the shoulder of a junior partner in kendo. Now Ogawa would cover him publicly — that is, in front of Tanaka. That is, in front of the man who was writing those imprecisions down on a form without a cover.

In two weeks he would either be closed by that form or forgotten by it.

He did not know which of the two he would prefer.

"Kurosawa-*keibubo*."

"Yes."

"Tanaka-san. The one in black — who is he?"

"I don't know. Ogawa didn't say."

"He's not NPA."

"No."

"Ministry of Justice?"

"More likely."

Sasaki nodded, the way one nods when the answer was needed only to fix the silence of the next five minutes.

The elevator doors opened onto the lobby.

"Sasaki."

"Yes."

"About Nao I will speak with you. Not today. But I will speak."

"I know."

She stepped out first into the cold light of the portico. He followed.

The snow held under the soles with the same dry crunch he had walked in with that morning.

Only now he was not walking alone.

CHAPTER TWO

Nakamura Aoi

At the bottom of the clean cup there was a crumb. Fresh.

The drive to Kita 24-jo took twenty-three minutes — along Kita 5, then Kita 12, then a left toward the station overpass and six more blocks north. Sasaki at the wheel. Kurosawa in the passenger seat, phone on his knee, a warm scarf spread across the knee and, on top of the scarf, a sheet on which four lines had been written by her at six forty-two that morning:

"Nakamura Aoi. 31. QA engineer. Ezo Systems. Did not come in on 30 October. Mother calling from Niigata."

Below, in a smaller hand:

"Mother says: Aoi has not picked up since Monday. Reads LINE, doesn't reply. Twice a year."

He read it for the third time.

"Twice a year she doesn't pick up?"

"The mother said 'once every six months, when she snaps — she doesn't pick up for two or three days.' I put it more tersely."

"When was the last time she 'snapped'?"

"The mother doesn't remember. Says, around April."

"About what?"

"She didn't say."

Kurosawa folded the scarf. Looked at the traffic light.

"How long did you talk to her?"

"Twenty-two minutes. She cried three times. Not out loud. Quietly."

"An educated woman."

"Primary-school teacher. Retired. Widow."

He nodded.

The light changed. Sasaki started forward.



The building on Kita 24-jo was seven floors, panel construction, from the nineties. Balconies with white aluminum frames. On every fourth one, laundry hung out, despite the two below zero on the thermometer. The residents of this district liked to dry laundry until it froze.

Apartment 402.

The building manager brought the spare key eleven minutes after they called. He came out in a down jacket over a house cardigan, keys on a lanyard — forty-two, forty-three, a wife who opens the door for him with suspicion at any hour. He walked them silently to the door and stood behind them while Kurosawa pulled thin latex gloves onto his fingers.

"Aoi — quiet. No complaints ever. No guests ever. Pays by home banking on the first of each month. The last transfer — first of November, as always."

"When did you last see her?"

"On the stairs. Maybe two weeks ago. Not less. Maybe more. I don't notice people like her."

Kurosawa nodded. Lowered the handle.

The door opened smoothly and quietly.



The apartment was 1LDK, a narrow entry hall, kitchen-living to the right, bedroom in the back on the left. Warm — not hot; the thermostat was set at eighteen, and someone had held it there on purpose.

Kurosawa stepped into the entry hall.

One pair of sneakers on the *genkan*. Onitsuka Tigers, white with a red stripe, size 24. The inner edge of the right heel was worn more than the left — by about two millimeters. She put her weight on the right foot; an old habit from small ankles. The sneakers stood straight, toes to the door, no dust on them.

He took off his own shoes. Set them beside hers, also toes to the door.

Sasaki, behind him, did the same, quietly.

"Manager," Kurosawa said over his shoulder, "we'll be here an hour. If anyone tries to come in — stop them."

"Yes."

The door closed behind them.



He went into the kitchen-living room.

The window faced north, onto a closed courtyard with parking and a laundry rack. A thin blanket of gray light lay on the table under the window. The table was low, white, IKEA. On the table — one MacBook Air, closed, the charging cable wound into a neat loop by

the upper right corner. To the right of the MacBook, a white ceramic cup. The handle of the cup turned toward the window.

He came up to the table without touching.

Crouched. Looked at the cup from the side.

The cup was clean. The inside was white, dry. The handle wiped. Along the rim — no lip mark.

He straightened up, walked around the table, looked at the cup from the other side. The same.

Then he leaned in and looked into the cup from above.

At the very bottom — under the oblique fall of light from the window — lay one small dark-brown crumb. The size of a cumin seed, perhaps smaller. Not a stain, a body — solid, with relief.

He turned to Sasaki.

"Sasaki."

She came over and leaned in.

"Coffee."

"Yes."

"Ground. Fine."

"Fine."

He straightened.

"The cup is clean. The walls are dry. The handle is wiped. On the bottom — a fresh crumb of ground coffee."

Sasaki did not answer at once.

"Yesterday she could have drunk coffee, washed sloppily, the crumb settled."

"She could have."

"But."

"But there is no coffee grinder in the apartment. No filter machine. No moka pot. Not a single jar of beans in the kitchen."

He opened the upper cupboard over the sink.

The shelf — three boxes of tea. *Genmaicha*, *Sencha*, *Hojicha*. One small jar of Nescafé Gold instant, two-thirds full. The lid not fully closed.

"Instant."

"Yes."

He closed the cupboard.

The second cupboard — plates, two bowls, two cups, all the same, from the same set. The third — rice bowls, three chopsticks in a stand, the stand empty.

Nowhere — ground coffee.

He came back to the table.

"Someone was here with their own coffee."

"Or brought it."

"Or sat down to drink with her."

He did not add the third.

Sasaki took an evidence bag from her belt pocket. Opened it. Kurosawa used tweezers to move the crumb from the bottom of the cup into the bag. The bag was sealed, labeled.

"Call the response team now?" Sasaki asked quietly.

"No. Not yet."

He wanted to go further in.



The bedroom was narrower than expected — a little more than a niche. A futon bed on a wooden frame, the blanket flung back two-thirds down, the way one flings back a blanket when getting up and not intending to come back. Two pillows — one flat, one fuller; she slept on the flat one.

Kurosawa looked.

On the flat pillow, the mark of a temple, oval, deeper on the southern side. On the nightstand to the left, glasses in a thin frame, the arm turned toward the bed, the way a person sets them down who sits up, takes them off as a last action, and lowers herself onto the flat pillow. Beside them, a water glass. Half-full. On the surface of the water a thin film of dust.

Half-full and with dust — that meant not two days. A week.

The blanket had been thrown back on Thursday.

"The mother reported her missing on the first of November."

"Yes."

"But she didn't sleep here Saturday night."

"Yes."

He opened the wardrobe.

Nakamura Aoi's clothes hung in the wardrobe the way clothes hang for a person who knows she will come back here today, and tomorrow, and Thursday. On the left, sweaters stacked, colors from the darkest on top to the lightest at the bottom; on the right, hangers with blouses and jackets; on the lower shelf, seven identical pairs of white striped socks and one pair of gray. Nothing shifted. Nothing

missing to the eye.

Kurosawa ran his fingers along the tops of the sweaters.

One sweater from below was not where it should have been. The color order broke at the fourth step from the top: dark blue lay above olive. That does not stay that way for a person who folds by gradient.

Someone had pulled out a sweater. Put it back in a greater hurry than she would have.

"Sasaki. Here too."

Sasaki looked, nodded.

He left the bedroom.



The work corner was the right corner of the kitchen-living room, under a tall lamp on an arc bracket. A low table, wooden. On the table — the MacBook, a switched-off Bose desktop speaker, two folders with papers, a box of Muji pens, black 0.38, six of them, and a cobalt dish with two paper clips.

And an empty rectangular place the width of a palm.

Kurosawa leaned over the table.

The place was half a millimeter lower than the surface of the table. A faint outline — the thinner dust had not settled where for years something had been laid down and picked up, laid down and picked up. Size — about thirteen by nineteen centimeters. Plus or minus.

"Moleskine."

"What?"

"A Moleskine used to lie here. Hardcover, standard L. Thirteen by nineteen. Did the mother say?"

Sasaki nodded.

"The mother said that Aoi never leaves the house without a notebook. It's in her bag or on her table. Always. Almost like a body."

"The bag is on the *genkan*."

Kurosawa went into the entry hall and lifted the bag — gray canvas, long handles. Unzipped it. Wallet, keys, glasses case, two Muji pens, a tube of hand cream, a small plastic container with two mints, a dry-cleaner tag for a suit dated last Thursday, two pages of printed code with small notes in green marker.

No notebook.

He put the bag down as it had been. Turned it in one motion by the strap so the clasp faced toward the door — Aoi set the bag down exactly that way, and the thin mark of the clasp on the *genkan* mat, a millimeter to the right of center, said so.

He came back to the table.

"The notebook has been taken," he said quietly. "Keys, wallet, work papers — all here. Bag here. Sneakers here. Blanket thrown back on Thursday. Sunday evening she did not come back. Someone was here today or yesterday."

Sasaki stood with a hand on her phone. Not dialing.

"Kurosawa-*keibubo*. Response team?"

"Yes. Now yes. Bring in forensics from the department — Ogawa will confirm by voice, I'll call myself. Tell them, no sirens — quietly, two cars, no publicity until evening. We'll canvass the neighbors

ourselves first, then them. And — Sasaki."

"Yes."

"Pull from the dust on the table — right from the spot where the Moleskine lay — a sample. Not around the edge, from the center, from the surface layer. With the thinnest tweezers. Not with a glove."

"You think the dust layer was smoothed after it was taken."

"I want to see what it was smoothed with."

Sasaki put her phone down. Pulled thin metal tweezers from a case. Crouched over the table, very low.

Kurosawa straightened.

He walked once more, slowly, through the kitchen-living room. He looked not at the objects one by one, but at what lay between them.

The bookshelf by the door to the bedroom: twenty-two spines. Technical books on the left, cookbooks in the middle, thin books of poetry on the right. Three or four Moleskine notebooks from previous years — with colored ribbon bookmarks — stood on the lower shelf, leaning against each other. He took out the first — leftmost, oldest. The date on the first page — 2019. Entries in Japanese, small hand. He did not read.

The second — 2020. The third — 2021.

The fourth — 2022. In the middle of it — he turned it with a finger — a thin strip where one page had been cut out. With a knife or blade. Neatly, along the spread. No trace of the torn edge remained; those who tear pages from their own diaries leave the gesture differently, and the one who cut here knew where the blade should press.

He put the notebook back. Did not show Sasaki yet. He only showed when a clue became a fact, and a fact became paper.

The fifth — 2023. The sixth — 2024. The seventh — 2025. The eighth — 2026.

The 2027 was not in the bag. It was not in the wardrobe. It was not in the entry hall. On the table — only an outline in dust.

The twenty-seventh — taken.



In the bathroom, one black brush on the sink, SunStar Ora2 toothpaste, the towel's tail looped on a hook. The mirror wiped not to the end; in the lower right corner a vertical streak from a water splatter that someone had missed. Someone — Aoi. Someone — not Aoi. One drop had dried since Monday, another over it — fresher, from yesterday or the day before. A thinner layer. Kurosawa looked at that overlap for three seconds and did not say it aloud.

In the corner of the shower cabin, a tiny rectangle of light color on the beige tile, the size of a little fingernail. He crouched. Looked closer. The tile there was cleaner than its neighbors; someone had pressed something sticky or damp against it — tape, a sticker — and pulled it off. Aoi did not keep stickers on tile. Whoever had — had not kept it there long.

He did not tell Sasaki about this. Not yet.

The response team came in forty-eight minutes — two cars, quiet, no siren, as he had asked. Forensics in white. Three of them. Nods, professionalism, no one said an extra word.

Kurosawa and Sasaki went out to speak with the neighbors.

The neighbor to the left — 401 — a woman about sixty-five, in a pastel tracksuit, hearing aid in her right ear. She had seen Aoi rarely. The last time — "the Monday before last, in the lift, with a bag from Seiyu." Did not notice at what time. Did not notice with whom.

The neighbor to the right — 403 — a single man of about forty, working from home, background music behind the door. He had seen Aoi "about two weeks ago," once heard "it seemed like someone was unlocking a door after midnight" — "maybe her door, maybe another floor, I get confused now." To the question "when exactly after midnight" he answered: "maybe Thursday? maybe the night going into Friday?"

The upstairs neighbor — 502 — was not home.

Kurosawa returned to the fourth floor. Knocked at 402.

"*Keibubo*," said the senior forensic officer. "The door was locked with a key, not the latch. The upper lock not engaged. Aoi walked out of here, turned off the light in the entry hall, closed the outer lock, took the key with her."

"Or someone with her key."

"Or."

"Prints?"

"Many. Hers, most likely. One cup, table, door handle, wardrobe. We'll take samples at Ezo Systems tomorrow for cross-check. We'll lift them. But — no fresh foreign prints on anything obvious. Whoever was here — cleaned up after themselves completely. Or was in gloves."

Kurosawa nodded.

The forensic looked at him.

"*Keibubo*. Is this the thing again?"

"Yes."

The forensic stood a moment, then dropped his chin and went back into the apartment.



They were driving away from Nakamura's building at half past one.

Sasaki at the wheel. Kurosawa in the passenger seat, phone on his knee. He called the Livedoor archive, called mixi support, called the corporate secretariat at Ezo Systems, called the Asahikawa district station, asking for Miho Ito's report to be sent by scan that same day. Each call — one minute, two, three. He counted them on the fingers of his left hand.

Between the sixth and seventh call — Sasaki.

"Kurosawa-*keibubo*."

"Yes."

"The mother. Aoi's. She needs to be met. She's flying in on the evening flight from Niigata."

"At what time?"

"Arrives at 19:40. She has no one here to meet her. Her aunt in Sapporo, with whom Aoi lived — at a conference in Kyoto until Friday."

"We'll meet her."

"Both of us?"

"You'll meet her. I'll come to the hotel to see her. Not to the airport. I don't want the first conversation at arrivals."

"Yes."

Sasaki was silent for a few seconds.

"Aoi," she said, looking at the road, "in twenty-two calls with her mother did not once say she trusted anyone in Sapporo."

"The aunt?"

"About the aunt she has one phrase: '*the aunt doesn't want extra words.*' She said that back in September."

"Whoever drank coffee at her place — not the aunt."

"Not the aunt."

Kurosawa did not answer at once.

He was thinking about this — about how someone had sat across from her in the kitchen, brought their own ground coffee in a small packet, made themselves one cup, drank; she drank tea from her Nescafé Gold or green from the cupboard; they talked. Someone talked for a long time. Someone knew how to talk for a long time with a woman who is silent. Someone she had let into the apartment more than once — because the first time she would not have set that cup so the handle faced the window: the handle faced the window because she knew from which side her guest would sit, and had set the cup in advance.

"Sasaki. That cup was prepared."

"I know. I saw."

"So she was waiting."

"Yes."

A pause.

"*Keibubo*. One request."

"Yes."

"The mother doesn't yet know about the Moleskine."

"I know."

"I want to tell her myself."

"About what exactly?"

"About the fact that it's gone."

"Why you?"

"Because she will cry, and I do not want the first person she hears it from to be someone whose face she then keeps seeing."

Kurosawa looked at her sidelong.

She was watching the road. She held her thermos — gray, metal — between her knees, the way one holds a hot thing that does not belong to one.

"All right," he said. "You tell her."

"Thank you."

He added nothing more.



In the car, when four blocks from headquarters remained, he tipped his head back and closed his eyes for five seconds.

In five seconds he managed to think one thing: that Nakamura Aoi had not slept in her apartment on Sunday night, that her Moleskine 2027 had been taken, that on the bottom of her clean cup a fresh crumb of a stranger's ground coffee remained, and that this meant the Doll Maker — or, more precisely, the man before the Doll Maker — drank coffee.

Then he opened them.

"Sasaki."

"Yes."

"When we're back at headquarters — Endo. At once."

"What to ask?"

"One question. Whether there is already, in the database, any fresh case from the last three weeks in Sapporo in which a crumb of ground coffee was found in the apartment of a victim on a piece of tableware that the victim herself did not use for coffee."

"So Aoi isn't the first."

"Maybe not."

"Or this is a new signature."

"Or this."

Kurosawa looked at his hands on his knees. He had not taken the latex gloves off until the car; he had taken them off at the wheel, dropped them into a bag. His palms smelled of powder and someone else's kitchen. He rubbed them together.

"Sasaki."

"Yes."

"The crumb in the cup — not a mistake. The Doll Maker does not make mistakes of that kind. If he left it — he left it on purpose. It's a sign."

"A sign of what?"

"Not a sign to us. A sign to her."

"To her?"

"To Aoi. So that when she comes back — or does not come back — and someone else walks into that apartment, whoever walks in would see that cup the way I saw it. Would see that someone had drunk coffee there with her. Would see that she had let someone in. Not a stranger."

Sasaki did not answer. She kept one hand on the wheel, the other on the gear lever — at the corner she was downshifting for the right turn into the headquarters garage.

"*Keibuhō*."

"Yes."

"You think — it's for the mother."

"Yes."

"For Aoi's mother from Niigata."

"Yes."

"So that when she comes in, she will understand: my daughter let someone into her own home."

"Yes."

Sasaki exhaled briefly, almost inaudibly, through her nose.

"That is cruel."

"That is the level of cruelty we call *method*."

Sasaki nodded. She did not move her hand to the thermos. Did not move her hand to the phone.

She just drove.

Kurosawa looked at the road.

In front of headquarters, on the portico, in the wedge of snow on the north side, two men in dark coats stood. He recognized Tanaka's silhouette from three hundred meters out.

"Keibuho."

"Yes."

"He's waiting for us."

"I know."

"Do we mention the crumb?"

"No."

Sasaki nodded again, slowly, very slowly.

The car went down into the basement garage.

CHAPTER THREE

Ito Kazuo

"National 39 remembers me." — an entry from twenty-three years before today.

Miho Ito's report came in by scan from the Asahikawa district station at sixteen forty-eight.

Kurosawa printed it while the printer was still warm. He took the sheet with both hands, put it on the desk under the high lamp, sat.

The report was written by hand. Blue ballpoint. The handwriting was schooled, neat, with a slight forward slant — the hand of a woman who had spent forty years filling out charts in an infirmary and had learned to write so that any chart could be read by anyone in any light. Surname — Ito. First name of the person filing — Miho. Date — 1 November 2027. Surname of the missing man — Ito Kazuo. Date of last contact — 30 October 2027, 21:47, LINE message *"arrived, ate, going to bed,"* Nagayama, Asahikawa.

In the *"circumstances"* field, three lines.

"On 31 October my husband left for the morning shift — the Asahikawa–Sapporo route, JR Hokkaido coach, the 06:20 run. He did not appear for the return run 15:40 in Sapporo. Does not answer LINE, phone off. Last seen by colleagues at the transfer point in Sapporo at 12:14, smoking on the crew balcony."

In the *"additional"* field, one line in a smaller hand:

"Has driven the same route for twenty-one years. Never missed a run."

Below, a signature, the stamp of the receiving sergeant, the time.

Kurosawa read the line about twenty-one years twice.

He knew this category of person. Drivers who do not make mistakes on a route for twenty-one years — those are not the ones who keep their hand steel from discipline. Those are the ones who keep their hand steel because it shook once and, after that once, they did not allow themselves the right to shake again. He had worked with witnesses from this category several times. They do not forget details of accidents that did not happen. They remember every car that overtook them, in the same place, over twenty-one years.

Kilometer 743. He had something at kilometer 743.

Then he set the sheet aside and went back to the computer.



LiveJournal, as a living organism, died in 2019, when the Russian parent holding company moved the servers and changed the privacy terms so that private diaries could be read via a direct URL. Whoever knew about it closed the door behind themselves. Whoever did not — left themselves open.

Kurosawa opened the side panel of the browser. Typed into the search: *"north wheel jp livejournal."*

The second result.

The profile of user `north-wheel-jp` — registered 4 March 2003, last log-in 12 January 2027 (less than a year ago). Avatar — a photograph of the iron counter of a coach wheel, taken close up. The profile description — three lines, in the old early-2000s internet style:

"Driver. Hokkaido. I read poets. I do not read news."

Five tags: "road," "night," "snowstorm," "Issa," "solitude." The last tag used twice in twenty-three years.

Total posts — 89. The last — 12 January 2027, four lines of a haiku, no signature, no comments.

Kurosawa scrolled down.

Posts from 2027 — four. Posts from 2026 — three. Posts from 2025 — two. Then rarer and rarer, with a break at 2010–2018 (about one post a year), and a cluster at 2003–2009, when the author had written eight to twelve posts a year.

He opened the archive for 2004.

The list of entries for November 2004.

"8 November 2004, 04:22 — Untitled."

He clicked.



"Six years ago on this night I hit someone. National Route 39, the Kamikawa Pass, in the snow. I did not stop. I did not look. I am still at the wheel. National 39 remembers me."

One paragraph. No signature. No comments. No tags. Time of publication — 04:22. That is, the same hour at which the event in 1998 had happened (he was counting by the author himself — that is, that "six years ago on this night" was 8 November 1998, in the morning hours).

The post was open. Not private. Not friends-only.

Kurosawa looked at the screen longer than he needed to.

Then he opened the LiveJournal diff-archive — that gray service he knew about through a Ukrainian journalist who had lived in

Sapporo in 2015 and left behind a set of bookmarks. The diff-archive kept snapshots of entries on various dates from 2004 through 2027.

He compared the entry of 8 November 2004 in the snapshot from June 2010, from May 2016, from November 2022, and from November 2027.

The first three — identical to the character.

The November 2027 snapshot differed by one character.

At the end of the line "*National 39 remembers me*," after the period, there was one space that had not been in the previous versions.

The date of last edit, extracted from the archive metadata: 21 October 2027, 03:11 night hours.

Ten days before 31 October — that is, before the day Ito had not come out from under the awning of the crew balcony in Sapporo.

Kurosawa leaned back in the chair. He rubbed the scar above his eyebrow with his palm — not because it itched, but because it was the gesture with which he held something inside himself.

One space. One. At the end of a line. To read that space, either no one could or one person could. On the same day, in the same week, the same had happened in Sato's tofu blog. In Aoi's private mixi — the same week, by their preliminary data on a punctuation mark. And now — here.

He noted the three edit dates on a sheet in a small hand:

"Sato — 4 October. Aoi — 19 October. Ito — 21 October."

Interval — from fourteen to seventeen days. Different posts. Different platforms. The same signature.

And — all three posts about the same thing in a person's life. In Sato's case, the one Michiko had mentioned once: *"once a year he shows me a post he wrote at night and later deleted."* That post had been deleted, but not from the archive. In Aoi's case — a private entry about a clinic in Niigata when she was fifteen. In Ito's — this.

Each one's worst night.

He put his hand on the phone and called Asahikawa.



Ito's wife picked up at once. Her voice was not tears, but the state of voice that comes to women who have cried three mornings in a row and are now in the hour of pause between fits.

"Ito-san."

"Yes."

"This is Kurosawa Yukio, Prefectural Police, Missing Persons Unit. I have your report."

"Thank you for calling. Three people have already called me today. You are the fourth."

"I am the one who leads."

"I understand."

He paused, briefly, as was customary.

"Ito-san. I have one question for now. We'll talk in full tomorrow — I'll come myself. But one now. In 1998, in November — did something happen to your husband? Something that changed him?"

At the other end — silence.

Then, a deep breath in. Not tears.

"I don't know the details," Miho said slowly. "I only know that in November of ninety-eight he came home from a run out of Kushiro — we were still living together in Sapporo then, I had just become pregnant with Ryohei — and he lay down for three days. Not ill. Just lay down. On the fourth he got up, shaved, went to work. A month later he resigned from Nippon Express. Six months later he took a job with JR, driving the Asahikawa–Sapporo coach. Twenty-one years since."

"Did he tell you why?"

"Never. I asked twice. The second time he answered, '*Miho, there are things a person carries in place of cargo. My cargo carries me back the same way.*'"

Kurosawa closed his eyes.

That line was not his own. That was from Issa.

"Ito-san. One more question. Did your husband keep an online diary?"

"No. We didn't even have internet at home until 2010. He has a button phone."

"At work? A computer?"

"At work, yes, in the dispatch room. But for timetables. He isn't —" she broke off. "Why? Is there something on it?"

"There is one old post from 2004. I just read it."

"On what?"

"On LiveJournal. It's an English-language platform, Japanese people rarely used it, but at the time it was popular among those who wanted to write anonymously."

"What does it say?"

Kurosawa looked at the screen.

"About 1998. Nothing more."

At the other end, a long pause. Then the even, almost administrative voice of a woman who had worked forty years in an infirmary:

"Kurosawa-san. I will make you tea. Come tomorrow."

"I will come."

"In the morning. Not after noon. In the afternoon my son comes."

"In the morning."

"Thank you."

She hung up.

Kurosawa sat for some time with the phone on his knee. Then he put it on the desk.

He held two things in his head at once: a woman in an infirmary uniform who would offer him tea at ten in the morning in a panel building in the Nagayama district, and the line of Issa about the snow that a branch holds for one more second, and one more, and one more, until it breaks. Ito had read that line for twenty-one years. He read it as counsel — as an instruction to hold the branch — and not as a warning.

The Doll Maker, Kurosawa thought, had read it as an instruction too. Only from the other side.



Miho in Nagayama with the tea — tomorrow.

Endo at the morgue — tomorrow.

JR dispatch — tomorrow.

The pass — the day after, and not alone.

He looked at the LiveJournal screen for `north-wheel-jp` again. Scrolled down. The last post, the one from 12 January 2027, four lines of haiku. He read them slowly:

"The road is longer than the memory that carries it. The snow does not ask."

Not Issa. Ito himself.

Kurosawa closed the tab.

Sasaki was standing in the doorway of the unit. She came in and sat on the corner of his desk, not at her own — on the corner of his, sideways, the way she used to sit last year, when she still didn't know how to talk with him about work without paper in her hands.

The gray metal thermos in her right hand.

"Keibuko."

"Yes."

"Endo asked for another half hour."

"For what?"

"To search the database for fresh cases with a coffee crumb. She has two prior matches — both from district stations, not ours. One from Kitami, four months ago. One from Hakodate, six months. Both closed as *'left of own accord.'* Both — women in their thirties, living alone, a crumb of ground coffee found on clean tableware. In Kitami — on the bottom of a teapot. In Hakodate — on the bottom of a teacup."

"Someone had come to drink with them."

"Yes."

"Have those two been found?"

"No. One is still missing. The other — no body found, the case closed for lack of criminal indicators. The mother of the second still calls the district station once every two weeks."

Kurosawa nodded.

"Will Endo file it formally? Enter it into our case?"

"She says she will, but wants to speak with you face to face tomorrow. About another matter."

"What matter?"

Sasaki looked at him briefly, then out toward the window.

"About 2022, *keibubo*."

Kurosawa looked at her.

"About my brother."

"Yes."

"What about him?"

"She didn't say."

Kurosawa did not move for a moment. Then he lowered his head half a centimeter — a motion meaning: *I have heard, I am holding this aside until tomorrow.*

"All right. Tomorrow."

Sasaki did not stand up right away.

"*Keibubo*. Ito. What did he write?"

"One paragraph. About the Kamikawa Pass, the night of 8 November 1998. He hit someone and did not stop. The post is open

— public. The Doll Maker added a space after the period of the last line. The twenty-first of October, at night."

"Twenty-first of October."

"Yes."

"Sato — the fourth, Aoi — the nineteenth."

"Three nights in October. One after another. One week."

Sasaki drew breath once. She held the thermos with both hands now.

"He took all three in one week. Maybe in one day. Toshi said so."

"Toshi doesn't make mistakes about such things."

"And it means that while you and I were driving to Kita 24-jo today — he already had the list for all nine."

Kurosawa looked at her.

"Nine."

"He has nine doors in each of his houses."

"Yes."

"Three is the beginning."

"Yes."

She stood, hip against the corner of the desk.

"*Keibubo*. I know you'll say '*let's take it one step at a time*.' But tell me one thing now: of the nine, how many can we still reach in time?"

Kurosawa looked past her for a long moment — at the far wall, where the January calendar with the bridge hung crooked on one pin.

"I don't know," he said. "I think four. Maybe five. Not more."

Sasaki nodded.

"Then we have to go to the pass."

"No. Not yet. First, to Miho tomorrow. Then Endo. Then, through the Asahikawa district station, to JR dispatch for the camera footage from the crew balcony in Sapporo at 12:14 on the thirty-first. Only after that — the pass, and not alone. With traffic. With the locals."

"That's three days."

"That's three days."

Sasaki nodded again. Took her notebook from the desk.

"*Keibubo*. One more thing."

"Yes."

"Tanaka."

"Yes."

"He was waiting for us. We didn't go down to him. He came up. I didn't let him in here — I said you were on a call."

"Thank you."

"He wants, by end of week, a full '*methodological justification*' — on paper — for our group."

"He'll have it."

"You'll write it yourself?"

"Ogawa and I. Ogawa will sign off on it."

"All right."

She stood up.

At the door she turned.

"*Keibubo*. About Nao."

"I remember."

"No, just one thing now."

"Yes."

"Her edit — the fifteenth of October."

Kurosawa looked at her.

"The fifteenth."

"Yes. Probably on the first day. That is, of these — four. Three known and one."

"Nao — in Niigata?"

"She's not there any more. I moved her this morning."

"Does she know?"

"She knows what I told her: '*I think you may be being watched, stay with our parents, don't go online from home in these two weeks.*' She listens. She's the younger one, she listens."

"Good."

Kurosawa was silent. Then said, evenly:

"Sasaki. You will not be alone in this."

"I know."

She went out.



At half past seven he switched off the monitor.

He folded the printout of Miho's report in two and put it into the inside pocket of his coat, next to the cream envelope and the

yellow lease-termination slip for Kingyo, which he had never taken out of the morning drawer — had forgotten.

No, not forgotten. Had not wanted to.

He pulled on his coat, wound his scarf — now the wool held also the smell of the latex gloves from Nakamura's apartment — and went out into the corridor.

The elevator held the same faintly stifling warmth.

In the lobby, behind the partition, Mori-san had gone; he had been replaced by the night man, younger, with some longer surname Kurosawa did not remember. The younger one nodded. Kurosawa nodded.

On the portico — again the wedge of snow. The two from Tokyo were not standing there. One crow was standing on the nearest lamppost, and it watched him longer than crows watch.

He went on foot.

In the pocket of his coat, next to the envelope and the printout and the yellow slip, there was now also one more thing: a small sheet folded into fours, with three dates and one word, "*nine*," underlined twice — once for each of its halves.

He did not know what he would do with it tomorrow.

He knew only that on the way back toward Maruyama, tomorrow, he would go to Miho Ito in Asahikawa, drink tea, and then go on — alone, without Sasaki — toward kilometer 743. Not to find anything on the road.

To stand there and listen to the wind.

Issa, he thought as he walked, Issa wrote about snow in branches. Never about snow on a highway.

Ito had read him for twenty-one years.

Choosing what not to see.

At the crossing by the old Shinto shrine, where a red cat with a scar across the bridge of its nose lived, Kurosawa stopped. The cat sat on its stone. Looked in his direction. Kurosawa looked back.

"February twenty-third, two thousand and two," he said quietly, not expecting the cat to listen, "Ren gave me for my birthday a small pocket edition of Issa, with a red spine. I read three haiku from it and put it on the shelf. It's still there."

The cat blinked once.

Kurosawa went on.

He had not thought of Ren since Monday. Since Monday he had thought about Sato, then about Aoi, then about Ito. Sasaki had said today, "*Endo wants to talk to you about 2022, keibubo*," and Ren had come back into his head by that name. Ren always came back by name, not by image. The image was in a frame on the kitchen wall next to Ayano, and Kurosawa had not looked at it directly for weeks.

He knew how to work with that. He had done it twice: in 2015, when he buried his mother; in 2024, when Ayano disappeared. He held the name to the side. He kept walking down the street. He did his work, and the name stood the way a man in the next subway car stands — you look at him from the side of your eye, until there is a reason to turn your head.

Endo would turn his head for him tomorrow.

He knew.

He only did not yet know what she would see there.

Two blocks from Maruyama, the light on the seventh floor of the furthest building in the block went off at the same moment as the temple bell. He reached his entrance, punched in the code, walked into the warm lobby. Ryoko did not come out of her door — her granddaughter was visiting today, he had been hearing voices through the wall since yesterday. He went up the stairs; the elevator in their building was running on one bearing, and in the evenings Kurosawa spared it.

At the door of his own apartment he stood for a second without putting the key in. Listening. Behind the door — the silence that holds in empty apartments to which someone will come back in a minute. Only that silence.

He went in.

CHAPTER FOUR

Sato-san

Three posts. One week. One choice.

The *livedoor* archive was kept alive in Tokyo on servers no one had cared about for a dozen years. That was the best guarantee against deletion: what no one needs, no one strikes out — it simply stops being turned off.

Kurosawa opened the blog at six in the morning. Outside the window it was still night — that particular Sapporo dark, when snow has not yet fallen but the air already knows it will. Ryoko was up in the kitchen downstairs; he heard her running water. He poured his own — twenty-two grams, three hundred and thirty grams of boiling water, as always — and did not drink. The cup stood to the left of the keyboard, slowly readying itself to be forgotten.

`'kingyo-oyaji.livedoor.blog'`.

He knew this blog. He had read it back in twenty-one, when he first started dropping in on Sato-san to sit for a while after work and had wanted to understand why a man who poured *saké* in silence had once written about tofu as if it were a prayer. Forty-three entries. The last one — June 2010. About autumn, which tofu knows before others do.

Now he was opening it not as a reader.



Kurosawa went through the first ten posts in reverse — from last to first — and was not looking for content. He was looking for shadow.

A space inserted where there could not be one. A comma shifted by one character. A timestamp missing one minute in the morning. A unicode void between paragraphs — the same U+200B the Doll Maker had once left in Murata's post the year before. This was not autograph for autograph's sake. This was a way to verify that access still worked, that the backend still opened — and, probably, a way to fix the date the victim had been chosen and locked into the list.

The ninth post from the bottom had a strange silence.

"Tofu and Autumn Rain," 12 June 2008. Between the third and fourth paragraphs — an interval that looked like an ordinary empty line, but when the text was copied to a terminal became visible. One zero-width character. U+200B.

Kurosawa reached for an "edit" button he did not have. He had only what the archive administrator saw at backup: the edit history. He had paid Kenji for access two weeks ago — in case something needed looking at.

Timestamp of the edit: 4 October 2027. 03:14 a.m.

Ten days before Sato-san disappeared.

Kurosawa felt the skin at the back of his neck cease being skin for a second and become parchment. It passed. He stood up, went to the sink, poured water into a glass. Drank it. Came back.

He was not surprised. He had been looking for exactly this. But to see was not the same as to predict. To see is when the skin forgets whose it is.

He copied the timestamp into a separate file. Named the file ``metronome.txt``. Still empty. That would change.



At seven Sasaki came in.

She brought two tuna *onigiri* and a sheet of paper. The *onigiri* she put beside the keyboard. The sheet — between his hands and the cup.

"You said 2channel," she said.

"I did."

"Otaru, 1998, September. Thread '*port, old stories*.' Thirty posts. I pulled an archive snapshot from the forty-seventh minute — before the author of one of the posts took the post down."

Kurosawa read the sheet.

One handle, 'kanata-1959'. Eight lines.

"Pier number three. The night after the typhoon. The clamp was rusted — I knew. The wave went out and came back. He held on. Then he didn't. I stood forty seconds and listened. Once he called out. Then there was only water."

No name. No date more specific than "*after typhoon Vicki*." No mention of whom. Only one person who stood forty seconds and listened.

Sasaki did not sit down. She stood behind him and waited.

"Kanata," said Kurosawa. "Distant. 1959 — year of birth."

"Yes."

"Did you check the wife?"

"Michiko Sato, '*snow-kingyo*' on *LiveJournal*. Five hundred and ninety-eight entries, 2004–2014. One entry, 2007, September: '*He told me one story. Not all of it. Then he showed me an old post he wrote*

at night, then deleted. I did not ask anything." A pause. "He wrote from a port café. Otaru, September 1998. That's the same one."

Kurosawa folded the sheet in two. Did not look at Sasaki.

"Next?"

"Next — I'll go to the Otaru Nishi archive," she said. "They should have the school kendo club rosters from 1974. I want to find who Kenta Ono was. The second Kenta. The nephew."

"Not nephew," he said. "Cousin. On the mother's side. Back then, in 1998, he was twenty-two."

She looked at him.

"You already know."

"I guess. He wrote about it in eight lines, without naming him. You don't name the one you still see."

Sasaki nodded. Took her laptop. Walked to the door.

"Kurosawa-san."

"Yes."

"The *onigiri* are getting cold."

"I know."

The door closed behind her softly.

Kurosawa went back to the screen. He did not eat.



The second post was found in Nakamura Aoi's *LiveJournal* before noon.

Kenji came into the unit at ten, brought three laptops, the cat Miso in a carrier (the cat was asleep), and silently set everything on

the corner desk. Kurosawa showed him the file ``metronome.txt`` with one line — Sato-san's timestamp. Kenji looked at it for four seconds.

"Give me victim two," he said.

"Aoi Nakamura. mixi, old profile, ``aoi_smoke``. Private, but after the 2020 leak readable through a direct URL. Entry of 3 February 2011."

"One minute."

The minute stretched to twenty-seven. Kenji did not do anything extra. He opened three terminal windows, ran three different diff scripts against three different archive mirrors of mixi (Kenji knew of two of them; of the third only Kurosawa knew, and the surprise in Kenji's eyes turned out to be useful — Kurosawa noted that Kenji was capable of being surprised). Then Kenji turned the monitor.

"One period became a comma."

"Where."

"名前を付けたら、覚えてしまう。' (*Once you name a thing, you can't help remembering it.*) In the version before 15 October — a period. In the version after 19 October — a comma. The original post from 2011 had been edited once in eight years. This is that once."

"Timestamp."

"19 October 2027. 02:41 a.m."

Kurosawa opened ``metronome.txt``. Added a second line.

4 October. 19 October. Difference — fifteen days.

"The third," he said.

"Ito Kazuo. Your long-hauler. *LiveJournal*, 'north-wheel-jp'.
Entry of 8 November 2004, the one about the Kamikawa Pass."

"One minute."

This time — eighteen.

"One space added at the end. After
'国道39号は私を覚えている.' (*National 39 remembers me.*)
Before — period and line end. Now — period, space, line end. The
author of these posts never did that; he has eighty-nine posts,
nowhere at line's end is there a trailing space."

"Timestamp."

"21 October 2027. 03:07 a.m."

Kurosawa opened 'metronome.txt'.

Three lines.

- 4 October 2027, 03:14. Sato Eiji. - 19 October 2027, 02:41.
Nakamura Aoi. - 21 October 2027, 03:07. Ito Kazuo.

Kenji pushed back from the keyboard a few centimeters.

"Kurosawa-san. These signatures are an audit trail to himself: he
keeps a list of who he has edited so he doesn't confuse them —
memory for nine people over many years is unreliable, and a
signature inside someone else's post is more reliable."

Kurosawa nodded slowly.

He looked at the screen. Three nights. One September week
before it — silence. One week after — silence.

The dates said nothing on their own until he had aligned them
with what was already in his head.

All three edits — within the middle of October 2027.

All three in the same three weeks in which, by his hypothesis, the Doll Maker had kept a ready list in his head and been making his last checks before the act. Not "*in one day*," as Toshi had said. That was a simplification. In reality — across a short cycle, when the hand that chooses had already chosen and was only verifying that all three were still in place.

But Toshi had not said "*one day*" by mistake. Toshi had said "*find the day*" — that is, the point of origin, the moment of choice from which the countdown had begun.

Kurosawa did the arithmetic in his head. If the Doll Maker made one edit per person as a test of access and a fixing mark — then between choice and edit he might have three days to three weeks. The earliest edit — 4 October. The latest — 21 October. Difference — seventeen days. If the test access takes on average a week — then the choice was made a week before 4 October.

That is, somewhere at the end of September, the beginning of October, 2027.

He opened a calendar. 27 September — Thursday. Thursday, the day Toshi publishes a haiku. Kurosawa opened *Schannel*.

The haiku for 27 September 2027. Toshi's post from the detention center could not have gone out — but back in July, on the second-to-last Thursday before the arrest, Toshi had put up his last haiku while free:

「三つの窓 夜のなかで 同じ光」

Three windows in the night — one light.

Three objects. One abstraction. One point in time.

Kurosawa leaned back. He looked at the ceiling. For a long time.

Kenji did not interrupt.

Miso woke up in the carrier and mewed softly.



At five in the afternoon Sasaki came back from Otaru.

She had found Kenta Ono on the roster of the kendo club at Otaru Nishi, class of 1974 — second dan, left-handed, had stopped at a slightly higher level than Sato. Died in the port in 1998. The mother is still alive, eighty-two, in a nursing home in Sapporo. Sasaki had found out the address but did not go. She knew it would be Kurosawa, and she knew Kurosawa would not go to see her before Sato was alive in a hospital bed.

"Have you eaten anything?" she asked.

"Not yet."

The *onigiri* lay on the desk, soft and cold.

Kurosawa took one, bit, did not taste, swallowed. The other he left.

Sasaki said nothing about it.

She put her notebook in front of him, open to a page with a diagram drawn in pencil — three crosses connected by short lines, and one point above them, from which three arrows ran down to each cross.

"It's not three," she said.

"I know."

"It's one choice that broke into three. He was not hunting one by one. He opened your list — I mean, those six or seven people in Hokkaido who fit the filter — and put down three ticks in one evening. After that there was only the calendar."

Kurosawa looked at her diagram longer than she was counting on.

"Sasaki," he said. "I have to go to Toshi."

"I know."

"Tomorrow."

"I know."

She took the notebook. Stood by the window. Looked out at the headquarters courtyard, where under a lamp one man in uniform was smoking, his face turned aside, the way a person does who does not want to be seen in that posture.

"He knew where he would go for each of them," she said quietly. "Two weeks in advance. And in those two weeks he did not hurry."

"Yes."

"You understand what that means for Ayano."

Kurosawa closed his eyes.

"I understand."

"He chose her the same way. Once. On one evening. Three years ago. And then waited."

Kurosawa did not answer.

He opened ``metronome.txt`` and added a fourth line, empty, without a date. The cursor blinked over it for three minutes. He did not fill it in.

Outside the window snow began to fall — thin, dry, still soundless. The Doll Maker, somewhere seven hundred kilometers from him, was closing a laptop in a kitchen Kurosawa did not yet know.

Kurosawa closed his laptop earlier than he wanted to. It was a gesture. Gestures were sometimes all he could afford himself.

"Sasaki."

"Yes."

"Tomorrow at eight. Detention center."

"I'll drive."

She went out. Kurosawa was left with cold coffee, an empty *onigiri* on a paper wrapper, and three dates in a file that had settled into a shape he was not yet ready to name aloud.

Metronome. He had chosen the word two weeks ago, when he did not yet know whether he would find its work in three different archives on three different nights. Now the word was accurate.

The Doll Maker had a metronome. And the metronome kept time.

CHAPTER FIVE

Kingyo, Broken Glass

Kettle cold. Shirt missing. Hair — four weeks.

The *izakaya* Kingyo had stood in its place on Susukino Minami 4-jo 6-chome for as long as Kurosawa could remember anything in this block. Half-basement entrance, six steps down, the sign — a goldfish once painted by Sato-san himself with boat paint — the yellow faded to the color of butter left out in a kitchen. The note "しばらく休みます" (*Closed for a while*) still hung on the door. The rain had wetted and dried it perhaps eight times over.

The door-glass Kurosawa had broken in the prologue — the small diamond-shaped pane by the handle — had not been replaced. In its place was plywood, nailed up in haste. By whom, Kurosawa did not know. Some neighbor, probably. Sato had many neighbors who did not ask.

Sasaki stood on the top step and waited while he worked the lock. There was no key — there was a short metal hook that Hokkaido Prefectural Police handed to every detective in the first year of service, and no one knew how to use it.

Kurosawa opened it in forty seconds.

"You've done this before," Sasaki said. Not a question.

"Once. Not here."

The door gave inward, softly. Inside it smelled of what *izakaya* smell of when they have not worked for two months: old soy sauce that has finished evaporating; oil thickened in the fryer to the density

of wax; and a third thing — wood that has soaked in smoke for forty years and breathes it when it is quiet around it.

Sasaki turned on a pocket flashlight. Kurosawa did not.

He knew this kitchen by touch.



Inside, everything was where it should have been.

Two counters — one for guests, one for work. Eight seats. Four chairs around a low table in the corner. A ceramic pitcher of water in the entry — the same style as the one in Kamishiroi — but here it was a real one, pre-war, with a thin crack around the neck that Sato had glued twenty years ago with rice paste. Sasaki ran the beam along the counter. Dust lay evenly — the even dust that settles in a closed room over eight weeks. No prints. No traces.

On the little shelf over the counter — a pack of Peace without filters. One.

Kurosawa came up, took it, weighed it in his palm.

"How many?" Sasaki asked.

He flipped the flap open. Counted with a finger.

"Fourteen."

"Out of twenty?"

"Out of twenty."

He put the pack back. Exactly in the place it had been.

Sasaki turned the flashlight onto the register. The register stood closed. On top of it — a fresh flat patch, about ten centimeters long — the trace of an envelope that had lain there several weeks and had then been taken. Kurosawa had taken it himself. Cream envelope.

Newspaper clipping. A face circled in red. He still had it in the drawer of his desk in the unit.

"Nothing fresh here," said Sasaki.

"There shouldn't be anything fresh here. There should be something exact."

"Exact of what."

"Exact to what he loved."

Sasaki looked at him.

Kurosawa went behind the counter, into the kitchen corner. That was no longer the guest side — that was his territory. Sato had stood here every evening from six to one for forty years. A thick board of thin cherrywood on the work table, worn in the middle to a pale yellow; a steel bar above it with magnets, on which two knives used to hang — now one, ceramic. The other was not there. Kurosawa looked at the empty spot longer than was necessary.

"The knife," he said.

"What."

"He took one knife."

"Sato."

"No. The one who led him."

Sasaki came up, shone the light on the bar. The empty magnet gleamed.

"The knife is steel," Kurosawa went on. "Wooden handle. *Yanagi-ba*, thirty centimeters. He kept it for fish. Cut for thin sashimi. He never worked meat with the ceramic one, ceramic doesn't take meat. Which means the one who led him knew the

difference. Or Sato picked it up himself. Or he was told to bring something with him."

"What could he have been told to bring."

Kurosawa did not answer. He opened the drawer under the work table. Inside lay three clean white towels, folded the way Sato folded them every evening after washing: three folds, corner to corner. One towel missing. Kurosawa closed the drawer.

"The peg," he said.

Behind Sasaki's shoulder, on the low peg by the exit from the kitchen into the corridor — where Sato hung his white cook's shirt between shift and shift — the shirt was not there. The peg was clean, no web, no dust on the edges. Someone had wiped it with a hand.

Sato never wiped that peg on purpose. He simply hung on it.

"The cook's shirt is gone," Sasaki said quietly.

"Gone."

"He put it on before he went out."

"He put it on. Or it was already on him. But no one takes another person's clothing off a peg when they are taking that person away by force. Only someone leaving of his own accord takes it."

Kurosawa closed his eyes for a second.

Sato had gone out in his shirt, in a clean apron, with a *yanagi-ba* knife wrapped in a clean white towel. That is how a cook goes out who has received an invitation to someone else's kitchen. That is not how a person goes out who is being abducted.



Sasaki found the hair on the spare fish knife — the one lying on the work table separately, under a light lid. Sato always kept it there: a small helper knife, for scaling a small saury or carp. The lid did not sit tight. In the gap between lid and handle, one hair had fallen.

Grayish. Fine. Four centimeters.

Sasaki lifted it with tweezers. Held it up to the light on both sides.

"Fresh," she said. "Not ten years old. About four weeks. Maximum five."

"His."

"Maybe. Maybe not. We'll have to check."

Kurosawa looked at the tweezers.

"It's his. He dyed in September." He stopped himself. That was foolish — to say such a thing about a man like Sato, who had never in his life dyed his hair. Sasaki paid no attention. Kurosawa corrected himself: "It's his. That was his gray. Grayish, yellowed at the tips from smoke. No one else our age goes gray like that."

Sasaki put the hair in a bag. Wrote on it with a marker, cap up: 'SATO / KING / kitchen-4wk / 15.11.2027'.

"Four weeks ago," she said, "he was still coming in here. Already after the abduction."

"Yes."

"He came on his own or he was brought."

Kurosawa looked at the pack of Peace on the shelf. Fourteen of twenty. Sato smoked his pack over two days. That meant that between the day he vanished in the prologue and the day this pack was last opened in his hand — three days. Not more. The pack had been left here *between the abduction and something*.

"He was brought," Kurosawa said.

"For what."

"To take something. To leave something. To show him something."

He stood a moment longer. Then went over to the coat rack in the corridor. Behind the rack — a photograph Sato had hung in the nineties: he and Michiko, taken on the pier at Otaru, both younger than he was now. Michiko is laughing. Sato is not laughing — but he holds her by the arm, and the way he holds her is more than a smile. The photograph was in place. Kurosawa touched the frame with the tip of a finger. The dust came off in an even strip.

"Sasaki."

"Yes."

"He came here to say goodbye."

She turned the flashlight in his direction. Not to his face — to his chest. She saw he was standing in front of the photograph.

"To whom."

"To Michiko." He took his finger from the frame. "It was his way. He went to her grave three times a year. But coming to this kitchen was easier — she stayed here longer. He would smoke one cigarette, look at this photograph, look at the tableware, then leave. He did this four times a year, in the week of their anniversary. He had to do it on the fifth of November."

"Abducted on the thirty-first of October."

"Yes."

"And brought here on the fifth."

"Yes."

"The Doll Maker knew about this ritual."

"Yes."

Kurosawa moved back from the photograph. He walked to the counter. Sat on one of the stools — the third from the right, the one he always sat on — and put his hands on the wood, the wood that had remembered his forearms for as many years as he could remember.

He did not cry. He looked at the empty register.

Sato had been walked out along his ritual. The Doll Maker did not take people crudely — the Doll Maker took people inside their own forms. Sato had gone of his own accord because he had been allowed to say goodbye — and the way he had been allowed, Sato took as understanding. Older people rarely meet strangers' understanding out loud. When they meet it, they follow it, as one follows a mother's voice.

"Kurosawa-san," Sasaki said quietly.

"Yes."

"You want to say something aloud."

"No." He stood up. "Let's go."



At the door Sasaki hung back.

"Kurosawa-san."

"Yes."

"You came here on Sunday. A week before the prologue. You told Ogawa you didn't open a case."

"I came. I didn't know. I thought he had just closed for a few days."

"You saw him last."

"October twenty-seventh. In the evening. I drank green tea here, at this counter. He was silent. That was normal."

"Did he say anything."

Kurosawa thought.

"One thing. He said, '*Kurosawa-keibu, you've lost weight again.*' I didn't answer. He poured me a second cup. That was all."

"That — was all."

"That — was all."

Sasaki nodded. Went out onto the steps. Kurosawa closed the door behind him. There was nothing to lock with — the hook only opened, it did not lock. He put the plywood back in place.

The note "しばらく休みます" swung on a draft and stilled.

"Kurosawa-san."

"Yes."

"He will go willingly into the next *ryokan* too. If we don't get there in time."

"I know."

Sasaki walked to the car. Kurosawa stayed on the top step for a minute. Took a cigarette from his pocket — not Peace, his usual Mild Seven Light — rolled it between his fingers, did not light it. Put it back.

He still had four in the pack. Not today.

He came down to the car.

Outside, the snow was falling — the same that had started overnight — and now you could hear it falling.



CHAPTER SIX

The Detention Center, Again

"Find the day. He chose them on one day."

The Sapporo Prefectural Police detention center held its light the same way it had held it a year ago: a green fluorescent calm without cause and without time. Kurosawa went through two metal detectors, handed over his watch, handed over his pen and his phone, kept his notebook — new, not yet opened — and the thermos.

The thermos was not the one from last year. That one had stayed on the metal table in front of Toshi then, and Toshi had not drunk, and Kurosawa had not taken it back, and afterward one of the guards had washed it and put it in the personal-effects cabinet of the detainee. Kurosawa had not asked about it. He had bought a new thermos a month after his discharge, from a shop near the station —

a plain steel half-liter, no writing. Screw cap. Water — not green tea.

When you drink green tea at the detention center, Toshi looks at that cup, and Kurosawa did not want him looking.

The guard nodded. Kurosawa went into the interview room.



Toshi was already sitting.

He did not stand. Did not look. Hands lay on his knees calmly, as always. In seven months in the detention center he had lost weight — not much — and the bone at his temple had become more visible. Shaved bald. Dark blue work trousers, a gray shirt. All the same.

Before him on the table lay a thin sheet of paper with one question. Kurosawa recognized the handwriting of Investigator Kawaguchi — he wrote the questionnaire every Tuesday and picked it up on Thursday, and in seven months Toshi had returned three hundred and twelve sheets with no answer.

Toshi took the sheet, folded it in two, laid it neatly on the edge of the table.

"You came."

"I did."

Kurosawa sat down. Put the thermos in the middle of the table. Unscrewed the cap. Poured water into a plastic cup — brought in beforehand, from a small bag — and set the cup between them, closer to Toshi but not so close that he would have to reach.

Toshi looked at the cup. Did not thank him. Did not take it.

Kurosawa screwed the cap on. Put his hands on the table. Opened the notebook. He had no pen — the pen had been taken at the entrance. The notebook was to have something to look at.

He did not look.

He looked at the wall to the left of Toshi's head.

Toshi looked at the wall to the left of Kurosawa's head.



The minutes in the interview room had their own physics. The first five — inertia. Then — vacuum. Then again inertia, in the other direction.

Kurosawa sat twenty-seven minutes without moving. Toshi sat twenty-seven minutes without moving. The guard behind the glass shifted from one foot to the other twice. Once — at the twelfth minute. The second time — at the twentieth.

At the twenty-eighth minute Toshi slowly — with that economical movement Kurosawa had always noticed in him — reached out his hand to the plastic cup. Took it. Did not raise it to his lips. Put it back.

At the twenty-ninth — he turned the cup a little with a finger.

At the thirtieth — he said, without looking:

"Sato-san."

"Yes."

Silence.

"Nakamura Aoi. Ito Kazuo."

"Yes."

Toshi nodded. Very briefly. Once.

Kurosawa opened his mouth — and closed it. In place of words he passed a palm along the edge of the notebook. Toshi waited.

"Three edits," Kurosawa said at last. "4 October. 19 October. 21 October."

Toshi did not react.

"But it is not three choices. It is one." Kurosawa laid his palms one on the other on the table. "Yes?"

Toshi looked aside. At the wall to the left of Kurosawa.

"Find the day," he said. "He chose them on one day."

"Which."

Toshi did not answer.

"End of September," Kurosawa said to himself, quietly. "Thursday."

Toshi did not change his expression.

"The twenty-seventh."

"The twenty-seventh," repeated Toshi. Not as an affirmation. As if trying the word for taste.

"You say 'the twenty-seventh.'"

"I say nothing, Inspector. I repeat what is yours."

Kurosawa looked away.

He knew this game. Toshi played it the same way he wrote haiku — with method and without blood. Never directly. Never by lying. Only by repeating what you yourself had said — and if you said something right, letting it stand. If you said something wrong, repeating it too, in the same even voice. The difference was in how long his eyes held on the empty wall between the words.

"The twenty-seventh of September," Kurosawa said once more.

Toshi's eyes stayed on the wall for one second longer than usual.
Kurosawa closed the notebook.



"Sato went of his own accord," he said after a pause.

Toshi nodded. Once.

"You knew he would go of his own accord."

"He always went of his own accord."

"You saw him."

"No." A pause. "I knew he always went of his own accord because you knew him."

Kurosawa turned his head. Looked at Toshi for the first time in the conversation. Toshi did not look at him.

"You knew Sato-san from my conversations," Kurosawa said.
"You never saw him."

"Yes."

"I talked about him in Furano."

"Yes."

"About which side, exactly."

Toshi thought.

"You said once, '*He is the only person with whom I can be silent and not feel guilty.*' It was in December 2024."

Kurosawa did not answer. He did not remember whether he had said it. He believed he had. He knew Toshi did not invent things of that kind — Toshi did not have a fantasy of that small a kind. Toshi kept details the way one keeps a rosary: each in its place.

He wanted to ask why Toshi had told this to the Doll Maker. He did not ask. He knew the answer. Toshi had told it not as betrayal — Toshi had told it as a person who shares with his spiritual director an observation about another person who is suffering. In Toshi's frame this was not an informing. This was compassion.

Kurosawa had long ago stopped being angry with Toshi over form. Now he was angry only over content.



"You understand," Kurosawa said, "that there is one more in two weeks."

Toshi did not answer.

"Or not."

Toshi looked at the plastic cup.

"Or not," he repeated after him, quietly.

"Do you know?"

Toshi was silent for a long time. At the edge of where silence stops being silence and becomes refusal.

Then he said:

"He has taken as many as he wanted. He counts, as I told you once. Nine."

"Nine in rotation," Kurosawa said. "Yes."

"Three new. One old one has gone earlier."

Kurosawa went still.

"Who."

"Do not ask."

"Who went."

Toshi held a very long pause. Kurosawa heard the guard behind the glass shift from one foot to the other — this was already *past* the standard minutes — a third time, at the thirty-seventh minute.

"The one who was long ago," said Toshi. "He stopped repeating."

"What does that mean."

"It means," said Toshi, "that when a victim stops repeating the old dream — she becomes unneeded. He lets her go. Sometimes into death. Sometimes into a new life — but not her own. Not she herself."

Kurosawa felt his fingers dig into the edge of the notebook. He unclenched.

"Who," he said again.

Toshi looked at the cup — and, for the first time in the conversation, at Kurosawa.

"Don't ask me," he said. "Ask Endo."



Kurosawa sat another five minutes.

Toshi did not look at him anymore. Looked at the wall.

The cup stood between them, full. Toshi did not drink.

At the forty-second minute Kurosawa screwed the thermos closed. Took the notebook. Stood.

"Thank you," he said. Not for anything in particular.

Toshi nodded.

Kurosawa walked to the door.

"Inspector."

Kurosawa stopped without turning.

"Yes."

"You will come again."

"Yes."

"Bring, please, green tea. Not water."

Kurosawa was silent for a long moment.

"All right," he said. "Next time."

He went out.

The guard locked the door behind him. The click was low, short — the same as last year. Kurosawa walked down the corridor to the effects room, took his watch, took his pen, took his phone, and only at the exit from the building put his coat on.

Outside, the snow was falling.

Sasaki was waiting in the car. He sat down on the right. He said nothing. Neither did she.

They drove two blocks. Kurosawa opened the notebook. In it there was one word, written by Toshi-with-his-pencil-in-his-head:

Endo.

He closed the notebook.

"Sasaki."

"Yes."

"To Endo."

"Now?"

"Now."

She turned the wheel.

Two blocks on, it was already dark. The snow was falling evenly.

CHAPTER SEVEN

The One Who Came Three Times

A thin voice. Rain on the veranda. A sheet of paper.

Reisen-ji. Autumn 2019.

Toshi was not yet Toshi then. He was Brother Jisai, twelfth year at the monastery, thirty-seventh year from birth. He shaved his own head every Tuesday, with a dull Feather razor he kept apart from the razor for his hands. He knew his face only when he washed.

Abbot Gensho, then still sixty-four, not seventy-two, kept him on pilgrim reception. It was a post for one who did not want to speak. You met a person at the gate, bowed, pointed to the stone for shoes, showed where to wash the hands, poured tea, showed the bed — and all these movements together made four sentences in a day. Sometimes five.

He remembered that pilgrim the first time — not because the man stood out in any way. Because he did not stand out.



He came on Thursday evening. Rain.

A young man — around thirty — in a gray coat. No umbrella. Not wet — he had come from the bus stop under the awning. Someone had shown him the way. He knew.

One suitcase. Not a rucksack.

Bowed correctly. Not deep, not shallow. Bowed like someone who had learned to bow somewhere else — not here.

The voice was thin. Not feminine. Just thin. That happens when the throat is soft from someone who speaks little.

"I'm told you take three nights here."

"We do."

"Thank you."

Jisai showed the stone for shoes. The pilgrim took them off. Set them straight, heel to heel. Jisai looked — not out of profession, but out of the body. He always looked at how a person set their shoes down. It said more than the eyes.

The shoes stood perfectly.



Second night.

The pilgrim went to the library.

That was allowed — to pilgrims who asked. Not many asked. The abbot made the decision — nodded.

Jisai brought tea at eight. Knocked. Went in. The pilgrim sat on a cushion at a low table — not with any book — but before his own sheet. Was writing. Not fast. Not with a pencil — with a thin brush-pen. Jisai saw only what he caught in a glance: three lines, short, with pauses between the ideograms that were noticeable to eyes accustomed to old bindings. Haiku.

He set down the tea. Bowed. Went out.

In the corridor he stopped.

Stood, looking at the plank of floor in front of him.

He could not have said why.



Third night.

Jisai did not bring the tea. The younger brother did — Getsui. Jisai sat in his own room. Looked at the wall. Was not meditating. Listened to the rain.

At half past nine there was a knock at the door.

"Brother Jisai."

He opened.

The pilgrim stood there. No coat. In a gray shirt. Hair dry.

"Forgive the disturbance. I'm told your name is Jisai."

"Yes."

"I'll leave something for you in the library. Do not take it. I do not leave it with the abbot — I'm in a hurry. But I wanted someone from the monastery to read it. Not necessarily you. Perhaps in some year."

"What is it."

"A bound sheaf. Thin. No name. Haiku."

Jisai nodded.

The pilgrim bowed. Went.

Jisai closed the door.

The rain came.



He did not go to the library until morning. Not out of curiosity — out of discipline. The abbot said: pilgrims leave what they leave. We

do not read on the go. We put it on the shelf. In ten years, when we forget whose it is — then we read it.

In the morning the pilgrim left. Took his shoes. Took his suitcase. In the entry hall he bowed to Gensho — Gensho bowed back. Jisai stood behind a pillar and watched. The pilgrim said something to the abbot — Jisai did not hear — and left.

Gensho turned to Jisai.

"How long was he here."

"Three nights."

"Who brought him."

"He knew the way himself."

Gensho nodded. Went to his room.

Jisai went into the library.

On the third shelf from the top — where things pilgrims brought were kept — lay a thin sheaf. Eight sheets of rice paper, sewn with black thread. No name. No date.

Jisai took it. Put it back. Did not unfold it.

Discipline.

He forgot about it for eight years.



Furano. January 2027.

Toshi sat in his hut. It was the second week after he had come out of the room. Memory came back in portions: not as images, but as the form of the body — how to stand, how to hold a cup, how not to ask.

He opened the laptop for the first time in eight months.

He did not know why he went to *Schannel*. His fingers knew. He went into an old thread — "*Silence and Its Sides*" — where twenty-three handles were silent most of the time. Read thirty posts from different authors.

At the twenty-third — he stopped.

A haiku. The same method. Five — seven — five. One object. One abstraction. One point in time. No scar.

He recognized it.

He could not have said what. The rhythm. The way of placing a pause before the third ideogram of the second line. The way of avoiding banalities. The way of not rhyming an image with an image. This was not a handwriting — this was a hand.

He opened his own shelf. Took down the thin sheaf. Eight sheets, black thread. No name. No date.

Unfolded it.

Eleven haiku. By the same method.

The same one.

Toshi sat for a long time, looking at the sheet.

Then — for the first time since memory had begun to return — he laughed. One short exhale through the nose. Not joy. Recognition.

The one whom he now knew as his return to himself — had come to him back in nineteen.

Had come three times, as a pilgrim. Three nights. Had written haiku in the library. Had left a sheet on the shelf. Had known that

Jisai was the man who would one day read it.

Had known it eight years before Toshi knew him.



Reisen-ji. Autumn 2019. Later.

Toshi now remembered one more thing that he had not mentioned to Inspector Kurosawa in the conversation in December.

The pilgrim, on the third night when he had knocked at his door, had said one more thing. Jisai had paid it no attention then. It was an incidental remark, courtesy.

"Brother Jisai," the pilgrim had said, "on the shelf behind your abbot stands the same faceless figure that stands at my sister's home. I saw it yesterday when he was showing me the calligraphies. That is a rarity."

Jisai nodded. Did not ask where the sister lived.

Then, in 2019, on Abbot Gensho's shelf there did indeed stand a small white porcelain faceless figure — a cone, smooth, about fifteen centimeters high. Toshi had never asked where the abbot had got it.

In 2027, in his hut — on the altar, in the corner — there stands one exactly like it. It was given to him by a woman he does not remember and whom he was not allowed to look at. Her voice — thin. He heard her for three nights as he returned to himself. She held him by the hand while he cried, and did not ask why. That was the sister.

He could not say whether that was the same sister the pilgrim spoke of in 2019. But one thing was certain: the figure was the same.



Toshi had given Inspector Kurosawa half of this in December 2024.

Then, in the detention center — already after the second arrest, in 2026 — he had repeated the half: the pilgrim, the quiet voice, three nights, the sheaf. Kurosawa had received it. Toshi had not spoken of the second half — that he had recognized the hand in 2027. Had not spoken of the sister. Had not spoken of the figure on Gensho's shelf.

Not out of protection of the Doll Maker. Toshi did not protect him — he had nothing to protect the man from, who was beyond protections.

He had not said it because Kurosawa, had he heard, would have taken two wrong steps:

First, he would have driven to Gensho and started asking about the figure. Gensho did not remember him — Gensho was old, his hands trembled, he confused the names of pilgrims from the last ten years. Kurosawa would have made himself angry for a wasted trip.

Second — Kurosawa, learning that the Doll Maker had come under the guise of a pilgrim and that Toshi had not recognized him then, would have begun to ask himself whether Toshi had recognized him then and lied. That would have poisoned the conversations in the detention center.

Toshi did not want to poison the conversations. The detention center was the only place where he and Kurosawa sat across from each other without the Doll Maker between them.

He kept silent out of love — if that word could apply.

He knew Kurosawa would not use him — yet.

He knew Kurosawa, when there was less time left, would come to him and bring green tea. And then — perhaps — Toshi would tell him the second half. Or — perhaps — he would not manage in time.

Toshi closed his eyes.

The rain in Furano fell the same way the rain had fallen in Reisen-ji in 2019 — evenly, without intent.

He opened his eyes.

The plastic cup of water stood in front of him. Empty. The detention center.

Time had shifted half a step again.

CHAPTER EIGHT

Endo, the Basement

"One molar, Kurosawa. Only one. But not that one."

Machiko Endo tossed her last cigarette into the ashtray outside the door of the morgue and stepped in — not to greet anyone — so that nothing would distract her for the next hour and a half. She closed the door with her shoulder. Turned the key. It was her ritual. The key turned not against outsiders — against herself, so she would not step out to the café around the corner before she was done.

On the lower floor — the place her friends in the police called *the basement*, though technically it was a semi-basement with proper windows under the ceiling — she had three fridges, two work tables, one archive cabinet with twenty-two drawers, and one shelf with a cup, a box of Lipton, and one bottle of Nikka behind the box. She had not touched the bottle for three weeks. That was a good sign.

She turned on the light. The fluorescents came on with that short half-second delay Endo knew better than her own name. She set the thermos on the work table. Pulled a folder off the shelf.

The folder was the same one she had kept on her table for seven months.

黒澤 蓮 / KUROSAWA Ren / DOB 1979.04.12 / DOD 2022.02.17 (protocol).

She opened it. Not because she did not know its contents by heart. Because on paper it became different — concrete.



Endo did not love Kurosawa as a person. She loved him as an obligation.

In 2019 he had found her sister. Not alive — the body — by a bridge, in a marsh, after seventeen years of searching. Endo had said one line to him then: "*Kurosawa-san, you think I'm thanking you. I owe you.*" He did not answer. That is his way of taking on obligations — not taking them on with words.

Now she had to return that obligation. Not to her sister — to Kurosawa. And she was returning it without hurry.

Endo did nothing in a hurry. It was a profession. The dead do not hurry, and the living who hurry make mistakes in the morgue, and Endo had seen three dozen such over twenty-two years — all reassigned to other posts or quietly let go.

She sat down. Opened the odontologist's protocol from 2022 — the one on top of the pile.

Three pages. Signed by Dr. Iwamura Ken'ichi, age as of 2022 — seventy-one. Retired in 2023. Died in 2025. In 2022 he was doing relief work at the forensic center — that was his third job, after private practice and teaching. Endo had known him since student years. Back then he was precise. In 2022 — no longer.

The description of the dental arch in the protocol was standard, laconic. On the lower left M1, a notation: "*present, no serious defects observed, restoration minor.*"

Endo set the protocol aside. Took from the same folder Ren's old dental file. She had obtained it two weeks ago — by lawful request through the investigation — from the private dental clinic Sapporo Odonto, where Ren had been treated since 2015.

The file was four times thicker than the protocol.

Entry of 8 March 2018:

"Patient Kurosawa Ren. Complaint: pain in the lower left jaw. Examination: M1 lower left — vertical root fracture, consequence of trauma (patient reports a fall from a bicycle in February 2018). Extraction indicated. Performed. Patient consented to subsequent implantation."

Entry of 22 April 2018:

"Nobel Biocare Active implant placed, titanium post 11 mm long, 4.3 mm diameter. Temporary crown. Patient satisfied."

Entry of 15 June 2018:

"Permanent crown, metal-ceramic, seated. Hygiene satisfactory. Next examination — May 2019."

Endo opened the third document in the folder. It was a table she kept herself, in pencil, on graph paper. Three columns: *"what should be," "what is recorded in the 2022 protocol," "conclusion."*

On the line *"Lower left M1"*:

- Should be: metal-ceramic crown on a titanium post of a Nobel Biocare Active implant. - Recorded in the protocol: molar present, restoration minor. - Conclusion: discrepancy.

Endo ran a fingernail under that last word. Her nails were cut short, like those of everyone who worked with their hands; the polish was clear, so no one would see it chipping.

A titanium post does not burn in a fire with a fuel-tank explosion. It deforms but stays. A metal-ceramic crown cracks — yes — but the post remains. An odontologist writing a protocol — even under stress — could not confuse a natural root with a titanium post. That is not a question of experience. It is a question of

instrument. Titanium does not pass through an x-ray as bone.

One of two things was the truth.

Either Dr. Iwamura had committed gross negligence in 2022 and, now dead, could neither confirm nor deny it.

Or the tooth in the mouth of the body in the burnt car in February 2022 — was not the tooth of Ren Kurosawa.



Endo took a second folder from the shelf. A thin one.

Inside lay one sheet. On the sheet — two names. Both were dentists. Both from Hokkaido. Both worked at different clinics, both were among those to whose backups the Doll Maker might have had access in 2020–2023. Endo was running her small OSINT, telling neither Kurosawa nor Ogawa. She loved OSINT the way a cook loves someone else's recipe — without admitting to the love.

One of the two dentists was the brother of a subcontractor at the firm Yuki-Kogei. Not much of a connection — but in Hokkaido everyone knew everyone within two handshakes.

Endo had not approached this dentist directly. She had only written his name on a sheet and put the sheet in the folder.

That would be for later, she thought — though she did not call it "for later" aloud. She called it *"what comes after."*

Another sheet, under the first:

A request for isotope analysis of tooth enamel — the typical method for determining a person's regional origin from the ratio of strontium and oxygen in the teeth. Endo had submitted the request two weeks ago to a Tokyo lab, through official channels, through Ogawa, paying out of her own budget.

Results were due in two weeks.

Endo looked at the clock on the wall. Half past eleven. Lunchtime. She had not eaten.



The call from the departmental secretary came at twenty past one.

"Endo-*sensei*, Kurosawa-*keibubo* is here. And Sasaki. They're downstairs."

"Let them up."

Endo did not stand up. Did not straighten her lab coat. Took the folder — both, the thin one hidden under the thick — and set it on the table.

Kurosawa came in first. Thinner. The scar on his brow white, which one day in poor light would be pink. Did not take off his coat — only unbuttoned it. Sasaki behind him, hair cut short, no makeup, with a thermos.

"Endo-san," said Kurosawa.

"Kurosawa."

A pause.

"I was told to come to you," he said.

"By whom."

"Toshi."

Endo nodded. Was not surprised. She had known that one day Kurosawa would come from exactly this side. She had only not thought it would be today. She had been counting on next week — after the isotope analysis. Then she would have had two more arguments and one less span of time.

"Sit."

He did not sit. Sasaki sat.

"Endo," said Kurosawa. "Ren."

"Yes."

"Speak."

Endo opened the folder. Turned it to face him. Pointed a finger at the odontologist's protocol.

"One discrepancy. Lower left M1. On the medical record — a Nobel Biocare implant, titanium. On the 2022 protocol — a normal molar."

Kurosawa was silent for a long time. Then he sat.

Sasaki looked at him sidelong. Said nothing.

"One mistake," Kurosawa said quietly. "It could have been the odontologist's mistake."

"It could have been," said Endo. "It also could not have been. But the odontologist is dead. You can't ask him."

"And?"

"And I have no second proof. One is not proof. Two is proof. I have the means to obtain a second."

"How."

"Exhumation."

Kurosawa closed his eyes. One second. Two.

Sasaki moved her hand toward the thermos, then drew it back.

"How long," said Kurosawa.

"For permission — up to a week. I need your signature — you are the only living blood relative. Your mother in Sendai, she is in dementia, her signature will not be accepted legally. For the procedure itself — three weeks. For the conclusion — up to a month. All told, five to six weeks."

"You are certain that you are right."

"No." Endo looked him in the eyes. "I am certain that I am not mistaken in what I don't know."

"What does that mean."

"It means," she said, "that I am not asserting the body is not Ren. I am asserting the tooth is not the right one. The difference is that from the first assertion follows horror, and from the second — work."

Kurosawa nodded slowly.

"One more thing," said Endo. "I've submitted a request for isotope analysis of the enamel. Privately, on my budget. The results will come in two weeks. That will tell me whether the person in the grave is from Hokkaido or from another region."

"That's not a Ren-test."

"That's not a Ren-test," she agreed. "That's a looking-for-who test."

Sasaki spoke for the first time.

"Endo-san." A pause. "When did you understand?"

Endo looked at her.

"In May. I was rereading the protocol for another reason — there was a case related to Nobel Biocare, we had to cross-check markings. That was when I saw that Ren's M1 had an implant and the protocol

did not. I closed the folder then and put it on the shelf. I did not open it for seven months."

"Why."

"Because," said Endo, "there was nothing to open it for. Kurosawa had grief, and I had a hypothesis. A hypothesis without a request is not a profession, it is gossip. I waited until Kurosawa himself began asking questions that required such a request. He began last week."

Kurosawa looked at her.

"How did I begin."

"You came to me on Monday," said Endo, "and asked whether I could give you a list of unsolved deaths in Hokkaido in the winter season involving a car fire. You put a question about method. That is a professional question. Not a question of grief. That was when I opened the folder."

Kurosawa looked at the table for a long moment.

"Let me sign," he said.

Endo opened the third drawer. Took out a form. Laid it before him. A pen — her own, not his — set beside it.

Kurosawa signed. Date. Name. Degree of kinship — "*younger brother*."

No reservations. No questions.

Sasaki looked out the window.

Endo took the form — she herself looked at the signature longer than she needed to — put it in the folder. The thin folder — with two names and the sheet about the isotope analysis — she moved to the lower drawer. Locked it. Put the key in the right pocket of her coat.

Kurosawa stood.

"Endo-san."

"Yes."

"How long will you still keep that folder in the lower drawer."

Endo looked at him.

"As long as necessary," she said. "Don't ask me that question again. I know what I'm doing. You know that I know."

Kurosawa nodded. Walked to the door.

Sasaki stood up, nodded to Endo, followed.

On the threshold Kurosawa stopped.

"Endo."

"Yes."

"Thank you."

"Don't thank me before there's a result."

He nodded. Went out.

The door closed.



Endo sat another five minutes.

Then stood up. Went to the shelf. Took the Nikka bottle from behind the Lipton box. Unscrewed it. Did not pour into the cup — poured into the plastic tumbler she kept for coffee — a finger's width. Drank.

Set the bottle back.

Turned off the light.

Went out into the corridor. Locked the morgue door. Turned the key twice in the lock — away from herself — and slipped it into the same pocket where the drawer key already was.

She did not go to smoke behind the morgue but on another street, a block away. Not because she did not want to meet anyone. Because she wanted to walk a little.

The snow fell evenly.

Endo thought one thing she had not told Kurosawa:

If the body in the grave was not Ren, then the Doll Maker in 2022 had had access to someone who had swapped documents inside the forensic office. Not an odontologist — a secretary or an assistant. That meant the Doll Maker had had a contact in their department back then, in 2022.

That meant — possibly — the Doll Maker had one now.

Endo finished the cigarette. Trod it out. Walked back.

She knew: when the time came, she would tell Kurosawa that too. But not before he was ready. He was not yet.



CHAPTER NINE

The Room — The Pier

The twenty-seventh of September, the night after the typhoon, the year he was thirty-nine.

The plank under his knee was wet — not the wet of rain, but that particular wet salt water leaves behind after it has gone and the salt on the boards has not yet dried.

He stood on Pier Three in Otaru harbor. He knew it because his feet knew. The right foot stood on a plank with an old nail without a head — that nail had always stuck up two millimeters — and the left held further on, past the rusted clamp he had not trusted twenty years ago. He did not remember how he had come here. But the body remembered.

It was night. Twenty-two forty-seven. He did not know how he knew. He knew.

The typhoon had gone forty minutes ago. The sky was already that sky — drunk out, black with green at the rim — and only one hanging lantern on the right flickered — with kerosene, it seemed — though there had not been kerosene lanterns on Pier Three since ninety-two. He knew. Still the lantern flickered.

He was in his white cook's shirt. The two top buttons — fastened. Sleeves to the elbow. The right cuff was dry. The left — wet along the edge.

The water under the planks knocked. It knocked the way it knocks against an empty box set in water — dryly, with an echo.

Behind the pier's post, half a step from his right foot, stood Kenta.

Kenta Ono. Not that Kenta-brother — the other one — a cousin on his mother's side. Twenty-two years old. Had put on his navy work clothes three weeks ago, when he came back from service. They hung too big on him. He was holding the clamp under the lower edge of the post with one hand. The clamp was rusted. He was just checking it.

"Eiji-san," said Kenta, "hold the motor line, I'll look at it from below."

He held it.

The wave went out.

The wave went out — not a big one — not the kind that walk for hours after a typhoon — a small one, stealthily small — and it came back sooner than it should have — and Kenta — Kenta with two hands on the rusted clamp — Kenta, who said something — Kenta — Kenta —

The hand opened.

He saw it open. Saw the fingers — they were in sea salt — and the knuckles — which the water showed him for a second when the fingers were no longer on the clamp. He stood on the planks. The planks under him rocked two degrees. His right foot did not want to step.

Kenta cried out once. Once. From under the water.

He counted — not then — but afterward, many years afterward — and it always came to the same number. Forty seconds.

Forty seconds he stood.

Then the water came again — and there was no more cry.



He stood on the planks.

He knew that this was a room. He knew it in the part of himself that still knew how to tell. He knew it because Typhoon Vicki had ended in ninety-eight, and that was why Kenta could not be standing behind the post in his navy work clothes — because Kenta was at Cape Takashima on the third day, under a sheet — and Kenta's mother — his aunt on his mother's side — had asked him, Eiji, to tell her how it had been — and he had said, *"I was behind the awning, making tea. I did not see anything."*

He knew.

Knowing did not help.

The planks under him rocked. The lantern on the right flickered. Kenta stood behind the post.

"Eiji-san," said Kenta, "hold the motor line."

He held it.

The wave went out.



He no longer counted how many times.

The voice came from behind his left shoulder.

Not loud. Not close. It entered his ear not as sound, but as warmth enters a palm from a heated kettle.

— あなたは飛べる.

You can jump.

He did not turn. He had nowhere to turn — behind his shoulder there was nothing — and still the voice was from there. He kept his eyes on the rusted clamp and on Kenta's fingers holding it — and thought, very quietly, that the fingers should not be so young. The body does not remember the fingers of forty years ago. Something else remembers them.

The wave went out.

The fingers opened.

He did not jump.

The room shook. Not with motion. With a shutter. The way an image shakes when a frame skips between two.



He stood on the planks.

Kenta held the clamp. The wave went out. The hand opened.

He set his right foot on the edge.

The pier under him rocked. The lantern on the right flickered. Far off, past the mole, where the water should have been — was not

water. Was black gravel. He saw it for a second — when the light of the hanging lantern went through the gap between planks — and saw small stones — dry, sharp — and saw that they were a meter below the planks, no more.

He knew. He knew, in the part of himself, that this was not Otaru harbor, and that under the planks there was no water. The knowledge lay in him the way the wet salt lay on the boards — tightly — and did not move.

The voice behind his left shoulder:

— *You can jump.*

He jumped.

Not into water. Into gravel. His knee struck a sharp stone — the right kneecap — the one he had spared for forty years. Pain went up his thigh into his lower back. He grabbed hold of a metal thing that was sticking out from the gap — a rod — the same one Kenta had held — and pulled.

The rod came out easily.

Along with the rod, out from under the planks came a body. Not a body. A rag doll in navy work clothes, filled with something heavy — sand, or a wet rag — the size of a person. The head — without a face. The hair — attached in a bunch. The clothes had soaked in sea salt the way real work clothes soak in real water.

He held the doll by the waist. The doll's left shoulder lay on his right shoulder — heavy — and the sea salt smelled of sea salt.

The voice behind his left shoulder said:

— 見て。あなたは彼を救った。

Look. You saved him.

He looked.

He cried.

He had not cried then, in ninety-eight — and he did not cry now — but something was in his throat — and in that small part of himself he thought — that he had saved him.



He did not know how long had passed.

He was sitting on the planks. The doll lay beside him, face — the one in which there was no face — to the sky. The lantern flickered. The sea knocked under the boards — but no longer knocked — now it was a dry sound — the knock of gravel under a load — but he did not hear it. He heard the water.

He knew he had saved him.

He knew it with the same knowing by which a man knows he has eaten breakfast — not remembering the menu, but only that fullness had been. Fullness had been. Rescue had been. Kenta was alive.

Kenta alive. Kenta on his mother's side, who worked on a launch at Otaru — the same one — who every July came to the *izakaya* Kingyo with his wife and son and ordered tofu steak.

Kenta alive.

He did not remember now whether Kenta had a wife. Did not remember whether there had been a son. But rescue had been. That was what mattered.

He turned his head.

In the corner of the planks, where the step went down to the mooring post — between two boards — stood a low black tray.

On the tray, a clay teapot the color of wet slate. One white cup, slightly crooked at the rim. A thin thread of steam rose from the spout in a patient, even line.

The tray did not belong on Pier Three in Otaru harbor. On Pier Three there had never been teapots. He knew this the way he knew the color of his mother's kitchen table.

He recognized the tray.

Not that one. But that. One like it had stood on the table in their kitchen — his and Michiko's — when Michiko still — when Michiko —

The name did not come.

The form came. A thin shoulder. A thin hand that held the teapot by the handle. Hair gathered into a knot at the nape. The taste of which tea — Asagiri — and the thin tartness — and the way she said, "*Eiji-san, the tap water today isn't right.*"

The name did not come.

He looked at the tray.

The voice behind his left shoulder said nothing. The voice knew that one could wait.

He turned away from the tray.

He looked at the doll in the navy work clothes — at its hair fastened in a bunch — at the waxy skin where waxy skin might be — and thought, in that small part of himself, that the name of the woman from the kitchen would come later.

Later meant later.



The room shook.

He stood on the planks. Kenta held the clamp. The wave went out. The hand opened.

He set his right foot on the edge.

The voice behind his left shoulder:

— *Eiji. You already know how.*

He jumped.

He pulled the doll out from under the planks. His knee no longer hurt — it knew this motion — it knew it from the first time. He laid the doll on the planks. He sat beside it. He breathed evenly.

He knew it was the twenty-seventh of September. He knew it was the night after the typhoon. He knew he had saved Kenta in ninety-eight.

He knew.

He looked into the corner.

The tray stood. The steam rose.

— *あなたは忘れたのではない。*

You did not forget.

The voice waited. The steam went up in a thin line.

— *思い出したのだ。*

You remembered.

He nodded.

He did not know to whom he was nodding.

He sat on the planks — and somewhere in him — in that dry small part into which he had for a long time put nothing —

something stirred — and fell silent.

The lantern on the right flickered.

The wave went out again.

Kenta held the clamp.

He stood up.



CHAPTER TEN

Reisen-ji

"He left it twenty years ago — I don't even remember the face now."

The road to Sounkyo went up in switchbacks, and the snow lay along the shoulder in a narrow white band — not the first November snow that would melt by noon, but already dense — the kind that gathers in the mountains a month earlier than in Sapporo.

Sasaki drove. Yukio sat on the right, holding a folder on his knees — thin — with two photocopies and one sheet of notes. The wipers went once every ten seconds.

"Two more hours," said Sasaki.

"I know."

"Did you sleep?"

"No."

She did not argue.

He looked through the side glass at the slope on the left, where the pines stood evenly at the same distance from one another — a planting, not a natural forest — and thought about how the monastery Reisen-ji had not been on the list of his case three weeks ago. Had not been on the list at all. He had no grounds to go there, except one line from Toshi across the table in the detention center: *"Find where he read."*

That was nothing. You couldn't build a warrant from that.

But Kenji had pulled three entries from the Schannel archive — under the handle *kazan-no-monogatari* — and by style they were Toshi's before the monastery. In those three entries a library was mentioned, and an abbot, and a sheaf of haiku with no name, *"left, they said, twenty years ago."*

Yukio had a photocopy of this text in the folder.

If it was the same sheaf — and if the hand in it was the same — then the Doll Maker had been at Reisen-ji. Before Toshi. Perhaps long before.

Sasaki shifted gears.

"What's the abbot's name?" she asked.

"Gensho. Seventy-two. At the monastery since ninety-three."

"Memory?"

"By the local paper — clear. Gives an interview about haiku once every two years."

Sasaki nodded. Yukio knew she had memorized it.



The monastery stood on the mountainside, small, with two *irimoya* roofs — and a third roof, over the library, was covered in fresh copper tile not yet darkened — a recent repair.

Yukio looked at it and said nothing.

A young monk in a gray robe met them in the *genkan* and showed the place for shoes. Sasaki's shoes stood straight; Yukio set his down two centimeters crooked and did not straighten them. His feet in socks found the warm floor — under the *tatami* went heating.

"Gensho-*roshi* is waiting," said the young monk.

He led them down a corridor that smelled of cedar smoke and old paper. The *shoji* doors at the end were thin — they glowed amber.

Gensho sat on a cushion by a low table, with two cups of tea already poured. He was thin, with short-cropped gray hair — hands on his knees — and looked at them with that calm that was not indifference but a practice earned across forty years of morning silence.

"Kurosawa-*keibu*," he said. "Sasaki-*junsu*."

"*Junsu-bucho*," the young monk corrected quietly.

"Forgive me," Gensho said, without the intonation of shame. "Sasaki-*junsu-bucho*. Sit."

Sasaki sat.

Yukio sat.

He took the cup in his palms — did not drink — held it the way one holds a cup to understand what clay it is made of. The clay was local, Ashibetsu — he knew by the weight. He set the cup down.

"We won't be long," he said.

"I'm in no hurry," Gensho said.

That was not politeness. That was a statement of fact.

Yukio opened the folder. Took out the photocopy of five lines of haiku and put it on the low table — text toward Gensho.

Gensho took the sheet. Held it at a distance, brought it closer, moved it away again. Read slowly.

Yukio waited.

Sasaki did not look at the sheet. She looked at Gensho's hands — at the fingers — at how the fingers lay on the sheet — and whether they would tremble if the text was familiar.

The fingers did not tremble. The fingers lay.

"A good hand," said Gensho. "Not mine."

"We know it isn't yours," said Yukio. "We want to know whether this hand ever lived in your library."

Gensho looked at him.

"In a library many hands live," he said. "Some stay. Some don't."

"This one — stayed?"

Gensho looked at the sheet again. Not longer — the same amount of time — but Yukio noticed that Sasaki tilted her head slightly. That meant she had seen something he had not.

"Perhaps," said Gensho. "Come."



The library was long and low — three rows of open cedar shelves — and at the end a separate niche with thin sheaves tied with silk cord. It smelled of dry grass and rice paste.

Gensho ran a finger along the third row from the bottom. The fingers knew the way — it was clear — they were not searching. They came to one sheaf, stopped, took it out.

Thin. The cover, light ochre *washi*, no writing. The cord, dark red, slightly faded.

Gensho laid the sheaf on the low table by the window. Untied the cord. Opened it.

Yukio leaned in.

The first line of the first page was the same as on the photocopy. The same hand. The same wide pauses between the ideograms — the same characteristic elongated right stroke in the character 冬 (*fuyu* — "winter").

He said nothing.

Sasaki beside him was silent too. She knew.

Gensho turned the page. The second — different haiku, the same hand. The third. The fourth. Twelve pages, thirty-four verses.

"Who left it?" asked Yukio. "Was there a name?"

"There was a name," said Gensho. "On the first cover, inside. It's rubbed off now. I don't remember exactly."

"Who would have rubbed it off?"

"Anyone. We don't keep the library under lock and key."

Yukio looked at him.

Gensho held the look.

"You remember him," said Yukio.

"I remember the hand."

"Remember the hand, don't remember the name."

"I remember," said Gensho, "that he lived here for several winters. Was not a novice — did not want the tonsure. He was, how would I put it, a guest. We have guests sometimes. Those who ask permission to stay a while."

Sasaki shifted a little.

"A novice," she said.

Gensho looked at her.

"You said, '*not a novice*,'" said Sasaki. "You paused before the word. Half a second."

Gensho smiled. Not with pleasure. Calmly.

"You are attentive, Sasaki-*junsa-bucho*."

"That is my work."

"Then I will answer you honestly," said Gensho. "The guest tried to be a novice. Tried for two years. Did not endure. Or endured, and understood that he did not want to. Left somewhere at the beginning of the two-thousands — perhaps two thousand one, perhaps two thousand two. I was not abbot then, but the second monk. The abbot then, the late Yoshida-*rosbi*, knew him better."

"When did Yoshida-*rosbi* die?"

"Two thousand ten."

Yukio was silent.

"Do you remember his appearance?" asked Sasaki.

"Not closely."

"Approximately."

Gensho thought.

"Medium height," he said. "Thin. Hands — I remember the hands. Long fingers. Left-handed, it seemed — wrote with the right, but ate with the left. I was not in conversation with him. He spoke little."

"The name," Yukio said again, quietly.

Gensho was silent.

Yukio did not press. He knew this kind of silence — when a person does not remember, and when a person remembers but will not say. This was the second. But it was not hostile. It was habit.

"Did he make a donation to the library?" asked Sasaki.

"Yes."

"Anything else?"

"To the roof," said Gensho. "Some seven years ago. A significant one."

"To that roof," said Sasaki — not as a question, but as a statement — "over the library."

"Yes."

"Through what company?"

Gensho looked at her for a long moment.

"I don't remember," he said. "That is the treasurer's decision."

"The treasurer at the monastery?"

"Yes. He is in Sapporo this week."

"We'll call him."

"Please."

Yukio kept his fingers on the sheaf.

"Can we take this for photographing?" he asked.

"I cannot give it to you," said Gensho. "This is the monastery's property."

"I'm not asking to give it. I'm asking permission to take pictures. Here. We brought equipment."

Gensho nodded.

"The young monk will help," he said. "I'll leave you."

He stood.

"Gensho-*rosbi*," said Yukio when he was already at the door.

Gensho turned.

"You know why we ask."

Gensho looked at him.

"I don't know," he said. "But I knew that someone would come. That knowing came to me long ago. I carried it."

"When?"

"Fifteen years ago," said Gensho, "perhaps twelve."

Yukio was silent.

"You have come late," said Gensho. "I am not angry with you."

He went out.

The *shoji* doors closed softly.



Sasaki stood over the sheaf.

"That is one hand," she said.

"One."

"With the 5channel photocopy?"

"One."

She set up the camera.

"Kurosawa-san," she said, without lifting her head. "He has not forgotten the name."

"He hasn't."

"He won't say?"

"He will tell the treasurer. The treasurer will produce some paper in which the name will not be. But there will be a date of donation. And there will be a company."

Sasaki nodded.

She took the pictures, page by page, evenly, and the lamp over the table gave off a quiet electric hum.

Yukio stood by the window. He looked at the roof — new — copper — and at how the copper lay on the rafters — and at how the repair had been done well, very well — the way repair is done by people who know how to do repair.

Yuki-Kogei, he thought.

He did not say it aloud.

He knew.



In the car, on the drive back, Sasaki turned off the radio.

"He was here before Toshi," she said.

"Nineteen years before," said Yukio. "Perhaps more."

"Then Toshi came here in two thousand twenty-one."

"Yes."

"And this guest left at the beginning of the two-thousands."

"Yes."

"Then they could not have met."

"Not here."

Sasaki looked at him.

"You think they met somewhere else."

"I think," said Yukio, "that the monastery is not a meeting place. It is a place to which the Doll Maker directed Toshi. Directed him so that Toshi would come here twenty years later and see what he had left."

"The sheaf."

"And the roof."

She kept her hands on the wheel. The road went down, toward Sounkyo, and the snow on the shoulder was grayer now.

"He recruited Toshi in advance," she said.

"He recruited Toshi the way one plants a tree. You put down a seed. You come back in twenty years."

Sasaki was silent for a long time.

"Kurosawa-san," she said at last.

"Yes."

"How many seeds are still lying?"

Yukio did not answer.

He looked through the side glass at the slope on the right, where the pines stood evenly at the same distance from one another — a planting, not a natural forest.



An hour and a half later they stopped at the parking lot beside the Asahikawa-Daisetsu service station. Sasaki went to the toilet. Yukio got out of the car — to stretch his leg — and lit a cigarette.

One cigarette per case. This was the first in this one.

He smoked slowly. The taste was foreign — he had not smoked for a year — and the throat remembered worse than the mind thought.

He dialed Kenji.

"Kurosawa-san."

"Kenji. Reisen-do Sangyo. Sounkyo. Ceramics, tea sets."

"Written down."

"Find every invoice they issued to the monastery Reisen-ji over the last ten years. Especially large ones. And especially on the roof."

"Large ones on the roof," Kenji repeated. "I'm on it."

"One more thing. Find the list of monastery guests. Not novices. Guests. Those the monastery fed and did not tonsure. Nineties, two-thousands. It'll be in the tax office — if there was a stipend donation."

"Kurosawa-san, I'll be honest. This can be found, but it's twenty hours minimum. That's a hundred and sixty thousand yen."

"Do it."

"All right."

Yukio pressed "end." Drew on the cigarette once more. Put it out in the ashtray at the parking lot — metal, with rain in it and a black film from old ash.

Sasaki came back.

"You called Kenji," she said.

"Yes."

"You didn't wait for me to sit down."

"I wanted to catch it before I forgot the abbot's exact word."

"Which."

"*The guest tried to be a novice.*"

"Yes."

"*Tried for two years.*"

Sasaki nodded.

"*Did not endure. Or endured, and understood that he did not want to.*"

"He said 'or,'" said Sasaki. "That's important. He offered two versions. He did not know which was the real one."

"Which means," said Yukio, "that he did not know because the guest did not tell him. And did not know because the late Yoshida-*rosbi*, who did know, had reason to keep silent."

"Or the guest left," said Sasaki, "and Yoshida-*rosbi* a few years later came to think it had not been '*did not endure*' but '*decided not to be*.' That's a difference."

"A difference."

Sasaki got in behind the wheel.

"Kurosawa-san," she said, "and what if this person, who spent two years trying to be a novice in the mountains, and did not become one, and disappeared for twenty years, and then came back and made the roof, is not the Doll Maker?"

"Then who?"

"Someone the Doll Maker knew. Someone who was at the monastery before the Doll Maker. And who left the sheaf in the library. And whose haiku Toshi later read on 5channel — and did not know it was the same hand — until the Doll Maker showed him."

Yukio was silent.

"You think," he said, "that the Doll Maker was not the one who went to Reisen-ji."

"I think," said Sasaki, "that he perhaps learned from the one who did. And that this is one more person who may still be alive. Or dead. But who exists on the diagram."

Yukio closed his eyes for two seconds.

The diagram was growing. He saw it in his head — and it was not a tree with one root — it was mycelium — with many points that came up to the surface.

"Kenji," he said into the emptiness. "A month's worth of work ahead."

Sasaki turned the ignition.

The car pulled out.

The road went down toward Sounkyo, and the snow on the shoulder was grayer now, and Yukio was thinking about the person with the long fingers — left-handed — who ate with the left and

wrote with the right — and about how this person, if still alive, would now be — by Gensho's reckoning — around sixty.

That was not the Doll Maker.

The Doll Maker was younger.

That was someone's teacher.



CHAPTER ELEVEN

Kenji Yamada

"Eight thousand an hour plus hardware. No name of mine in the reports."

The café on the ground floor of the Susukino business center was the kind you go into not to drink coffee but to wait something out. Always fifty percent of the seats empty. You could always sit so as to see the door.

Yukio came in twelve minutes early. Ordered a short coffee — not from desire, but from ritual — and sat in the corner from which he could see the door, the stairs, and the exit into the back corridor. He put a thin notebook in front of him — not to write in, but so that something would lie in front of him.

At sixteen zero five the door opened.

Yukio did not lift his head.

The young man who came in was thin, one meter seventy-two, in a black hoodie with the hood thrown up and a light windbreaker over it. Glasses in round black frames. On his shoulders — a rucksack. In his right hand — a carrier.

The carrier was soft, dark gray, with a mesh window. In the window, a gray cat's face.

Yukio looked at the cat once. And relaxed his shoulders slightly. Those were the first shoulders that had relaxed in him in a week.

The young man came to the table. Looked at Yukio. Looked at the second chair. Sat.

Put the carrier on the floor by the wall, in shadow, so the waitress wouldn't look at it.

"Yamada-san," said Yukio.

"Kenji."

"Yukio Kurosawa. *Keibu*."

"You are not the first to find me," said Kenji. "I saw you three days ago on Chiebukuro. You were asking about the 5channel archives and doing it too specifically — not the way someone asks who is learning, and not the way someone asks who is looking to resell. I thought: who is this. So I answered when you wrote. That you were police I understood by your second reply in the exchange. You correctly named the internal 5channel API but made one mistake — used the old field ``timestamp_client`` instead of ``edited_at``. That's how an amateur writes who has learned quickly — or a person who doesn't write scripts every day, but knows which circle to search in."

"And how did you understand I was police and not a journalist?"

"A journalist asks for it cheaper. You wrote about payment right away."

Yukio nodded.

"I apologize," he said, "for the cover. I had no other way to reach you that would not have gone through the department."

"I understand."

Kenji raised a hand. The waitress came over. He ordered coffee with no sugar. His voice was even, without intonation — not indifferent, just even.

Yukio waited for the waitress to move off.

Kenji lowered his hand into the carrier and touched the cat's ear with a finger. The cat closed its eyes. Opened them.

"Miso," said Kenji. "Last three weeks with me. He's stressed, strangers came to fix the air conditioning. I don't want to leave him."

Yukio nodded.

He saw, from the side, that Kenji was not timid. Thin, quiet — yes — but not timid. He had that particular quietness of people who work at night and count each word the way others count money.

"Kenji-san," said Yukio.

"Just Kenji."

"Kenji. I need to map a corporate network of four Japanese legal entities registered to dead directors. Each firm exists legally, pays tax, has held a bank account since two thousand eight. Through them houses are bought, electricity is paid for, furniture is ordered. I need to find how these four firms are connected to each other — and whether there is a common point between them. For example, a mailing address, a phone number, an IP, a signature, a bank."

"How much time will I have."

"A week."

"How many victims."

Yukio looked at him.

"Two are missing," he said. "One more will be missing by Friday."

Kenji nodded.

"And one girl," said Yukio, "went missing three years ago. She may still have time."

Kenji was silent. Not the silence that hides — the silence that counts.

The waitress brought the coffee. Kenji took the cup with two fingers by the rim and took one sip.

"I read about Kamishiroi," he said. "Not pompously. You did not give interviews yourself."

"I did not."

"I thought it would be either a dull story or a bare sensation. It turned out to be neither."

"I didn't come to be liked."

"I know. I came to explain why I didn't stand up and leave."

Yukio waited.

"Now for terms," said Kenji. "Eight thousand yen an hour. Hardware costs on top, with receipts."

"Good."

"No name of mine in the reports. I am '*external consultant*,' in the documents — my freelance company."

"Good."

"No meetings with the press. If journalists see me with you even once — I disappear that same evening. I won't return the money."

"I won't show you."

"One more thing."

Yukio waited.

"If at some moment," said Kenji, "I tell you I don't want to any more — you will not press. You will not appeal to the girl, to the victims, to your boss, to anything. You'll just say '*understood*' and we part."

"Understood," said Yukio.

Kenji smiled a little. Barely at all. The way a person smiles when another person has said the word at the right time — and added nothing to it.

"Then," he said, "we can begin."

"From tomorrow?"

"From today. Send me everything you have. Firms, dates, any invoices, any emails you could pull. Name of the contact person in each firm, even if that's someone long dead. I want to look at this tonight. Tomorrow at ten in the morning we meet, I'll tell you where to start."

"At the office?"

Kenji thought.

"Not at the office," he said. "First — here. I want to look at your team — that later — when I understand the work exists. I don't want to walk into a police station for no reason. I'm not one of those who

like the police."

"Neither am I," said Yukio.

Kenji looked at him for a long moment.

"You just said," he said, "something I did not expect."

"I didn't want to please you. I said what I think."

"I believe you."

Yukio nodded.

Kenji reached into the carrier, took from his pocket a pouch of dried fish, and pushed a strip through the mesh window. The cat took it.

"What happens with him tomorrow?" asked Yukio.

"I take him with me. He sits quietly."

"You don't mind," said Kenji, "cats in the office?"

"I mind many things in the office. Cats aren't on the list."

"Then we're agreed."

Kenji finished his coffee. Stood up. Took out a thin wallet, put a thousand yen on the table.

"No need," said Yukio.

"There is need. This is my coffee. When I start work, you'll pay for coffee. Today I'm not yet working."

Yukio did not argue.

Kenji lifted the carrier.

Kenji started for the door.

Yukio stayed.

He sat for a long time. The coffee in his hands was cold.

He took out his phone. Wrote to Sasaki: *"Found him. I'll introduce him tomorrow at ten."*

"Good. What kind of person."

"Calm. Cat with him."

"A cat is a good sign."

Yukio did not smile, but something in his chest unclenched by a fine half-millimeter — for the first time that week — and he put the phone screen down and stood.

Outside, a fine snow was falling. The first of November in Sapporo.

He buttoned his coat.

He knew that tomorrow at ten Kenji would come on time. Knew it the way he knew the color of his mother's kitchen table.

He walked out into the street.



The next morning at nine fifty-seven Kenji was standing by reception with the carrier and rucksack. The duty sergeant, Yoshida, raised an eyebrow — but said nothing — because Yukio had already come down and nodded.

"Yamada-san is with me."

"Consultant guest?"

"Yes."

"The cat too?"

"The cat too."

Yoshida opened the service doors.

Yukio led Kenji down the corridor to the third floor — past the poster "*Prevention of Domestic Violence*" — past the cooler with warm water — past the door with the sign "*Missing Persons Unit*" — and brought him into his office.

Sasaki was already sitting at the side desk. On the desk was an open MacBook, a cup of green tea, and a photocopy of a Hokkaido map with four black squares — the preliminary sketch of what Kenji was to turn into a proper map.

Kenji put the carrier down in the corner by the radiator. Miso yawned loudly.

Sasaki lifted her eyes. Looked at the cat for two long beats. Then at Kenji. Then at Yukio.

"Kurosawa-san," she said, "you warned me about the person. Not about the cat."

"The cat was unforeseen," said Yukio.

"He's not a problem," said Sasaki. "He's nice."

Kenji nodded.

He set his MacBook Air on the corner desk Yukio had cleared for him the evening before. Plugged in the power, the external SSD, and began opening browser tabs.

"I'll give you the starting data," said Yukio. "Each of the four firms has a corporate number. Here."

He put on Kenji's desk a sheet with four numbers, four addresses, four names of deceased directors, and dates of registration.

Kenji looked. Took a pen. Corrected the fourth digit of one number — Yukio had miscopied it from the registry.

"Thank you," said Yukio.

"It happens."

Kenji began.

The keyboard tapped evenly — not fast — evenly. Yukio stood at the window, looking at the square in front of the department, where Ogawa's service Toyota Crown stood. Ogawa was at a briefing at the prefecture today.

"Kenji," said Yukio, not turning.

"Yes."

"One more question. Not about work."

"Go ahead."

"You live alone. The cat is with you. You sleep under a weighted blanket."

Kenji stopped typing.

"How do you know."

"I saw laundry-instruction stickers on the things in the carrier yesterday. Those come with weighted blankets after washing."

Kenji was silent for a few seconds. Then smiled a little.

"Are you testing me."

"No. I'm talking with you."

"Then, honestly. Yes. Nine kilograms. Helps with the fact that I live alone and the cat doesn't weigh nine kilograms."

Sasaki at the side desk tilted her head slightly. Yukio looked at her. She said nothing. She had remembered.

"All right," said Yukio. "Let's work."

"Let's work."

Kenji started typing again.

Yukio sat down at his desk. Opened the folder. Took out the photocopy of the haiku sheaf from Reisen-ji — the one Sasaki had photographed yesterday. Put it in front of him. Took a pencil.

The first verse was about snow on the rafters of an old temple.

He did not hurry.

He knew that Kenji would work until evening, and that Sasaki would call the treasurer at ten, and that Miso would sleep in the carrier by the radiator, and that Ogawa would come back from the briefing at four, and that this would be — perhaps — the week when the work would begin to move.

Yukio held the pencil over the verse.

Miso in the carrier sighed.

The office smelled of coffee, of cedar from the photocopy, and a little of dried fish from Kenji's pocket.

Yukio did not notice when he relaxed his shoulders a second time.



CHAPTER TWELVE

The Room — The Clinic

The third of February, eleven forty in the morning, the year she was fifteen.

The fluorescent lamp over the couch gave a white light without shadow — that particular white that has two shades — the upper cold and the lower with a barely visible green — and in which skin never looks the way it is.

The room was two by three meters. The walls were white, smooth, under oil-based paint. The right wall was a cabinet with two glass doors, behind which stood metal boxes labeled in small handwriting in two rows. The left wall was a concertina screen, half folded. Directly in front of it, a narrow window with ribbed glass. Beyond the window — a light emptiness. No clouds, no line, no roof of a neighboring building. Only white.

Aoi sat on the couch.

The couch was covered with a paper sheet the color of cream ice-cream — it cracked when Aoi shifted by two millimeters. Aoi did not move. Her legs hung from the couch — she was in a white hospital gown with ties — and her feet in white socks touched the linoleum. The linoleum was cold.

She was fifteen years old. Her body knew that without her.

A metal-legged table stood to the left. On it, a metal tray. In the tray, three things: a plastic syringe in a sterile wrapper, a cotton swab, and a disposable towel with the clinic's logo. The logo was unfamiliar to her — pink, in the shape of a crescent — and she knew it was the logo of the Niigata Woman's clinic, and she knew the clinic was at Kamioshima 3-chome, and she knew she had come here on bus number seventeen, and had told her mother she was going to a school competition.

She knew.

The knowing lay in her evenly — did not burn — it was there the way a certificate lies in a folder.

The door of the room opened.

The door was not *shoji*. It was white, with a metal handle on a spring — a procedure-room door — and it opened quietly, on well-oiled hinges.

The nurse came in.

Aoi lifted her eyes.

The nurse was in a white knee-length coat, white trousers, white slip-on shoes. On the head, a white cap with a double fold. On the face, a surgical mask — white, covered nose and mouth entirely — and over the mask, large glasses in a white plastic frame, lenses

slightly tinted, of the kind given out in dental offices to keep splashes from the eyes.

Above the glasses, a narrow band of forehead — and hair, also under the cap — not a strand outside.

Aoi did not see the face.

Aoi saw a silhouette.

The silhouette was tall — a head taller than she was — and the shoulders were wide — not the wide of a woman — but those shoulders that do not fit into a woman's coat armhole the way they should. The coat was stretched on the shoulders. The seam on the right shoulder — slightly parted.

Aoi did not notice this in the first second. In the fifth she noticed it. Did not think about it.

The nurse came up to the couch.

"Nakamura Aoi-san?" said the nurse.

The voice was female, neutral — that calm, friendly voice nurses have in clinics of this type — where many come alone and everyone is afraid. The voice went through the mask — but there was something else in it too — a small, thin, almost imperceptible electric note — the kind that happens when a voice is processed — when one frequency is cut and another added.

The note was on the "s" in the word "Aoi-san." Thin. One.

Aoi heard it. Forgot it half a second later.

"Yes," said Aoi.

"You are alone?"

"Yes."

"Your mother did not come?"

"No. She doesn't know."

"All right."

The nurse sat down on a low round stool on wheels beside the couch. Took a clipboard from the tray. A pen. Wrote.

"Allow me a few questions," she said.

"Yes."

"How many weeks of pregnancy?"

"Eight."

"You are certain?"

"The test was three weeks ago. The second one a week ago."

"What did it show?"

"Two lines. Both times."

"Last period?"

"Eighth of December."

The nurse wrote.

The pen went along the paper with that particular dry sound — the one that happens when the pen is good and the paper poor.

"The child's father," said the nurse, "does he know?"

"No."

"Do you want him to know?"

"No."

"Do you want the procedure medically or surgically?"

"Medically."

"You understand that this is two doses of tablets at intervals of forty-eight hours, and that the pain may be significant?"

"I understand."

"Do you want to think about it?"

Aoi looked at her.

The voice asked what had not been asked on that day. On that day — that real third of February two thousand eleven — the nurse had not asked "*do you want to think about it.*" The nurse had simply given the tablet and watched Aoi swallow it and said "*come back in forty-eight hours.*" It was eleven forty in the morning. It was carried out. It was finished.

"You can go to Doutor by the station," said the nurse. "Order a melon soda. Sit a while. Come back in an hour, if you're ready. In a week, if you need."

Aoi was silent.

Aoi knew that on that day she had gone to Doutor after the procedure and had ordered a melon soda, and had not drunk it, and had returned to the station and taken the bus to her grandmother's, because she could not meet her mother in the evening.

The knowing lay in her.

The knowing did not move.

"I'll think," said Aoi.

"Good," said the nurse. "Do you want to say anything more?"

Aoi thought.

The word she had written that night in her notebook — and never opened that page again after — came of its own.

"Haru," she said.

"What?"

"If it were a child. The name. I already made it up."

The nurse tilted her head slightly. That gesture was not feminine. It was feminine to 80 percent — and 20 percent it was male — a light, very light preponderance of the right shoulder — the way people tilt their head who have worn a uniform for many years.

"A good name," said the nurse.

The voice said it warmly.

The warmth was not a woman's warmth.

Aoi did not notice.

"Haru," Aoi repeated. "Spring."

"Yes."

"He'll be born in spring. If I —"

She did not finish.

The nurse said nothing. The nurse put the clipboard back on the tray. Stood. Went to the door.

"I'll leave you," she said. "You can lie down. Or sit. As you wish. I'll be back in fifteen minutes."

The door closed.

Aoi sat.



The room shook.

Not with movement. With a shutter. The way an image shakes when a frame skips between two.

Aoi sat on the couch. The paper sheet crackled. The table stood to the left. The tray, the syringe in its packet, the swab, the towel with the pink crescent.

The door opened.

The nurse came in.

"Nakamura Aoi-san?" said the nurse.

The voice was female. Neutral. Friendly. The warm electric note on the "s."

"Yes," said Aoi.

"You've thought?"

Aoi thought.

"I am not going to do this," said Aoi.

The nurse tilted her head 80 and 20.

"You are certain?"

"Yes."

"You understand this is a decision for life?"

"Yes."

"You will tell your mother?"

"I will tell her."

"You will call Koji?"

"I will call him."

"You will keep the name?"

"Haru."

"Haru," said the nurse. "Beautiful."

The nurse gave her a hand. Aoi stood up. The nurse walked her to the door. The door opened. Beyond the door was the corridor of the clinic — but the corridor was not that corridor — the corridor was warm, with cream wallpaper — and at the end of the corridor Aoi's mother stood. The mother was in a black coat. The mother was smiling. The mother said: "*You did the right thing.*"



The room shook.

Aoi sat on the couch. The paper sheet crackled. The table stood to the left.

The door opened.

The nurse came in.

"Nakamura Aoi-san?" said the nurse.

"Yes," said Aoi.

"You've thought?"

Aoi knew.

Aoi knew — in the small, tiny, ever-smaller part of herself — that this was already the twenty-fourth time the door had opened. Or the forty-third. She could not count. The number scattered.

She knew that Haru was the name she had made up in a dream, and that she had given it to no one, and that there was no child — because there was no child — because —

The knowing scattered.

Haru was. Haru lived in Niigata, with grandmother, because Aoi worked in Sapporo — and Haru was fifteen — and Haru played the cello. Haru came to visit her on holidays twice a year. Haru liked

miso soup.

Haru was.

Aoi looked at the nurse.

The nurse stood there with the same silhouette. Shoulders — wide. The seam on the right shoulder — slightly parted. The surgical mask — white. The glasses — tinted.

Behind the tinted glasses, for a second Aoi saw the eyes.

One eye.

Not two. The right one reflected green from the fluorescent lamp. The left was hidden by the shadow of the frame. The right eye was dark, calm — with that calm that does not calm — and it looked at Aoi without curiosity — the way a person looks at work — at work they know how to do.

The eye did not blink.

Aoi lowered her eyes.

She lowered her eyes to the metal tray, to the syringe, to the swab, to the towel with the pink crescent — and beyond the tray — in the corner between the table and the wall — on the floor — stood a low black tray.

The tray lacquered. On it, a clay teapot the color of wet slate. One white cup, slightly crooked at the rim. A thin thread of steam.

The tray did not belong in the procedure room of the Niigata Woman's clinic. Teapots were not kept in procedure rooms.

Aoi looked at the tray.

The thin thread of steam rose evenly.

Something in Aoi — in that dry, tiny, ever-smaller part — recognized the tray.

She could not have said from where. Could not remember whose teapot. Could not name a name — neither female nor male — neither mother's nor her own.

But the tray was familiar.

Aoi cried.

Not loudly. Not at once. First one tear went from the right eye down the cheek and stopped at the corner of her mouth. Then a second. Then she breathed out — and her shoulders lifted themselves once, and dropped — and after that she cried without shoulders, quietly, with open eyes.

She did not know why.

The nurse stood in the doorway. Did not move. The one green eye behind the tinted lens watched.

The nurse said nothing.

The nurse waited — exactly twenty seconds — and turned — and went out — and closed the door.

Aoi sat on the couch and cried at the tray.

Haru was.

Haru would be.

The tray stood.

The steam rose in a thin, patient line.

The fluorescent lamp over the couch gave a white light without shadow.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

Four Firms, One Post Box

"He does not keep one address. He keeps one pocket."

Kenji brought the printout in a black plastic tube — the kind architects carry plans in — and stood the tube upright by the door of the office, the way one stands an umbrella in a *genkan*. Miso in the carrier was silent. It was ten forty-eight in the morning.

Yukio sat at his desk. Sasaki at the side desk, on the right. Endo stood in the doorway with two paper cups of coffee — did not come in — was looking to see if she could.

"Come in, Endo-san," said Yukio.

Endo came in. Set one cup in front of Yukio, the other in front of Sasaki. Kenji had his own Boss Coffee from the vending machine in the corridor — the can stood on his corner desk, still cold.

"All right," said Kenji. "Unrolling it."

He opened the tube. Drew out a sheet rolled into a tube — not an ordinary A1 but larger — a meter by a meter and a half — printed on a plotter. Unrolled it on the conference table in the middle of the room.

The table was small. The printout hung off the edges by fifteen centimeters on each side.

"Small table," said Kenji. "I knew it would be. I brought tape."

He weighted the four corners with small metal weights of the kind sold in stationery shops. The table turned out to be the dinner

table of the Kurosawa family when Kurosawa Yukio and Kurosawa Ren had sat on one side and their mother on the other — only it was in the office — and on it lay a network.

Yukio stood over the table.

Sasaki stood on the right.

Endo — on the left, holding her coffee.

Kenji stood at the foot of the table, facing the map.

"Four legal entities," he said.

He set an index finger on the four squares in the four corners of the printout.

"Upper left: Yuki-Kogei LLC. Head office, Sapporo Chuo. Restoration of traditional architecture. Director — Tanaka Hideo, died in Otaru, September two thousand eight, kidney failure. The daughters who might have inherited — two — neither knows her father was director of anything."

Yukio nodded. He had known that.

"Upper right: Kita-Michi Zaimoku KK. Ashibetsu. Trade in cedar timber. Director — Sasaoka Yoshiro, died in Ashibetsu, February two thousand eleven, heart attack. Forest. Taiga. Was a local mountain ranger for thirty-seven years."

"Forest," said Sasaki. "Taiga."

"Yes," said Kenji. "Through this firm all the construction material comes into the network. Cedar, Japanese larch, bamboo for interior partitions."

He set his finger lower.

"Lower left: Reisen-do Sangyo KK. Sounkyo. Goods for the tea ceremony. Ceramics, tableware, teapots, lacquered trays. Director — Oshima Kiko, potter, died in Sounkyo, April two thousand seven, pancreatic cancer."

Yukio put a hand on this square.

He did not look at anyone.

"Reisen-do," he said quietly.

"Yes," said Kenji.

"Reisen-ji."

"I thought about it," said Kenji. "One root. One mountain. You spoke yesterday about the monastery. I don't think the coincidence is accidental."

Sasaki looked at Yukio.

Yukio was silent. He was not yet ready to speak about this aloud in front of everyone. He took his hand off the square.

"Go on," he said.

"Lower right: Ainu-Tabi Hosho LLC. Kotan, near Lake Shikaribetsu. 'Tourism insurance.' Director — Kaizawa Takeshi, an Ainu guide, died in Kotan, August two thousand fifteen, stroke. Through this firm electricity is paid for in —" he paused, looking at the left column, "twenty-eight properties across the prefecture. Twenty-seven of them in Hokkaido, one in Yamagata."

"Twenty-eight," said Endo. "Excuse me, I was thinking five."

"Five active," said Kenji. "Twenty-three sleeping. Plus the twenty-eighth itself, sleeping, in Yamagata. I put every property on this map."

He passed a palm over the central part of the printout. There was the space of Hokkaido — the outline of the island — and on it black squares — twenty-seven — and one separate square in the lower right corner as a plus to Yamagata. Each square had a number. Each number had a thin line running to one of the four corporate squares in the corners.

There were many lines.

Very many.

Yukio looked in silence.

"This is not a network," said Kenji. "This is a system. Each property is fed from three or four firms at once. Cedar comes from Kita-Michi, ceramics from Reisen-do, electricity through Ainu-Tabi, restoration through Yuki-Kogei. No firm holds a property on its own. They are woven together so that if one is taken away — the others compensate."

"But," said Sasaki, "something holds them all."

"Holds them," said Kenji.

He set a finger in the very center of the map. There was a small yellow square.

"One postal point. A rented box at the post office Sapporo Kita 1. All four firms receive their official correspondence there. The box is paid for in cash once a year — always on the first Wednesday of April. In the last six years, on those days, the same person appears in the post office cameras — but the cameras are low quality — and the person is in a cap and mask. Height — one hundred seventy-five to one seventy-eight. Movements economical. Right-handed. Carries a bag — dark — of soft material."

"In April," said Endo, "on the first Wednesday."

"Yes."

Endo looked at Yukio.

"The next first Wednesday of April is five months away," she said.

"I know," said Yukio.

He did not intend to wait five months.

He kept looking at the center of the map. Not at the yellow square of the postal point — but at the interweaving of lines — at how it spread across the whole island — and how it held the five active houses — and how it held the twenty-three sleeping ones — and how in Yamagata, on the southern slope of Mount Zao, there stood one property completely apart, outside Hokkaido.

One outside.

Yukio looked at it.

"That is outside Hokkaido," he said. "Zao-minami. One."

"One," said Kenji. "Plus the sleeping Zao-kita. Both — Yamagata prefecture."

"So," said Yukio, "Hokkaido isn't the border."

"Not the border."

Sasaki opened a folder she was holding under her arm. Took out three thin sheets.

"Here are three," she said.

She put the first sheet in the middle of the map, over Ashibetsu.

"This is where Aoi was. Taken away five days ago."

The second sheet — on the right, over Lake Shikaribetsu.

"This is where she is now. With Sato. With Ito. Three victims in one house."

The third — to the northwest, over the island of Rebun.

"This is where Ito was. Taken earlier."

Three sheets. Three properties. Three victims in one place.

Kenji was silent.

Endo said:

"He is gathering them."

"Gathering them," said Yukio.

"That is either a breakthrough or a trap."

"A trap," said Yukio. "It is a trap. He knows that we know. He wants us to come there."

"Then we don't go," said Endo.

"We go," said Yukio.

Endo looked at him.

"But not today," said Yukio. "We go when he isn't expecting us. And we go not the way he is counting on. Kenji, how much time do you need to draw a schedule of Yamato deliveries to Kotan for the past six weeks?"

"Two days."

"Do it."

"Doing it."



Half an hour later Endo left. Kenji rolled up the printout — but left a small copy on the desk, A3 — and hung it on the office wall next to

the prefecture map. Miso in the carrier was asleep.

Yukio sat at his desk. Sasaki opposite.

"Kurosawa-san," said Sasaki.

"Yes."

"Reisen-do. Reisen-ji."

"I know."

"You saw the treasurer yesterday?"

"I haven't called yet. I'll call today."

"Kurosawa-san," said Sasaki, "the treasurer will say nothing."

"I know."

"But the firm will. Reisen-do issued an invoice for the monastery roof. That invoice will be in the monastery's bookkeeping. It cannot not be. It's the tax office."

"Yes."

"So," said Sasaki, "we give the treasurer one day. On the second — we demand the documents officially. From the prosecutor we take a warrant. Through Fujiwara."

Yukio nodded.

"Fujiwara will only issue a warrant if we show him this map."

"We'll show him."

"He'll register it in the case. It will go into the official record."

"I know."

"The Doll Maker will find out."

"He will."

Sasaki was silent.

"Kurosawa-san," she said.

"Yes."

"He already knows."

"Yes," said Yukio. "He already knows."

He looked at the small A3 copy on the wall. At the four squares in the corners. At the twenty-eight black dots on the island. At the one yellow dot at the center.

He thought about Ashibetsu, where a week ago there had been a warm teapot.

He thought about the monastery Reisen-ji, where the new copper roof had not yet darkened.

He thought about the post box at Sapporo Kita 1, about the person in cap and mask, about the fact that the person came in once a year, about the fact that they had a bag of soft material, about the fact that they were right-handed and moved economically.

He thought about the one in Yamagata, apart from the island.

He thought about Ayano — not here, not on Kenji's map — but somewhere.

Somewhere on one of the twenty-eight properties — perhaps on the twenty-ninth Kenji had not yet found — sat a girl with a thin hand and hair gathered into a knot, and drew in a notebook with the pixiv stroke Sasaki had recognized on a screen two weeks ago.

Yukio reached for the phone.

"Kenji," he said.

Kenji lifted his head.

"You said twenty-seven and one. Twenty-eight."

"Yes."

"Could there be twenty-nine?"

Kenji looked at him for a long moment.

"Kurosawa-san," he said. "There could be thirty."

Yukio nodded.

He picked up the phone. Dialed the treasurer of the monastery Reisen-ji.

The tone went.

Outside, snow was falling — fine, November, the kind that does not stay on the asphalt longer than twenty seconds — and Yukio looked through the glass at it and thought about the first Wednesday of April.

Five months.

He did not have five months.

The tone went.

The treasurer picked up on the eighth.



The treasurer of the monastery Reisen-ji was a man of about sixty, with a thin, tired voice.

"Kurosawa-*keibu*," he said. "Gensho-*rosbi* warned me."

"Thank you," said Yukio. "I will take little of your time."

"I'm listening."

"The roof over the library. The repair was done seven years ago. The donation went through the firm Reisen-do Sangyo. I need a

copy of the invoice and a copy of the payment order."

"You could get them officially through the prosecutor."

"I could. But that would take a long time. I give you a day. If in a day the documents are not on my desk, I go to the prosecutor, and that path is a different one — with searches of the monastery's bookkeeping."

The pause was long. Yukio waited.

"Kurosawa-*keibu*."

"Yes."

"I will give you the documents. But I have to say one thing."

"Go on."

"Reisen-do Sangyo is not our only benefactor. We have many. I don't know why this firm in particular."

"I am not accusing the monastery," said Yukio. "I am accusing the firm. The monastery is a victim no less than the others."

"Thank you."

"One more thing."

"Yes."

"Do you remember the monastery's guests in the nineties and two-thousands? Not novices — guests."

"Not all. I remember those who made donations. We have a book."

"I need that book. The same term — one day."

"All right," said the treasurer. "I'll send them. Kurosawa-*keibu*."

"Yes."

"Gensho-*roshi* this morning asked me to pass on one more thing. He said, '*Kurosawa-san thinks he came late. Tell him he came in time.*'"

Yukio was silent.

"You'll pass it on?" said the treasurer.

"I will."

"Good."

Yukio pressed "end." Put the phone face-down on the desk.

Sasaki was watching him.

"What did he say?"

"Gensho-*roshi* sent me a message. That I came in time."

"Is that good or bad?"

"It is," said Yukio, "what a person says when he doesn't want to say '*all right.*'"

Sasaki nodded.

Kenji at the corner desk lifted his head.

"Kurosawa-san."

"Yes."

"I checked with the banks. Reisen-do issued an invoice to the monastery in December two thousand twenty. Seven hundred forty-five thousand yen. For '*goods for the tea room.*' Not for the roof."

Yukio turned to him.

"For the tea room."

"Yes."

"But Gensho said — for the roof."

"So," said Kenji, "either Gensho didn't know about the invoice for the tea room. Or he knew and didn't name it."

"Or," said Sasaki, "Gensho is thinking of a different kind of donation. Not monetary. Material. People in monasteries sometimes speak that way. '*They gave us the roof.*' And in fact they gave the tableware."

Yukio looked at her.

"Yes."

"And that means," said Sasaki, "that Reisen-do brought into the monastery ceramics, teapots, trays. Perhaps the same lacquered tray that stands in every one of the Doll Maker's rooms."

Yukio was silent.

That was right.

That was terrifying.

That meant that the same trays — from the same batch — that Aoi sees in her Clinic and that Sato sees on his Pier — stand right now in the monastery Reisen-ji, on the shelf of the tea room, where Gensho-*rosbi* holds tea ceremonies once a month for a dozen local old people.

It meant that the Doll Maker distributed his mark not only to his victims. He distributed it to the world. He held the world on one tray.

"Kurosawa-san," said Sasaki quietly.

"Yes."

"We won't be taking the trays from the monastery."

"We won't."

"We won't be speaking about this to the press."

"We won't."

"We'll keep silent about this until —" she stopped. "Until we take him."

"Yes."

Kenji, who had been listening, was silent. He understood more than he spoke. That was his quality.

"Then," said Yukio, "we write a report for Ogawa. Short. Four firms, one postal point, twenty-eight properties, five active. Yamagata outside Hokkaido. Hypothesis: an event is being prepared at Lake Shikaribetsu. Validity of the hypothesis — a week."

"A week," said Sasaki.

"A week."

Yukio looked at the little A3 on the wall. At the four squares. At the twenty-eight dots. At the one yellow dot at the center.

He looked at the square for Reisen-do Sangyo.

Reisen-do.

Reisen-ji.

One root. One mountain. One hand in the library twenty years ago.

Yukio took a pen and on the small A3 circled the Reisen-do square with red.

"That one," he said, "is not the newest. That one is the oldest of the four. That one is the door into the past."

Kenji nodded.

Sasaki said nothing — but stood and brought Yukio a fresh coffee from the corridor — without asking — and set it on the desk.

Yukio did not thank her aloud. He nodded.

Outside, the fine November snow was falling in a thin, patient line — the same patient line — and Yukio for a second remembered the steam from the teapot on his own kitchen tray — the one on the upper shelf above the sink — and thought whether it had been bought, some long time ago, through the same Reisen-do Sangyo.

He did not remember where the tray had come from.

He set the thought in a corner. It would be for later.

Now — a week.

A week to the lake.

The first personal message

"You're looking not where I was. You're looking where I will be."

Kenji arrived at ten in the morning, in a black hoodie, a laptop in its sleeve, and a can of *Boss Coffee* in his pocket. He always came with a single can, as though the dose were a measure — not of thirst, but of the time he would stay.

"Uncle," he said, setting the bag on the corner table. "You didn't answer the mail yesterday."

"I was asleep," Kurosawa said.

"At two in the morning?"

"Asleep," he repeated, level.

Kenji glanced at him briefly — the way one glances at a computer that has begun to throw a new sort of error — and opened the laptop. The three monitors weren't set up yet; for these two weeks he'd been bringing one *ThinkPad* from home and adjusting to the office.

Sasaki sat at her desk, reading a protocol from Asahikawa. She did not lift her head.

"Coffee?" said Kurosawa.

"I've got mine," said Kenji, patting the can.

Kurosawa put the pot on. Twenty-two grams of coffee, three hundred and thirty grams of water — a motion made by the body, without thought. He had long since stopped thinking about this

ritual; thought would begin only if he broke the proportion. He didn't break it.

The coffee boiled. He poured into two cups — his own and Sasaki's — set his own on the desk, set hers by her elbow. Sasaki nodded silently, not looking up from the paper.

Kurosawa's laptop chimed quietly — the way mail chimes — each time a new message came through the service. He opened it. Three protocols, two callouts, one letter from the prefectural archive. Nothing important.

Then a second notification came. Not from the mail. From the browser he kept open in the background on the *mixi* service.

He froze for a second — not visibly to the others — and turned his head to the monitor.

mixi was a dead network. People had used it back in 2008, when Kurosawa was still in Tokyo — a junior inspector with the organized-crime division who thought at the time that *mixi* was the place they told you to go to "keep tabs on the youth milieu." He'd set up an account, written fourteen posts over three months, then forgotten.

He didn't remember the password. The mail the account had been registered to — the old Tokyo corporate address — had ceased to exist long ago.

And yet on the screen was a notification: new post on your page.

Kurosawa clicked.

The page unfolded slowly — the old *mixi* layout, thin pink borders, *Osaka* font — all as he remembered. The avatar was his own — the same one taken in 2008 in the kitchen of the Tokyo apartment, when Ren was still alive — a shot from the windowsill,

him in profile, short hair, cup in his hands, the gray Tokyo sky behind. He'd thought himself superfluous in his own photograph at the time. He didn't like himself in pictures. But he had kept this one because his brother had taken it.

Beneath the avatar — a new entry. Private. Dated today, 11:47.

One sentence:

"You're looking not where I was. You're looking where I will be."

Beneath the text — one more picture. A thumbnail. Attached as though an illustration to the post.

Kurosawa did not move for a long time. He heard Sasaki turn a page of the protocol behind him — a dry, even paper. He heard Kenji click open the tab of his can.

Then he said:

"Kenji."

His voice came out in a way that made Kenji lift his head at once.

"What."

"Come here."

Kenji came, glanced at the screen. He read for three seconds, no more.

"This is your account."

"Yes."

"You didn't post that."

"I haven't had the password in seventeen years."

"Who did."

"No one," said Kurosawa. "It's dead, this account. I registered it in Tokyo in 2008. Haven't logged in since 2009."

Kenji lowered himself onto his heels beside Kurosawa's chair — his habitual pose when reading someone else's screen — and for several seconds simply read.

"Uncle. That thumbnail. Click."

"What will it give us."

"We'll see."

Kurosawa clicked. The picture opened to the whole screen. Gray winter sky, the thin branch of a pine in the lower-left corner — and nothing else. No hint. The frame was empty the way a frame is empty when it was made deliberately about nothing.

"Download the original," said Kenji. "Not the preview. Right-click, save as."

Kurosawa saved. Kenji sat at the next desk, plugged in a cable, pulled the file to his laptop.

"Sasaki," said Kurosawa. His voice level again. "Come here."

Sasaki came, glanced over his shoulder at the post. She read for as long as Kenji had. Then she put a hand on the back of his chair — not touching his shoulder — and said:

"This is the first direct address."

"Yes."

"To you."

"Yes."

She said nothing more. He was grateful.



Kurosawa sat. Did not move. He knew how to hold the weight of such notifications — he had learned in Tokyo back in 2005, the first time in his life he had seen a threat envelope arrive at a prosecutor colleague's service address. His senior had told him then: *"Don't move for ten seconds. Then move the way you were moving before. There must be no difference."*

He counted off ten seconds.

Then, with two fingers, he opened another tab in the browser. Entered the address of the prefectural mail-server archive. A search for *"mixi"* — over the last thirty days. Nothing. Over the last seventy-two. Nothing. He closed the tab.

Kenji was silent for fourteen minutes. Kurosawa counted it off by the clock on the wall. In that time Sasaki had managed to make two calls — both on other cases — and to brew herself a second cup of green tea from the thermos.

At twelve-o-seven Kenji lifted his head.

"Uncle."

"Yes."

"The *EXIF* on this file has been rewritten. Not wiped — rewritten. Someone wanted you to read it."

"What's there."

"Coordinates. A GPS tag. Latitude, longitude. Camera model is fake — *Nikon D40*, no such model exists with that firmware. Date of the shot — today, 06:14 in the morning. Time zone — JST."

"Coordinates to where."

Kenji turned his laptop screen toward him. On the screen — a map. One point marked in red.

Kurosawa looked.

Mountains. Northeast of Sunagawa, in the foothills. The area — Ashibetsu-yama. Not touristic, not residential. A reserve where an old mountain trail begins across the ridge.

He knew this place. Not because he had been there — he hadn't. Because it was on the map Kenji had assembled earlier — the layout of *ryokan* networks across Hokkaido. One of twenty-eight points. Not a priority. Not the highest in electricity consumption. Periphery.

"It's one of the *ryokans*," said Kurosawa. "Ashibetsu."

"Yes," said Kenji. "It's the tenth point on my list."

"How long to drive."

"Three hours forty," said Kenji, without checking. "Route 452, then a mountain track. The last five kilometers — on foot or by off-roader. In winter — off-roader only."

Sasaki stood behind, listening. Kurosawa felt her shift her weight from one foot to the other.

"Sir," she said. "It could be a trap."

"Yes."

"He's drawing you out personally."

"Yes."

"*You're looking where I will be.* That's future tense. He's saying he isn't there yet."

"Or telling us he isn't," said Kurosawa.

Kenji clicked at the keyboard. Did not lift his eyes.

"Uncle. One thing. There's another comment in the metadata, hidden. Three characters."

"Which."

Kenji turned the screen.

Against the black of the *EXIF*-editor hung three ideograms:

急がない

"I am not in a hurry."

Kurosawa looked at them a long time. Kenji did not interrupt.

"What does it mean," Kenji said at last.

"It means," said Kurosawa, "that he is waiting for us, and that he can wait."

"That's bad."

"That's the worst thing he could have said."



Kurosawa went down to the canteen on the first floor — a small one, with four tables and one vending machine — bought a hot *ō-mugi* in a can from the machine, came back to the office, put the can on the desk, did not open it.

Sasaki asked:

"Sir, have you eaten today?"

"No."

"You should."

"I know."

She pulled a small packet of rice crackers from her drawer, laid it in front of him. He nodded — did not begin. The crackers lay between the keyboard and the phone for twenty minutes. He did not eat one.

Ogawa came in at one in the afternoon. Kurosawa showed him the screen — mixi, coordinates, comment. Ogawa read for a minute. Then he sat on the corner of Kurosawa's desk — the way he sat when he needed to think, not to stand — and rubbed the bridge of his nose with two fingers.

"Kurosawa," he said. "This is personal."

"I know."

"He's talking to you."

"I know."

"I have to pull you off."

"You won't."

Ogawa smiled briefly — the dry smile that meant *I know I won't, but I had to say it out loud*.

"What do you need."

"Two off-roaders. Three operatives. Sasaki with me. Kenji in the comms vehicle — not in the field. Timing — tomorrow at six in the morning."

"I'll have to inform the prosecutor."

"Inform him."

"He'll say to take *tokushu* with us."

"Tell him we're taking them," said Kurosawa. "We won't."

Ogawa looked at him for a long moment.

"Kurosawa."

"Ogawa-san."

"If it's a trap out there, I'll bury you at state expense with military honors. Don't promise my wife I won't."

"I don't promise," said Kurosawa.

Ogawa stood up, nodded briefly to Sasaki — she nodded back — and left.

Three remained in the office.

Kenji opened his second can of *Boss* — for half a day this was already a lot for him — and sat looking at his screen. Not at the mixi post. At the coordinates.

"Uncle," he said. "One question."

"Yes."

"Who restored that account for you."

"No one. It came back on its own."

"Someone reset the password. Through phone recovery. Or through a backup mail. Or someone knows your secret question."

"What was my secret question."

"Uncle," said Kenji, "I can't see. He rewrote the table in the database. That means he has access to mixi's servers, or he has access to someone who does. mixi was folded into Recruit's holding in 2019. A hole opened in 2020, publicly. Half the old accounts have been reachable through that hole to this day."

"So he just went in through the hole."

"Yes. And wrote a post from your name."

"Then," said Kurosawa, "he knew the account was mine."

"He knows a lot," said Kenji. Not as a supposition. As a fact.

Sasaki stood by the window, looking at the dense snow that was beginning beyond the glass. She did not turn.

"Sir," she said. "He was reading your page."

"What is there to read. Fourteen posts from 2008."

"He was reading your page," she repeated. "And he could also have been reading pages linked to yours. In your friends list."

Kurosawa froze.

He opened the friends list on *mixi*. Twelve names. All long-dead accounts. But the third from the top — Kurosawa Ren.

He clicked.

Ren's page loaded. The avatar — Ren in 2008, aged thirty, in a gray jacket, smiling at no one in particular. The last post — April 4, 2019, two days before Ren "disappeared." One line:

「今夜、雪。」

"Tonight — snow."

Kurosawa looked at this line a long time.

Then he asked, without turning his head:

"Kenji. Can you see whether anyone visited this page."

"Your brother's?"

"My brother's."

Kenji shifted closer, took control of the screen. He clicked for about five minutes.

"Uncle."

"Yes."

"The last visit to this page was today at six-fourteen in the morning."

"From what device."

"I can't see the device. Through *Tor*. But from the same session that posted to yours."

Kurosawa closed the laptop. Quietly, with both hands — the way one closes the lid of a chest in which something lies.

He stood up, went to the window, next to Sasaki. He looked at the same snow she was looking at.

"He's reading my brother," he said.

Sasaki did not answer.

"He's reading all of us," she said a minute later. "You knew that."

"I knew," said Kurosawa. "Now I know differently."

Kenji did not interrupt them from behind. He was clicking again — quietly, without pauses, in the rhythm from which an experienced listener could read that the keyboard did not intend to stop for a long while yet.

"Kenji."

"Yes."

"How much can you pull from the steps he took on my brother's page."

"Uncle," said Kenji, without lifting his eyes, "on the *Tor* network no steps remain. But he may have left local caches. If he was reading from a laptop — and if that laptop ever connects to an unwashed network — we'll see him."

"How long to wait."

"A week. Maybe a month. Maybe never."

"Do it."

"Doing."

Kurosawa looked at him one more second. Kenji was already looking at his screen again. Kurosawa nodded to himself and turned back to the *mixi* monitor.

Sasaki stood beside him. Did not move.

"Sir," she said quietly. "One more thing."

"Yes."

"He wrote *will be*. Not *is*. Not *was*."

"I know."

"So he is drawing you to a place he has not yet arrived at."

"Yes."

"Or wants us to work it out that way."

"Yes."

Kurosawa nodded grimly. Both readings equally weighted. Neither gave advantage. He had long since learned not to like texts from which both readings emerged equally plausible — these were texts written by someone who knew how to hold symmetry.



At six in the evening Kenji closed the laptop, dropped the can in the bin, took his bag.

"Uncle," he said at the door. "One small thing."

"Yes."

"I looked at that avatar of yours. The original. The metadata of the original has a comment too. One character. Not the one on the coordinates."

"Which."

Kenji raised his phone, showed him. On the screen — one ideogram.

兄

"Older brother."

Kurosawa looked. Then he nodded, briefly.

"Thank you, Kenji."

"Don't thank me," said Kenji. "It isn't a gift."

He went out, closing the door quietly.

Sasaki stayed. She stood by the window for a few minutes more — beside Kurosawa, who did not move — then took her jacket from the back of the chair.

"Sir."

"Yes."

"Tomorrow at six."

"Yes."

"Sleep well," she said.

He almost smiled. Didn't quite.

"You too," he said. "And, Sasaki — Nao is in Niigata today?"

Sasaki looked at him a long time. Not surprised — attentive.

"Yes," she said.

"Good."

She nodded. Didn't ask how he knew. Both knew he knew. Both silently agreed not to open that conversation now — but marked that it would come.

Sasaki nodded, went out.

Kurosawa stood at the window a long while. Snow beyond the glass fell slowly — in those large fat flakes that mean there is no wind — and each reached the sill in the rhythm that keeps only in Japanese winters, when darkness comes at exactly four o'clock.

He thought about Ren's little page. About that last post — *tonight, snow* — written two days before his brother left the apartment in Chiba on a working evening and did not return. About how Endo now said the body in the grave was not his. About how someone today at six-fourteen in the morning had visited that page. Not him. Not Endo. Not Kurosawa. A third person, who was reading his brother.

He thought about the phrase *"You're looking not where I was. You're looking where I will be."*

It was an invitation. Direct. For the first time.

But an invitation always has a second layer. He knew this. The one who sets a trap sets it so that the victim walks into it on her own feet — believing she is following her own trail.

Kurosawa opened the laptop once more. Clicked on the post — the new text on his page — and right-clicked on the picture itself. From the drop-down menu he chose *"save page as complete."* The computer rustled quietly for a few seconds, saving.

He knew that tomorrow at six in the morning they would drive to Ashibetsu-yama. He knew what they would find there. Or not

find. He knew this would be a way station, not an end.

He knew one more thing, and from this knowledge it was hardest.

He knew that he wanted to go.

Not because the Doll Maker might be there. And not because victims might be there.

But because the trail of his brother might be there.

Kurosawa closed the laptop a second time.

He stood a minute more. Then took his jacket.

Went home.

The smell of boiled rice from Ryoko's apartment reached him on the stairs. He stood on the landing a second — not ready to go into his own straight away — then nodded to the invisible neighbor behind the door and turned the key in his own lock.

On the kitchen windowsill stood two white porcelain figurines without faces. One his. The other from Toshi's hut.

He did not glance at them.

He went to the kitchen — and began to set the pot on again.

Twenty-two grams. Three hundred and thirty grams. The water boiled faster than he had reckoned; the kitchen was colder than usual, and the kettle on the burner hummed differently. He poured into one cup. Carried it to the table, set it down — did not sit, stood beside it. Looked at the steam.

Then he said aloud — quietly, into the empty room — as quietly as one speaks only to those who hear without hearing:

"Ren."

The steam from the cup rose vertically — there was no draft — and vanished in the air half a meter above the surface.

He said nothing more.

He drew the phone from the inner pocket. He wrote Sasaki one message:

"Tomorrow at six. I'm ready."

He put the phone down. Did not wait for a reply. He knew it would come in half a minute — short, one letter of confirmation. So it did.

He drank the coffee standing. Beyond the window the snow lay evenly on the sill. Two porcelain figurines without faces looked into the same emptiness — with a look they did not have.

Kurosawa finished the coffee — and only then sat down.



CHAPTER FIFTEEN

The Highway

"You came earlier than that time."

The cab smelled of diesel and something third — perhaps varnish — that hadn't smelled on any truck he had worked in for twenty-one years.

Ito sat at the wheel. Held it at ten and two — not by habit: his wrists knew it before he had time to think. The engine hummed the way an *Isuzu Giga* from 1997 hums — his old cab from the first years at *Nippon Express*. On the panel the electronic clock glowed blue: *three forty-two in the morning*.

Beyond the windshield went winter. Route 39. Kamikawa pass. The forty-third kilometer before the summit. The blizzard was thin — only the first flakes — but visibility had already dropped to fifteen meters. The wipers moved unevenly: the right one a little slower

than the left, and each time it left a thin streak on the glass.

He knew that streak.

You can hear it, said the voice.

The voice came from behind his left shoulder. Neither high nor low. Neither male nor female. He did not turn his head. He never turned.

What do you hear.

The engine.

What else.

The wipers.

What else.

The silence beneath the wipers.

Correct.

The wheel this time turned when he turned it — with that small resistance a real wheel has on the road. Earlier, for some twenty cycles, it had spun like a toy, independent of anything. In the last cycle something had changed. They had given him the wheel.

Three forty-three.

He saw her.

A figure was on the right shoulder. Walking against his direction. Shoulders lowered, dark jacket, cap pulled low.

He knew that figure. He had known it for twenty-one years.

Watanabe Kōichi. Twenty-seven years old. A hydroelectric worker, his car had broken down ten kilometers up. Walking home on foot. Always took one more step nearer the road — precisely the

one that put him into the right mirror's blind zone.

Ito pressed the brake. The truck slowed evenly. He drove past the figure at fifty. The figure did not turn its head.

Some two hundred meters on he stopped the truck on the shoulder. Turned on the hazards. Blue flashing reflected in the snow on both sides. Killed the engine.

Silence fell at once. Only the blizzard rustled thinly on the roof.

He opened the door. Wind broke in, struck his cheekbone. He threw on the old JR jacket and climbed out.

The road was wet-icy. He stepped slowly — the way a man steps whose feet once failed him at the wrong second — and walked in the reverse direction. Toward the figure.

Two hundred and forty-two steps.

The figure was still there. Standing. Not moving. The face was not visible.

He came within five meters. Stopped. Coughed. Quietly.

"Excuse me."

The figure did not answer.

"Excuse me," he said louder.

The figure did not stir.

Now he could see the jacket — dark-green, woolen, with a patch on the left elbow. Trousers spotted with fuel oil. Heavy boots, soles worn inward. This was Watanabe Kōichi's clothing. He had read the description in the newspaper in 1998 — three times. Could have listed every detail, including the size of the boots: twenty-seven.

He came within two meters.

"Watanabe-san."

The figure slowly turned its head.

A face was there. But it was not of details — of form. Oval, nose, mouth. Eyes not visible under the cap. But it was a face. He could have said one thing about it: it was not dead.

"You're going home," said Ito.

The figure nodded. Once.

"Far still."

"Eight kilometers or so."

The voice was low, calm, with the drawn Hokkaido *o* in *or so*.

"I'll give you a ride," said Ito. "To the bridge. From there it's close for you."

The figure looked at him. He felt the eyes though he could not see them.

"Thank you," said Watanabe.

They walked to the cab. Ito a little ahead — not because he was hurrying, but because he could not bear walking beside for longer. He opened the passenger door, held it. Watanabe climbed in heavily, with a short exhale.

Ito walked around the truck, sat behind the wheel. Started the engine. Pulled onto the road. The blizzard strengthened.

They drove five minutes in silence. Watanabe placed his hands on his knees. He smelled of wet wool and gasoline.

"You're local," said Watanabe quietly.

"Asahikawa."

"A ways off."

"I was in Kushiro."

"Long haul?"

"*Nippon Express*. Second year."

Watanabe nodded.

"My car broke down," he said. "Ten kilometers back. Starter went. I thought — maybe a lift."

"There are no lifts here at this hour."

"I know."

He did not say *thank you* a second time. He didn't need to.

They passed the turnaround loop — the one that had always tightened Ito's chest across all these years — and he did not notice the moment.

You came earlier than that time, said the *voice*. From behind the left shoulder.

Ito froze.

He saw — for a second — that beside him sat not Watanabe. Beside him sat a mannequin. Rag-cloth. With a cap low over the oval where the face should be. Rope-hands on knees.

He blinked. Watanabe was there again. Looking ahead. Breathing.

Ito drew a slow breath. Held it.

"I come here twenty-one years," he said quietly. "To this road. Twice a day."

Watanabe turned his head to him.

"Why."

"I don't remember."

Watanabe did not ask more. Nodded.

They drove another six kilometers. The wipers barely kept up.

On the dashboard, right under the clock, lay a small lacquered tray. The size of a palm. On the tray — a tiny clay teapot, one tiny cup. He knew this tray. Not from here. From somewhere else. He always looked at it at one and the same moment — when the clock read *three fifty-five* — and always felt that there was something to remember, but he could not.

The clock read *three fifty-five*.

He looked at the tray. Did not remember.

But today on the tray beside the tiny teapot stood two tiny cups. Not one.

He looked for several seconds.

Watanabe was not looking. Watanabe was looking ahead, at the road.

You came earlier than that time, said the voice, quieter still. One for you. One for him.

Ito nodded slowly.

He was not sure to whom.



The bridge went past. Watanabe asked to stop two hundred meters after it, by the fork.

"From here on foot. Thank you, driver."

"I'll take you to the village."

"No. That's my custom when I come back from the night shift."

Ito stopped the truck. Turned on the hazards. Watanabe opened the door — and before climbing out turned to him.

The face was visible now. Twenty-seven years old. Eyes — gray, Hokkaido. Not angry. Not sad.

"Driver," he said. "Get some sleep."

Ito nodded.

Watanabe climbed out, closed the door. Walked along the shoulder toward the fork. His steps were swallowed by the blizzard in ten seconds.

Ito sat. The engine ran quietly. The right wiper left the same thin streak.

After a minute he switched off the engine. Silence fell. He put his hands on the wheel and closed his eyes.

You came earlier than that time, the voice repeated, quite quietly. Next time you will come earlier still.

Ito sat. Did not contest.

He knew this.

Next time he will live — as he lives today. And the day before. And three nights ago. And he will always live, because you will stop. Because you can stop. Because you can.

He held the wheel.

You can.

He held the wheel.

Beyond the windshield it was dark and white. The clock read *four ten*. Beyond the window to the right — the thin branch of a pine, under which Watanabe had passed.

He wanted — with all his strength, with all his years, with all his twenty-one years — for the tray on the panel to have two cups again. Not one.

He opened his eyes.

The tray had one.

He looked a long time. Did not move.

Then, quietly, like a small child from whom a toy has been taken — he said aloud:

"Do not take it."

The *voice* said nothing.

The wipers went. The right one left a streak.

Ito waited.



He always waited here. Knew it in every cycle. Waited until the *voice* said: *begin again*. Then he would appear once more on the forty-third kilometer before the summit, at three forty-two in the morning. A figure on the shoulder.

Sometimes he drove past. Sometimes he stopped. Sometimes he struck. Sometimes he took to the village.

He had long since stopped counting the times. He knew only one thing: each time he came a little earlier.

Maybe one day he would come before Watanabe left his own house in the mountains.

Maybe one day he would pull up to Watanabe's very door, and go with him into the kitchen, and Watanabe's mother would set before them both a cup of tea from the tray.

The *voice* had said as much one cycle. Promised.

Ito believed.

He could not remember his own name. Could not remember who was the woman who sometimes came to the dream and laid a hand on his shoulder. Could not remember what his son's name had been, and whether there had been a son. Could not remember who *Issa* was, why in the breast pocket of his jacket lay a thin volume of poems.

But he could remember the name Watanabe Kōichi, and the address of his village, and the color of his jacket, and how his hand trembled on the strap of his bag as he walked alone along Route 39 at three forty-two in the morning.

It was enough.

The *voice* said: *begin again*.

Ito pressed the brake though he was stopped. Started the engine. Pulled onto the road.

The clock showed *three forty-two*.

The blizzard grew thin.

The figure on the shoulder — in the distance — emerged from the white.

Walking against his direction.

The wheel was under his hands, at ten and two.

He held it steady.

He knew he would stop.

He knew that this time he would stop ten meters closer than the last. And that the *voice* would praise him. And that on the tray there would once again be two cups, if only for a second.

That second was all he had.

That second was all he wanted.

He held the wheel.

And the blizzard began to strengthen.



CHAPTER SIXTEEN

Ashibetsu-yama, empty

"He knows that we know."

The off-roader lifted onto the last rise — the engine dropping into a lower gear, wheels slipping a centimeter — and came out onto a small plateau from which the roof of the *kominka* opened to view.

Sasaki eased off the gas.

The roof was black, steep, covered under a good forty centimeters of snow. No smoke came from the chimney. No tire tracks on the approach — apart from old ones, left perhaps a week ago and then powdered over. No people. No sound but the engine.

"Stop," said Kurosawa.

Sasaki halted the vehicle twenty meters short of the door. Killed the engine.

The silence fell at once. It was the kind mountain forest carries in itself before a winter noon: no wind, no birds, no water. Only the thin creak of a pine somewhere to the left — the pine giving notice it was alive.

Kurosawa opened the door. Climbed out slowly. His boot cut into the snow to the ankle. He stood a second — inhaled air that smelled only of pine and cold — and nodded to Sasaki.

Sasaki got out from the other side. She held her pistol in the holster, under her unbuttoned jacket. She did not draw it. She simply kept a hand close.

Behind them, twenty meters back, stood the second off-roader. Three operatives. They did not move until Kurosawa gave the sign. He did not give it.

"Sir," said Sasaki. "No tracks."

"Yes."

"None fresh at all."

"No."

They walked to the door. Kurosawa in front, Sasaki half a step behind and a little to the left — the way partners walk in the field when they do not know what waits inside.

The *kominka* was old. Wood, roofed with red tile, with a wide eave beneath which mushrooms had once been dried. The sign above the door — faded — was hard to read, but the word *yama-no-ya* (mountain house) still showed through.

The door was shut but not locked. Kurosawa pressed. It creaked. Opened.

He froze on the threshold. Did not cross.

Inside it smelled of old *tatami* — dry, cooled — and faintly, barely, of *burnt pine*. Not today's. Yesterday's, or the day before. Smoke that had had time to soak into the walls and almost air out.

And one more thing. Faintly.

Coffee.

Not the smell of a fresh brew. The smell of grounds left in the filter and forgotten — the way one leaves them in a hurry — grounds that had dried but still remembered themselves.

"You smell it," Kurosawa said quietly.

"Yes."

"It's not today."

"No. But recent."

He crossed the threshold.



The *genkan* was empty. One pair of cold white *zōri* stood to the left, evenly — the way one sets them for a guest who is to come but did not. Or — the way one leaves them behind.

Kurosawa unlaced his boots. It was an automatic movement — not from custom, but from the fact that in another's house you do not enter *shod*, even when hunting a criminal. Sasaki also took off her boots. It was not in the video-protocol; it was simply what they did.

He took the flashlight, switched it on. The beam was white, wide.

The corridor. Wooden floor. To the right — *zashiki*, to the left — kitchen, at the end — a way out into the garden. He went right.

The *zashiki* was empty. *Tatami*, low table, alcove — *tokonoma*.
In the alcove hung a scroll.

Kurosawa raised the flashlight to the scroll.

One ideogram. Large. Drawn with wet ink, recently; the paper at the edges was slightly darker where the ink had been drying. Not days ago. Two days at most. Perhaps less.

動

To move.

Kurosawa looked a long time. Sasaki stood at his shoulder, also looking.

"Sir."

"Yes."

"That's his hand."

"I know."

"He wrote this recently."

"I know."

Kurosawa nodded slowly. Lowered the flashlight.

They went to the kitchen.



He walked farther — to the kitchen. To the right of the entry a *dozō* showed through — a thin wall of clay plaster, coated by time's soot; the soot was not fresh, an old layer quietly shed with time. To the left hung a narrow shelf — dishes had once been kept on it, now empty, only two rings from old round bases.

The kitchen was small, cramped. A table, two shelf-boards, an old electric burner, an old tin kettle. In the corner — a *Melitta* filter with a wooden handle, in which lay dark dried coffee grounds. Kurosawa lifted the filter with two fingers. The grounds were dry — but not brittle. Three days, no more. He replaced the filter.

The sink — dry. No water came from the tap: Sasaki turned the handle — only one short cough in the pipe — and closed it.

The refrigerator — unplugged. Door held open a centimeter — the way one leaves it when one does not want the inside to spoil with smell. Empty.

On the kitchen windowsill stood three white porcelain figurines without faces. Not nine. Three.

Kurosawa looked at them a long time.

Sasaki said nothing.

She knew that nine was the full set. Three was a remainder.

He shifted the flashlight into his left hand. With his right, carefully — with two fingers — he took one of the figurines. It was cold, smooth, as always. On the base — a small, almost invisible stamp. He brought it closer to the light. The stamp read: 2019.

He replaced the figurine.

"Farther."



In the *hallway* — a long corridor with several doors. Kurosawa counted: one, two, three. At the end — a small one, with a padlock hasp — a storeroom. The door was ajar.

He went in.

The storeroom was small, a meter and a half by two. Shelves — floor to ceiling. On the shelves — boxes. All alike. Wooden, roughly thirty by twenty centimeters, with a thin lid on hinges.

He counted. Nine boxes.

He opened the first.

Empty. Only a scrap of soft silk on the bottom — pink, with a thin gold pattern — on which a figurine had once lain. A hollow in the silk held the shape.

The second. Empty. Hollow.

The third. Empty. Hollow.

The fourth. Empty.

The fifth. One white porcelain figurine without a face. Lay evenly in its hollow.

The sixth. One.

The seventh. One.

The eighth. Empty.

The ninth. Empty.

He counted again, aloud:

"Three here. Three in the kitchen. Together, six. Should be nine."

Sasaki stood behind him, in the storeroom doorway. She did not enter — there was no room for two.

"Sir. He took three with him."

"Yes."

"He's moving them."

"Yes."

Kurosawa closed the ninth box. Put it in place.

He stood a second more in the storeroom — held the flashlight, looked at the empty hollows. Three figurines on the kitchen he had left. Three in boxes. Three taken. Nine broken into three-three-three.

It was a move. Deliberate. He wanted them to count.

Kurosawa left the storeroom.



They went through all the rooms. Nine doors along the corridor. All empty. In the third — the *tatami* had a fresh stain, round, damp to the touch, the size of a palm; Sasaki sniffed it — no smell — and registered it on the phone. In the fifth — on the windowsill lay a pair of thin wool socks, black, rolled into a ball, men's, size twenty-seven. He did not touch. Sasaki also registered.

In the seventh — on the floor, at the center of the *tatami*, lay a single long gray hair. Kurosawa bent, looked closer. Some twenty centimeters. Straight, thick — not thin women's — with that particular sheen that hair has in a person past sixty, cared for, in soft water. He did not touch. Pointed with a finger to Sasaki. Sasaki nodded — photographed it, entered it in the protocol.

"His," she said quietly.

"May be. May be another."

"How many people cut his hair."

"One."

Kurosawa straightened. They went farther.

In the eighth — nothing.

In the ninth — on the *futon*, folded and set against the wall, lay a single sheet of paper. Thin, white, the size of a postcard. On the sheet — not a single word. Only one line in ink — short, made in one stroke — from the upper-left corner to the lower-right.

Kurosawa looked at this line a long time.

It was a diagonal. Just a diagonal.

Or it was a sign: *from here to there*. A course. A direction.

He photographed it.

Sasaki stood silently in the doorway. Then she said:

"Sir."

"Yes."

"He knows that we know."

"Yes."

"And he's telling us so."

"Yes."

"He's telling us he knows, and he doesn't care."

"Yes."

Kurosawa placed the sheet in a clear evidence bag. Left the ninth.

They walked back down the corridor. Three operatives waited in the *genkan* — they had come in — did not ask. Kurosawa said quietly:

"Perimeter. Log every room. Grounds from the filter — to analysis. Do not move the scroll. Call Endo-san to the site."

"Understood," said the senior of the group.

"Also," said Kurosawa. "The hair in the seventh. Log it separately, in its own bag. Not with the other biomaterials. It was placed — not dropped. This is not a routine sample."

"Understood."

"And one more. No smoking here. Not on the yard, not in the kitchen. He is sensitive to strangers' smells in his rooms. If he comes back — and he will not — I want him to know we didn't smoke."

"Understood."

They nodded, dispersed.

Kurosawa went out onto the threshold. Sasaki behind him.

The sky was low, gray. Snow was beginning again — thinly.

He stood on the wooden eave. Looked into the forest.

"How long," he said.

"Three, four days," said Sasaki. "By the grounds. By the smoke in the walls. By how the kettle dried out."

"He led them out."

"Yes."

"He knew we'd find the address."

"Yes."

"He gave us the address himself."

"Yes."

Kurosawa was silent a long time.

Then:

"So he wanted us to see exactly this."

"Yes."

"An empty storeroom. The scroll. The diagonal on the sheet."

"Yes."

He turned from the forest. Looked at her.

"Sasaki. We are in a game where he is giving us the moves."

"Yes, sir."

"I don't like it."

"Neither do I."

He almost smiled. Didn't quite. A smile wasn't possible now.



They drove back to Sapporo in the second vehicle. The three operatives stayed at the site, awaiting Endo and the forensics team.

Sasaki drove. Kurosawa sat on her right, looking out the window at the slopes of Ashibetsu-yama as they slowly fell behind.

"Sir."

"Yes."

"One more thing."

"Yes."

"The scroll. *To move*. That doesn't mean *I am moving*. It means — a command. Or an invitation."

Kurosawa thought.

"You're right."

"He's telling you: *move*."

"Yes."

"He wants us to move further."

"Yes."

"That means he is leading us somewhere."

"Yes."

"Not here."

"Not here."

Sasaki added a little gas. The off-roader ran smoother.

"Sir."

"Yes."

"I want to stop by Toshi's."

Kurosawa turned his head.

"Today?"

"Today. On the way. At the detention center."

"What do you want to ask him."

"I want to ask," said Sasaki, "who else knew about Ashibetsu."

Kurosawa looked at her a long time.

He knew Toshi would not answer that question. And he knew Sasaki also knew this. But she wanted to ask.

"All right," he said. "We'll stop."



At the *Sapporo Chūō* detention center they took walk-ins badly — they had no schedule for unplanned interviews — but Kurosawa had called in an hour ahead, and the duty officer, seeing the surnames, only sighed and nodded. Kurosawa and Sasaki entered a small room

with two tables and one bench at four forty-two. Toshi came in from the other side five minutes later.

Kurosawa looked at the empty bench in front of him. He kept his hands on the table — palms open, downward. It was his old habit at interrogations — to show his hands. To hide nothing. He did not notice that he was doing it now, when the one across the table was not a suspect but a witness who had once been a suspect and who might, perhaps, be a witness again.

Toshi had thinned further. Shoulders lowered. Head freshly shaved — this morning — a small nick from the razor on his cheekbone. He sat. Put his hands on the table.

Kurosawa set down the thermos. Poured water into a plastic cup. Set it between them.

They did not drink.

"Nakamura-san," said Kurosawa. "We were in Ashibetsu-yama today."

Toshi did not stir. He listened.

"He left. Three, four days before we arrived. The room dry. The storeroom empty — three figurines he left. Scroll in the tokonoma: 動."

Toshi nodded slowly.

Kurosawa waited.

Toshi said:

"He moves faster than you."

"I know."

"Because he knows where he is going."

"I know."

Sasaki leaned slightly forward. Her voice was level.

"Nakamura-san. Who knew about Ashibetsu apart from you."

Toshi turned his eyes to her. Looked a long time. Not hostile — simply.

"Sasaki-san."

"Yes."

"I did not know about Ashibetsu when he kept me there. I knew only that it was mountains and that it wasn't Kamishiroi."

"You lived there."

"I did not live there. I was there. That's different."

"Who else was there."

Toshi did not answer.

He looked into the cup of water Kurosawa had set before him. Did not drink.

"I don't know," he said at last. "I'm not one of those who keeps a notebook."

"Then who does keep the notebook."

"He has no notebook," said Toshi. "He has memory."

Sasaki did not ask again.

Kurosawa watched the two of them — Toshi sitting straight, and Sasaki not looking away.

"Nakamura-san," said Kurosawa. "He wrote to me today."

Toshi slowly — very slowly — raised his eyes to him.

"To you."

"To me."

"Through what."

"Through *mixi*. My old account."

Toshi nodded.

"And what did he write."

"You're looking not where I was. You're looking where I will be."

Toshi closed his eyes for a second. Then opened them.

"He has begun with you," he said. "Now he will not stop."

"He began long ago."

"No, inspector. Before, he spoke with you through me. Now — directly. That is different."

Kurosawa sat. Kept his palms on his knees.

"Nakamura-san," he said quietly. "I need to know something. Where he went from Ashibetsu."

Toshi did not answer at once.

He looked into the cup of water. Long.

Then he said:

"Inspector. It is not that he left Ashibetsu. Ashibetsu is what he had long since already been leaving. You arrived at an empty place because he had long moved on."

"Then where was he moving to."

"To a lake."

Kurosawa froze.

"Which."

"I will not name it for you," said Toshi. "I do not know it myself. I know only that it is — and that it is the one out of which no one comes."

He raised his eyes. For the first time in the conversation he looked Kurosawa straight in the pupils.

"Inspector. He is taking them there now. All of them. Into one room."

"How many."

"As many as there are."

Kurosawa was silent for a long time.

Then he stood. Took the thermos. Nodded to Toshi.

"Thank you," he said.

Toshi did not answer. Looked into the cup.



In the car Sasaki did not hurry to switch on the ignition. She sat a minute, hands on the wheel.

"Sir."

"Yes."

"He says — a lake."

"Yes."

"We have twenty-eight points on Kenji's map. How many are by lakes."

"I don't remember. We'll get in and check."

"Sir."

"Yes."

"One more thing."

He turned his head to her.

"He is taking them all into one room. That means," she was speaking evenly, "they will be together. For the first time. If we find the lake — we find them all at once."

"Yes."

"Or lose them all at once."

Kurosawa did not answer.

Sasaki started the ignition.

"Sir."

"Yes."

"Kenji has to be told. About the lake."

"I'll tell him from the car."

"I'll tell him."

"All right."

Sasaki took out her phone, put it on speaker, laid it on the panel. Kenji answered on the second ring, briefly — he already knew the call was coming.

"Kenji," said Sasaki. "Priority. Every point from our map within a three-kilometer radius of a lake. Every lake in Hokkaido. Ponds, reservoirs. Anything with fresh water and a shore."

"Received."

"By morning."

"Received."

He hung up without a goodbye. It was his manner — it did not annoy Sasaki. She liked people who did not waste words.

The off-roader pulled quietly from the spot. The sky over Sapporo was already dark — four forty-two in the afternoon in December — and along the road shoulders the first yellow lamps were coming on.

Kurosawa looked out the window.

He remembered the seventh room. One hair in the middle of the *tatami*. Not dropped — placed. He saw it now, as the vehicle went through the darkness of Route 452, and understood it differently: the hair lay evenly parallel to one of the seams between the mats. It was not a hair that had fallen. It was a gesture.

I was here. I placed this for you.

Kurosawa looked out the side window. The forest had lost its outlines — become black masses — and at the edge of the road the marker posts flashed briefly.

He thought about the diagonal on the sheet in the ninth room. About the scroll 動 in the *tokonoma*. About the three porcelain figurines without faces on the kitchen windowsill, set in a row.

He thought, for the first time in many days, not of Ayano. But of Ogawa, whom tomorrow he would have to tell that the lake existed.

He placed his palms on his knees. Looked forward. The wipers went evenly, both of them.

Sasaki was silent.

Beyond the window a sign flashed by — *Ashibetsu 2* — the town waking to winter evening, a few windows already yellow — and the vehicle bypassed it, going around by the highway without entering.

Kurosawa closed his eyes for ten seconds. He needed ten seconds not to think of the scroll 動, not to think of the photographs of hollows in silk, not to think of Endo, who tomorrow would come with the result of the grounds and say: *"Kurosawa-san, he brewed coffee in a Melitta with four holes. That's not a household filter. That's a restorer's. Such filters are used in workshops where furniture is restored and gourmet-grade coffee is brewed alongside. Fourteen such filters have been sold in Hokkaido in the last two years. I've passed the list to Kenji."* He knew Endo would say this — he knew it already by the form of the grounds — and he needed ten seconds not to hold it in his head together with all the rest.

He opened his eyes.

Route 452 went to Sapporo.

He did not yet know that tomorrow he would not manage to tell Ogawa.



CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

Ogawa

"He did not weep."

Ogawa left Asahikawa at two-ten in the afternoon.

He'd risen that morning earlier than needed — at five-forty — and sat half an hour in the kitchen, while his wife still slept, with a cup of coffee and *Hokkaido Shimbun*. He read the sports column. Nippon-Ham had lost in Komagazawa — not a league game, a friendly — but someone young, an understudy at third base, had turned a triple, and the column was about him. Ogawa read it twice. He liked short pieces about young men. He liked seeing the start of someone's road.

At six he dressed — gray suit, blue overcoat, the old cashmere scarf his wife had folded into his bag on Monday. He wrote his wife a note: *"Back by eight. Don't warm anything."* Fixed the note to the

fridge with a Hokkaido-maru magnet.

Left Sapporo at six-forty.

Route 39 ran southwest through a thin layer of fresh snow. The plow had come through at ten in the morning — an even dark-gray stripe down the middle, white banks to the sides — and Ogawa kept the *Toyota Crown* at forty-eight kilometers an hour, no faster. He did not like speed. Never had.

The meeting in Asahikawa was brief: the deputy chief of the city police, an old colleague from Tokyo days, apologized for not being able to come to Sapporo himself, and for half an hour they drank coffee in the duty office. Ogawa reported on the general shape of the case. The deputy nodded, listened. On the way out he asked quietly:

"Ogawa-san, Your inspector."

"Yes."

"Kurosawa."

"Yes."

"Is it hard for him now?"

"It's always hard for him," said Ogawa. "That's how he lives."

The deputy nodded once more. Shook his hand. Ogawa stepped into the piercing sun of an Asahikawa afternoon — the sky was clear, with thin gray clouds at the edges — and got into the car.

On the back seat he set two bento he'd bought at the station. One for himself, one for Sasaki. Sasaki's wife — as he sometimes joked when he loaded them with evening work — didn't warm their supper. He did. It was one of those old-fashioned gestures at which Kurosawa slightly shrugged and Sasaki accepted with a barely visible nod.

He cracked the window a centimeter — fresh air on his cheek — and drove out of the city.



Thirty minutes on he turned off Route 39 onto 452. This was a narrower mountain road — the one that led toward Ashibetsu. He was not planning to go to the *ryokan* itself — that was Kurosawa's business, he'd sort it out — but he had a small detour: in the roadside settlement, twenty kilometers before the mountain itself, lived an old forester who had given an unofficial account of an unmarked car that had twice in the past month driven up toward the *kominka*.

Kurosawa had wanted to send one of the operatives. Ogawa had said:

"No need. I'll stop by from Asahikawa myself. It's on my way."

"Ogawa-san."

"Kurosawa. I'm not going up the mountain. I'm going to the village. A village is not a ryokan. A village is a village."

Kurosawa looked at him a long time with that look of his in which Ogawa always read a little more than had been said. But he didn't object. Kurosawa never objected to his elder — if his elder was Ogawa.

Ogawa had smiled to himself then, inside. Kurosawa trusted him. That was that.

Now he was driving Route 452. Forest on both sides. Snow in the branches. The sky had darkened a little — low clouds from the northwest — but visibility was normal.

He turned on the radio. Local Asahikawa station. Weather forecast — by evening, possible blizzard in the mountains. Then an

old *enka*, a man's voice, calm, about a port and a woman. Ogawa hummed quietly along — the refrain he'd known since youth.

The clock showed *fourteen forty-seven*.

He thought briefly, without weight, that Kurosawa had looked tired today. This morning at the briefing. That *mixi* post. Ogawa had glanced at the screen over Kurosawa's shoulder, read it twice, nodded — and then spent half a day thinking about what to say. Said nothing. He knew: Kurosawa knew. Words would have been superfluous here. The best thing he could do for Kurosawa was not to keep him from thinking. And — not to show that he was worried.

He decided: on the way back tonight he'd stop by that bento shop at the station, take two. One for Sasaki. One for Kurosawa. Kurosawa would refuse. That was nothing. Ogawa would make him eat at least the rice.

He smiled to himself. Quietly.



Eight kilometers ahead slow equipment appeared. First only the yellow flash of a beacon among the white-gray landscape. Then — the outline of a tractor. A small agricultural tractor with a front dozer blade — the kind municipal services use to clear side roads. Moving slowly — maybe fifteen kilometers an hour — in its own lane.

Ogawa slowed. Assessed the distance. The oncoming lane was clear — a straight sight line of some four hundred meters — and he could pass calmly. He switched on the left indicator, glanced in the rearview mirror, checked oncoming once more.

Clear.

He pulled into the oncoming lane and began to pass.

At the second the front of his *Toyota* drew even with the tractor's cab — the tractor, sharply, without a signal, without prior braking, turned its wheel to the left.

The bucket went toward the *Toyota*.

Ogawa had two tenths of a second to react. He managed to press the brake and crank the wheel to the right. It was the right decision — from the physics of it — but the tractor was no longer going straight; it was going at a diagonal, and the oncoming vector of the bucket struck the driver-side door of the *Toyota* at fifteen kilometers plus fifty — sixty-five combined.

The *Toyota* took the strike full into the center of the driver-side door.

The A-pillar deformed inward. Glass shattered. The airbag deployed — but from the side, not the front — and not where it should have.

Ogawa lost consciousness at once. The second event — aortic rupture from blunt chest trauma — occurred in the next three seconds.

He did not manage to notice either.

The car slid off the highway onto the shoulder, fell on its right side into a snowbank. The engine ran another twenty seconds — then stopped by itself.

The radio kept playing. The man's voice was finishing the song about the port.

The tractor stopped. From the cab, slowly, a man in a blue work coverall climbed out. Around sixty, short-cropped gray, a good face.

He came to the *Toyota*. Looked through the broken glass. Saw.

He drew a phone from the chest pocket of the coverall. Dialed 110.

"Accident," he said evenly. "Route 452, somewhere on the seventh kilometer from the crossing. Car against a tractor. The driver, it seems, is not moving."

He gave his name. Katsushi Matsuda, sixty-two, municipal worker of Ashibetsu. Dictated the number of his ID. The dispatcher said a team would be there in ten minutes.

Matsuda ended the call. Stood beside Ogawa's car a few more seconds — the way a man stands who has just done everything he could. Then he went back to the tractor, took a thermos of tea from the cab, poured into the lid. Drank, standing on the shoulder, looking down the road from the Asahikawa side.

Waiting for the ambulance.



Sasaki took the call at three-eight in the afternoon. Kurosawa sat opposite, at his desk, reading someone's protocol. He watched her.

She listened for half a minute. Did not say a single word. Only — once — briefly closed her eyes. Then opened them.

"Yes," she said. "Yes. We're leaving."

She put the phone down.

Kurosawa was watching.

"Sir," said Sasaki. "Ogawa."

Kurosawa said nothing. Waited.

"Accident. Route 452. A tractor."

"Alive?"

"No."

Kurosawa looked at her a long time. Then he lowered his eyes. On the protocol in front of him was written something about a Yamato delivery schedule to Ashibetsu village for October. He read the first line again — mechanically — did not understand a word. He read it a second time.

Then he said, quietly:

"Who."

"The tractor driver. Local. Sixty-two. Sober. No record."

"Where did he swerve."

"Into the oncoming lane. Ogawa was passing him — the driver turned left. Without a signal."

Kurosawa nodded.

"We're going."

Sasaki was already standing with her jacket in her hands. She had known he would say it. She had known it when she was on the phone.

Kenji stood up from his corner desk.

"Uncle," he said. "Am I with you?"

"No," said Kurosawa. His voice level. "You stay. Keep working the Hokkaiden power-pattern. Find the lake."

"Uncle."

"Kenji. This isn't about you. We need you here."

Kenji sat down. Did not object. Did not look at the screen at once. Just sat — held his fingers on the keyboard, did not move them.

Kurosawa took his jacket.



Sasaki drove. Kurosawa sat on her right, looking out at Route 12, then at the interchange with 39, then at 452.

They were silent.

Twenty minutes short of the place the snow began. Fine, not yet a blizzard. The *Corolla's* wipers went. The right one left a thin streak — Kurosawa noticed this for a second — and forgot at once.

He thought about Ogawa. About how Ogawa had stood up at his desk in the January meeting and said aloud: "*Kurosawa is leading this series.*" About how Ogawa would step out with him on the balcony and smoke one cigarette. About his wife, whom Kurosawa had seen twice in ten years — a small woman with a long braid, smiling quietly. About his elder daughter — a teacher — whom Ogawa had once shown him on the phone, with a pride in which there was no fatherly pathos, only fact.

He was not yet thinking why this had happened today. Not yet. That would come.

Sasaki glanced at him once.

"Sir."

"Yes."

"I'm sorry."

"I know."

She said nothing more.

He said nothing either.

The blizzard began to strengthen.



The site was ten kilometers before Ashibetsu-yama. A straight stretch. Two patrol cars already stood — blue-red flashing. The ambulance too — a stretcher being unloaded from the rear doors, empty. No one was hurrying.

Kurosawa got out of the *Corolla* before Sasaki had killed the engine. Walked slowly.

The *Toyota Crown* lay on its right side in a snowbank. Driver-side door broken and crushed inward. Glass on the road. One rear number plate, bent, lay separately.

He came closer. A police officer from the local station — a junior inspector, about thirty — recognized Kurosawa from his shoulders and straightened. Wanted to salute.

"Don't," said Kurosawa. "Show me."

The junior inspector nodded. Led him to the car.

Ogawa sat in his seat. His seatbelt was fastened. His head bowed to the left, toward the broken door. Right shoulder turned forward. Eyes closed.

On his lap lay a paper — pulled from the brown envelope in which, from the look of it, he had kept the report after the meeting with the Asahikawa deputy. The paper was slightly bent, but dry — no blood on it. There was very little blood at all. Only on the left cheek — a thin line from the mouth.

Kurosawa looked for a minute.

Then he slowly bent and with the tips of his fingers fastened two buttons on Ogawa's overcoat collar — the top button was unfastened, the collar turned aside. It was a gesture Ogawa himself

would have made had he woken in the morgue and seen himself laid out. Small — but Kurosawa could not not do it.

He straightened.

Sasaki stood half a step behind.

"The tractor driver," said Kurosawa, without turning.

"Over there," said Sasaki. Quietly.

Kurosawa turned his head.

Fifteen meters off, by the tractor, stood an elderly man in a blue coverall. Held a plastic cup — most likely, tea. Talking with another officer. He didn't look shaken — not calm, but with the look of a man who has just reassigned his own life, telling the story in detail, slowly, without tears.

Kurosawa went to him.

The tractor driver saw, fell silent.

"Matsuda-san," said Kurosawa. He'd caught the name on the badge.

"Yes, sir."

"Kurosawa, prefectural police."

"Yes, sir."

Kurosawa looked him in the eyes a long time. Matsuda held the gaze. Did not look away. In his eyes was that particular emptiness that comes to people who have been told what time to get into the cab at six in the evening, and who got in — and did what they were told.

Kurosawa did not see fear in them. He also did not see a lie. He saw a third thing — and, unlike with Toshi, had no dictionary for it.

"Tell me," he said quietly, "when did you last work this road before today."

"Yesterday, sir. And the day before. And on Monday."

"Every day."

"Yes, sir. The chief gave the order. Clear the sides."

"Who is your chief?"

"The Ashibetsu municipality. Head of public works."

"His name."

"Suzuki-san."

"Thank you."

Kurosawa turned to Sasaki. He said nothing. She understood: *check Suzuki*. She nodded.

Kurosawa looked at Matsuda again.

"You're sober."

"Yes, sir."

"You haven't taken any medications today."

"No, sir."

"You see well."

"Yes, sir. Glasses only for reading."

"Did you see the car you were being passed by?"

"Sir," said Matsuda, "I didn't notice it."

Kurosawa looked at him a minute. Then nodded.

"Thank you," he said. "Someone will speak with you again."

Matsuda nodded. Lifted the cup to his lips. Swallowed. His hand did not tremble.



Kurosawa stepped away from him to the shoulder. Sasaki came up in ten seconds. Both stood above the highway, looking at Ogawa's *Toyota* lying on its right side in the snow.

"Sir."

"Yes."

"This is not an accident."

"I know."

"Matsuda is not the one who did this."

"I know."

"Matsuda is the one who was told."

"Yes."

Sasaki was silent.

"Sir."

"Yes."

"I'll check Suzuki. In two hours I'll have his biography. In six — his accounts."

"I know."

"I'll find nothing there. He'll be clean. Through him someone paid someone, who through someone else paid the one who hired Matsuda."

"I know."

Kurosawa was silent a long time.

Then he said:

"He knew Ogawa was going there."

"Yes."

"He knew it no later than this morning. We decided it last night in the office."

"Yes."

"That means we have someone in the department."

Sasaki turned her head to him.

"Toshi said as much then, at the detention center."

"I know."

"Then you thought he was bluffing."

"I know."

Kurosawa looked down at his boots, covered with fresh snow. The toe of the right was black from melted ice — he had not noticed when.

"Then I thought he was bluffing."

He did not add *now I do not think so*. It was unnecessary.



Kurosawa looked once more at the *Toyota*.

The radio in Ogawa's car was still playing — quietly, muffled through the broken glass. Now it was another song — a woman's voice, old, of the sort Ogawa would not have chosen himself, and would only have listened to because the station had chosen for him.

Kurosawa came closer. Stretched his arm through the broken side glass — carefully, around the sharp edge — and turned off the radio

with a short flick of the finger. The button clicked.

The silence became complete.

The junior inspector, standing a meter behind, bowed briefly.

"Sir," he said, "we were awaiting your instructions, or —"

"That's fine," said Kurosawa. "The radio was on. That's how it should have been. I turned it off."

The junior inspector nodded — did not understand why, but noted in himself: *"at sixteen seventeen the radio was turned off by Inspector Kurosawa by personal decision."* It would go in the protocol. Someone in Tokyo would read this someday.

Kurosawa turned back to Sasaki.

"Tell Kenji," he said. "To check Suzuki's calls over the last three days. All of them. And the calls of the number Suzuki called most often. Then — every number in contact with that number."

"A ring."

"Yes. Three levels. No further — three is enough to see who's really steering."

Sasaki nodded. Stepped five meters away — the signal was better there — and began dialing.

The ambulance took Ogawa at four-twenty. The forensics team worked until late night. Kurosawa stayed until dusk — stood by the shoulder — then Sasaki came up and said quietly:

"Sir. Let's go. They'll finish here without you."

He nodded. Went to the *Corolla*.

She opened the passenger door for him. He got in. Not at once. He stood a second before the door — a hand on the top — and

looked once more at the place where the *Toyota* had stood. It had already been towed away. Only tracks in the snowbank remained — deep, black on white.

He sat down in the car. Belted in. Sasaki closed the door behind him, walked round, sat in the driver's seat.

The engine came to life. The wipers switched on.

The right wiper left a streak.

Sasaki did not pull away at once.

Looked forward.

Kurosawa also looked — not at the road — just forward.

Beyond the windshield the blue-red pulses of the patrol cars still flashed. One of the officers was waving a flashlight, directing the occasional oncoming driver around. Someone from the forensics team was setting up a portable floodlight on a tripod — evening was falling fast, and they still had work.

Sasaki opened the glove box. Drew out a small white towel — she kept it there for all occasions — and laid it on Kurosawa's lap. Did not put it in his hand. Just laid it. Kurosawa did not move.

She took the shifter. Engaged first.

"Sir."

"Yes."

"Where."

Kurosawa thought. Did not answer at once.

"To his wife," he said at last. "She should be told in person."

"To Hiragishi."

"Yes."

Sasaki nodded. Released the clutch. The car pulled slowly from the shoulder onto the road.

Beyond the window drifted the place where the *Toyota* had stood. Tracks in the snow. One broken side mirror flashed once in the headlight of a passing car — and vanished around the curve.

Kurosawa sat. Held the towel on his lap. Did not wipe anything. He had nothing to wipe.

Kurosawa sat in Sasaki's car by the roadside. He did not cry. He did not yet know how many times this would not be the final price.



CHAPTER SEVENTEEN AND A HALF

Kingyo, at night

In the second cupboard — a shirt no one will take back.

Kingyo had been closed for two hours when Yukio unlocked the back door.

He did not switch on the overhead light. Only the lamp above the counter — the one Sato left burning all night so the fish in the round tank could see each other — and its faint reflection in the bottles on the shelf. It smelled of warm wood and the remnant of ginger broth.

Yukio did not sit in his own place.

He sat one stool over to the left — the one Ogawa took once every two months, after work, on a Thursday when his wife was at her sister's in Otaru. Ogawa would order one sake, warmed, and one small plate of *edamame*. Drank slowly. Spoke little. Sometimes he'd

take a folded newspaper from his pocket and lay it on the counter — not to read, just to lay it there — as though he needed an ordinary object on the surface.

The stool was empty.

Yukio drew a pack of *Peace* from his inner pocket. Set it on the counter. Opened it. Turned it upside-down, shook the cigarettes into a neat row — evened them with his little finger — fourteen. Sato used to do this before a long shift: he would lay out the pack and not smoke a single one, only look. He said it was his way of testing whether he would hold the night.

Yukio did not smoke a single one.

Beside the row he laid what he'd taken from the car — before the photographer from the department arrived, before all of it became evidence. The glove. The left one. Ogawa could never find the right one in his overcoat pocket in time and always put on the left first — his wife had laughed at him for it twenty-two years. The leather was dark, worn on the pad of the thumb. Inside, under the lining, warm — Yukio touched it with a finger — still warm, it seemed, though it was impossible, the car had been standing in the cold nearly an hour before they arrived.

He laid the glove palm-up. Straightened the fingers.

The clock on the wall in Kingyo ticked the way it always ticked. One of the fish knocked its nose against the glass and turned back.

Yukio sat.

He was not thinking about the case. Not thinking about Endo, not thinking about the photographs, not thinking about the fact that tomorrow was morning and he'd have to go to Ogawa's wife and say what had to be said. He looked at the row of cigarettes and at

the glove and at the empty stool, and inside him was one simple, dull, good thought: Ogawa liked coming here.

After a long time he gathered the cigarettes back into the pack. One by one, without hurry. Closed the lid. Put it in his inner pocket.

He did not take the glove. He laid it on the stool — where a palm would have been — and pushed it slightly toward the counter so it wouldn't fall.

Kingyo he did not take with him. Kingyo was Sato's, and Sato was to come back tomorrow at ten, and everything had to be in place.

Yukio switched off the lamp above the counter. In the dark the tank still glowed for another minute with its own faint light — Sato kept a night-light in the water for the fish — then his eyes adjusted, and he saw only the outlines of the bottles.

He went out through the back door. Locked it with his own key — Sato had given him a spare three years ago, after the fire in the neighboring building, "just in case," and Yukio had never once used it.

The key turned stiffly. The frost had drawn the lock tight.

Yukio stood a second more beneath the door, holding the key in the lock. Then drew it out.

He'll release him tomorrow. Not today.

Endo, the grave

"The name," she said, "you'll have to invent again."

The morgue of Sapporo Kōsei stood on the north side of the hospital block, in the shadow of the eight-story clinic, and the sun in November never reached it. Kurosawa parked in the staff lane. Nobody checked the placards there.

Endo waited on the second-floor balcony. In a coat over a sweater, in worn-out sneakers that had been hers, it seemed, since their first meeting in 2019. She held a cigarette in her palm — not raised, just held. She saw him — did not wave, only nodded.

He came up by the service stairs.

"Kurosawa."

"Endo-san."

"Let's go."

She did not ask how the funeral had gone. He did not say. They kept between them the distance of profession that neither checked more often than needed.

In the corridor it smelled of formalin and, faintly, of vending-machine coffee. The fluorescent lamps hummed on one note. Two assistants greeted them and walked past. Endo went ahead, not looking back.

She led him not into the anatomical room but to her own office — a narrow room at the end of the corridor, with a single window

that gave onto an inner courtyard with rubbish bins and one stunted oak.

On the working desk, on a clean sheet of paper, lay a folder. Old, cardboard, pasted over with two layers of tape.

"Sit."

He sat.

She closed the door. Did not go to the desk at once — stood with her back to him, arms folded, rubbed with two fingers under her left eye.

"I'm sorry about Ogawa," she said, without turning.

"I know."

"He came here on Monday. Was asking about the 1998 archive. I didn't have time to speak with him."

"I know."

She turned.

"Kurosawa, I didn't want to say this today. I wanted to wait a week. But you came yourself, and I'm not in the habit of keeping folders closed on the desk."

He was silent.

She came over, pulled out the chair on the other side and sat — not in her own place, but opposite him, as to a patient.

"We've finished the analysis," she said.

"And."

"First — one thing. The guardian of the mother in Sendai signed on Monday. I spoke with him personally, not through a notary. He said: if this isn't Ren, then where has the body gone."

Kurosawa nodded. Once.

"The body in your brother's grave — is not your brother."

He laid his palms on his knees. Kept them there. Did not look down.

"Say it more slowly."



She opened the folder. Inside was a thin stack — two protocols, three photographs, a printout of the DNA report with lines underlined. She did not give him anything to hold; she laid them out in the order convenient to her.

"First. The molar."

She placed the first photograph before him — a digital photo of a tooth, black and white, with a millimeter ruler alongside.

"This is the lower left M1 from the body exhumed from the Shukotsu-dō cemetery in Hiragishi. Twenty-eighth of October. An ordinary molar, healthy, no implant. One filling entry in the occlusal pit — old, amalgam."

"Ren did not have this tooth."

"He did not. In Ren's place stood a ceramic implant with a titanium post. Installed at the Midori clinic in Tokyo, 2018. I have a copy of the chart. I have the post-operative control X-ray. The post does not burn in a fire, Kurosawa. It can deform, but it's there. Here it isn't."

He nodded. Once.

"Second. A rib."

The second photograph. A fragment of a curved bone, with an oval outlined in chalk in the middle.

"The eighth left rib. Here — a microcalcification, long healed, consolidated. An old fracture, mended with a small bulge. Such things stay long. There is nothing like it in your brother's medical history. He never broke a rib. Not in childhood, not later — I asked Kioko-san, she confirmed."

"You spoke with my mother."

"Yes. I told her nothing. I asked about fractures as though gathering a family-history brief. She believed."

"Thank you."

"Don't thank me, Third."

She laid down the DNA printout.

"Mitochondrial. Samples from the dental pulp. Comparison with your sample and with the archival sample of your mother. No match."

"Mother."

"She's been in the bone-marrow donor registry since '99. We have her mt-profile in the archive. It is unambiguous."

"What's the margin for error."

"One in something that doesn't happen."

He was silent. A long time. Endo did not fill the silence.

The breath of a lab assistant in the corridor — through the crack under the door — showed once and then didn't.

"Who is this man," said Kurosawa.

"Unidentified. Thirty to forty-five. By enamel isotope analysis — grew up on Hokkaido, likely the northeast. Diet — fish-based. I can't give more without opening the case."

"Don't open it."

"I don't intend to. For now."

He at last looked at her hands. At the thumb of her right, on which was a small cut — fresh, two days old, already dried. She noticed his glance.

"Envelope knife," she said. "Funny."

"Not funny."

"Not funny."



She stood. Went to the window. Took an ashtray from the sill — small, ceramic, with two grooves — and set it on the edge of the desk between them, as one might who wanted her guest to do at least one ordinary thing.

He did not light one. Nor did she.

"Kurosawa."

"Yes."

"I won't tell you what this means. I know you know it better than I do."

"I know."

"But I have to say one thing."

He waited.

"If he wasn't in that car — it doesn't mean he is alive now. It means he wasn't in that car."

"I understand."

"These are different things. I've seen too many people confuse them. Don't."

"I won't."

She nodded. It was one of those nods of hers in which there was more attention than in most of her words.

He looked at the DNA printout. At the underlined line. At the date of the analysis — yesterday, 22:14. She had worked in the night.

"You slept," he said.

"No."

"How long."

"Three hours. I don't like to hold a result more than a day."

"You should sleep."

"I should do my work. So should you."

He rose. Not at once — hesitating, bracing one palm on the knee. The rib on the right, the sixth, twinged with old memory. He set his foot down more firmly, and it quieted.

"Thank you, Endo-san."

"Kurosawa."

He stopped on the threshold.

"One more thing."

She came to the door — not close, left a step and a half between them — and looked at him the way she had not looked at him in this

office before. Not as a forensic. As a person who knows that after her next sentence will come years of another's life.

"You searched for Ren for five years. Those were years with a name. Now the name doesn't work."

He was silent.

"The name," she said, "you'll have to invent again."

CHAPTER NINETEEN

Toshi goes free

Everything is paid for by someone not in the room.

The courtroom on the fourth floor of the Sapporo District Court was the smallest of the three used for motions. Twelve seats for the public. One window, closed at two turns. The heating warmed the air as though there were syrup in it — and everyone who came in from the corridor stood a few seconds on the threshold, waiting for their eyes to stop watering.

Kurosawa sat in the second public row. Alone. Sasaki had not come — she'd stayed at the department, working the new Yamato delivery block Kenji had pulled at dawn. Kenji had not come either. It was the right call.

Toshi was brought in wearing a gray sweatsuit. Not the prison blue — the lawyer had negotiated the change at the previous hearing. The cuffs were removed at the threshold; two guards remained in the doorway. Toshi walked to the defense table evenly, without wavering — the way he had always walked in Furano between the house and the well: not fast, not slow, exactly as long as needed.

He did not look toward Kurosawa.

The prosecutor — Fujiwara, in the same black suit as a month ago — opened the folder, cleared his throat, and began by the protocol. The crisp pages in his hands rustled slowly.

Kurosawa did not listen for the first four minutes. He watched the back of Toshi's head. Clean, shaved two days ago — a faint

whitish undergrowth in the hollow above the collar. Thin. In seven months of detention Toshi had lost some fourteen kilograms, as the doctor had written in the petition. From this angle it was visible how it looked.



Toshi's lawyer was new. Not the one from the start. That one had been state-assigned, sluggish, read from an iPad and mixed up dates. This one Kurosawa was seeing for the first time: about forty, slim, suit not from the prefectural catalog — Tokyo cut, thin wool — rimless glasses. Briefcase — shadowy brown leather, thin stack, well worn.

The name on the badge — Sudo, Sudo Kenji. Kurosawa noted it briefly in a notebook.

Sudo spoke evenly. He repeated three points of justification — cooperation with the investigation, voluntary surrender, deteriorating health — but did it not the way one speaks by the protocol, but the way one speaks when one knows the court will hear him out to the end. He laid before the judge three certificates, four recommendations, and one billing statement from the Hokuto clinic. Everything — properly filed. Everything — in stitched folders with the same cloth spine.

Kurosawa narrowed his eyes. Cloth spine. Bound in two places in Sapporo — one of them, an old one in the Chūō district, serving the city's leading law firms. Expensive.

The judge — a woman in her fifties, with a thin scarf at her neck — asked two clarifying questions. About internet access outside service purposes. About the possibility of a trip to Aomori for the funeral of a distant relative, which might happen in the coming months. Sudo answered clearly: internet — only from a police

workstation, under Kenji Yamada's log; travel — only with prior coordination from the prosecutor. He knew the staff's names. He knew the department's schedule.

Kurosawa slowly turned a page of the notebook.

The prosecutor objected briefly, by form. Not seriously, without insistence. His formulations, too, even, shorter than they might have been.

The judge heard him out. Recorded it. Announced the ruling: the defense motion is granted; recognizance not to depart; electronic bracelet on the lower limb; daily check-in at the Chūō-minami station; consultative work with Sapporo police under an agreed program; contact with any possible witness in the Kamishiroi case prohibited.

Toshi did not move. Only once he lowered and raised his eyelids — longer than an ordinary blink.

Kurosawa looked at his hands. Folded on his knees, relaxed. Callused palms. The calluses — old. He had not held wood for seven months, but the hands had not forgotten the shape.



In the corridor before the stairs Sudo was waiting for him.

He did not come near — he stood by the fire hydrant, back to the window — but nodded to Kurosawa the way one nods to a person with whom one has a brief business exchange.

Kurosawa came over.

"Sudo-sensei."

"Kurosawa-keibu."

"Who hired you."

Sudo smiled — briefly, without offense.

"You know I can't answer that question."

"I know. I'm asking anyway."

"The client is a legal entity financing a rehabilitation program for former Zen novices who have found themselves in difficult circumstances. It's in my materials."

"I read them. In your materials — the name 'Reisen-dō Sangyō.'"

"Yes."

"That's the restoration of temple interiors. Hokkaido, Tokyo. Four branches."

"Correct."

"You know who else this firm finances."

Sudo adjusted the temple of his glasses. Calmly.

"Kurosawa-keibu. I know that you know. I know that you know that I know. It doesn't change my work. My client has the right to pay for the defense of its ward. In all the documents — cleaner than most corporate cases that pass through this corridor."

"I don't doubt it."

"Don't. Good day."

Sudo nodded, took his briefcase, walked to the elevator. He went unhurriedly.

Kurosawa stood a second. Looked at the glass of the fire hydrant. Saw his own reflection in it — slightly bent — and saw that the right brow, with the old scar, stood a little higher than the left. It had been standing so for several weeks now. Only now had he noticed.

He looked away.



Toshi came out through the service exit — not the main one. Kurosawa waited for him in his car in the side lot, heater on. Toshi recognized the car, came over, stopped by the passenger side.

Kurosawa opened it from inside.

Toshi sat. Cautiously — as though the car were a stranger not only to him but to his body after seven months of a cell. He belted in. Placed his palms on his knees.

"Where to," said Kurosawa.

"Wherever you take me."

"Your studio on Kita-nine."

"Yes."

"Your lawyer has already brought your things there."

"I know."

"Did he tell you?"

"No."

"Then how do you know?"

Toshi looked out the window. Did not answer at once.

"Because otherwise he wouldn't be that lawyer."

Kurosawa pulled the car out of the lot. The warmed engine hummed evenly. Snow fell in a fine grain — not from yesterday's cloud, but from a new, thinner one — and beyond the windshield filled the emptiness of the intersection.

They drove three blocks in silence.

"Toshi."

"Yes."

"I would have taken you into the department as a consultant regardless."

"I know."

"But Fujiwara signed faster than I thought."

"I know."

"You understand why."

"I understand."

"Then say it yourself."

Toshi turned his head to him. For the first time in the conversation — directly.

"Because it's convenient to him too," he said. "Me on the outside is easier for him to find if he wants to find. And me on the outside is easier for you to show to others if you want to show. Everyone who needed it got theirs."

"And you."

"I got the way out."

"And what will you do with it."

Toshi looked ahead a long time. In the light of oncoming headlights his profile seemed unfamiliar — not Toshi from the hut in Furano, but someone from the road, picked up on the highway.

"I'll do what I did."

"That's not an answer."

"I know."

Kurosawa did not press. He knew the rules. Toshi's answer came once per meeting; he had given it today with that one "got the way out." No more.

They came up to the right building — a five-story *manshon* with a steel-sheathed entry. Kurosawa stopped the car. Toshi slowly unbuckled.

"Toshi."

"Yes."

"We leave the day after tomorrow. North. Shiribetsu."

"I know."

"You come with us."

"Yes."

"It's not an offer."

"Not an offer."

Toshi opened the door. Did not get out at once — held the handle.

"Kurosawa."

"Yes."

"I won't go to the other side of the lake with you."

"I didn't ask."

"I know."

He got out. A thin figure in a gray sweatsuit under the entry-lamp. Did not look back. Did not wave. Opened the door with a key, went in, and through the glass Kurosawa watched him climb to the second landing — holding the rail with his left hand — and

vanish.

Kurosawa sat another minute with the engine on. He looked at the entry. At the yellow rectangle of the lamp. At the fine snow that fell into that light and vanished before reaching the asphalt.

He dialed Sasaki.

"Kurosawa."

"Dropped him off."

"How is he."

"Thin."

"Understood."

"Sasaki."

"Yes."

"Sudo. The lawyer."

"Pulled him on the registry while you were still in the corridor. Tokyo, partner at 'Sudo-Yamaguchi-Mori.' Clients — three religious foundations, four construction, one pharmaceutical. Reisen-dō on the list the last five years. Funds flow through a sub-account for the 'rehabilitation program for former novices.' Legally — clean."

"Legally."

"Legally."

He was silent.

"Kurosawa-san."

"Yes."

"He's playing chess with us through him."

"I know."

"You took the piece that was handed to you."

"I know."

"That's nothing. We know it's his. We move on."

"We move on."

He hung up. Pulled the car out of the yard. Onto the ring road.

Streetlamps stood sparser than downtown. Snow from the second cloud had now settled to a steady fall, and in the light of each lamp it fell at the same angle — as though someone had set one light source on the whole district and did not wish to change it.

Kurosawa drove home. Not home — to the department.



CHAPTER TWENTY

Hokkaido, snow, 2022

I think I have someone who listens to me differently.

Hokkaido, winter, five years ago.

Ren set the meeting in a small *kissaten* on the second floor of Otaru Station. Not in the café on the first — the tourists sat there — but in the old one, with wooden paneling and a menu that hadn't been changed since the nineties. Kurosawa had flown in that morning from Tokyo on a matter that wasn't a matter: a second-order witness in a fraud case he was tangentially attached to. He had two hours before his return flight. Ren had proposed it — himself — and Kurosawa had been surprised, because Ren rarely asked for meetings on a working weekday.

He came up the stairs at ten-forty.

Ren sat by the window, back to the door. He had hung his coat on the chair back — dark blue, right elbow worn through — and was himself in a beige sweater Kurosawa remembered from their last winter in the parental home, some ten years ago. Ren's hair had gone grayer — not like Yukio, who had grayed evenly at both temples, but in patches — and one such lock stood above his right ear like a brushstroke someone had forgotten to wipe away.

Ren turned when he heard the step. Smiled quickly. Stood.

"Yukio."

"Ren."

They did not embrace. They never embraced. They nodded to one another — the way brothers nod who have four years between them and one shared memory of the night their father first failed to return — and sat.

The waitress was alone, elderly, hair lacquered into immobility. She brought water in glass tumblers. She did not ask — she knew Ren took a pot of coffee with milk, and the guest would decide for himself. Kurosawa asked for black.

Beyond the window — Otaru, snow-covered, with steam from the fish stalls below rising to the sill and vanishing.

"How are things," said Kurosawa.

"Quiet."

"Quiet is good."

"Quiet is what is."

Ren always answered that way. Kurosawa forgot it every visit and began with the same phrase. Every time got the same back.



They spoke first about Ayano. She was fourteen. She'd just started her second year of middle school, chosen the drawing club instead of tennis — and Ren was pleased and not pleased at once, in that particular way a single father is pleased that a child is quiet, and not pleased that the child is quiet — and could not say it. Kurosawa listened. Did not hurry.

"Does she show you her work?" he asked.

"She shows me."

"Good?"

"I don't know. She draws small things. Corners of rooms. Tables. Once — a coat sleeve on a chair. I don't know if that's good. I only see that she looks at such things more attentively than I do."

"That's already something."

"Yes."

Ren fell silent for a moment. Stirred the coffee. The spoon knocked the side of the cup once.

"Yukio."

"Yes."

"I've recently started going to one meeting."

"Where."

"Not exactly a club. Not a group. It's a person."

Kurosawa did not immediately understand which.

"A therapist?"

"No." Ren smiled at the corner of his mouth. "I don't think so. He doesn't call himself that."

"Then what."

Ren looked out the window. At the steam. At a woman's figure below, carrying a box with something long, wrapped in paper, and vanishing into a side street.

"I don't know how to explain. He's like — an interlocutor. He listens. Doesn't propose. Doesn't give advice. Doesn't assign homework."

"How much does it cost."

"He offers it free."

Kurosawa slowly set the cup down.

"Ren."

"I know what you're about to say."

"That's not the point."

"That too."

"Who is he."

"An acquaintance of an acquaintance. I don't want to explain how we met — because you'll be asking questions until evening, and I won't give you answers to all of them. He's — quiet. He lives far away. I go to him once every two months, on a Sunday. One hour."

"What do you tell him."

"What happens."

"About Ayano?"

"About everything."

Kurosawa was silent.

He had many questions. He had professional questions — about addresses, about registries, about prior records — and he had brotherly questions — why not me — and he had one question with which the rest began and ended: is this man well.

He asked none of them.

He knew how to speak with a witness. He did not know how to speak with a brother who had just laid on the table between them something that was not quite a complaint and not quite a trust, but something third, for which Kurosawa had no name.

"Are you happy at these meetings?" he said at last.

Ren thought. Looked into the cup.

"Not 'happy.' That's not the word. I think I have someone who listens to me differently."

"Differently — how."

Ren raised his eyes.

"Not like you. You listen the way you put questions. He listens the way one stands by the door and holds it open."

Kurosawa nodded. Said nothing.

He'd thought at the time that it was an offense. He wasn't offended — such things did not work as offenses between them — but he'd thought about it aloud in the night, flying back to Tokyo, and forgotten by morning. He remembered that Ren had said something about doors. He didn't remember what.

He would forget also what Ren said next.



"Yukio."

"Yes."

"If ever — I don't know why — I don't pick up the phone for two weeks running — don't worry right away."

"Why might that happen."

"I don't know. Just — don't worry right away."

"Ayano."

"Ayano I'll leave with the neighbor. Mizuki, from the flat below. She has the key. She's kind. She knows whom to call, if anything."

"Are you going somewhere?"

"No. I'm only saying — just in case. You know that these last six months my heart has been giving me small warnings. Aunt Kioko had the same."

"Have you been to a doctor?"

"I have. They say it's stress. They say cut down the work. I'm cutting down."

"How many hours a week."

"Fifty-five, now forty."

"That isn't forty."

"That's approaching forty."

They smiled at one another briefly. Very briefly.

Kurosawa took these words about "two weeks" the way one takes another's superstitious wishes — with polite seriousness and without weight. He was forty-one, his brother forty-five, both full of blood and alive, and Kurosawa did not live in a world in which men at forty-five vanished.

"All right," he said. "I won't worry right away."

"Thank you."

Later, even later, this moment with "thank you" Kurosawa would play out aloud for five years. First as a lapse of hearing. Then as a lapse of attention. Then as a lapse of love itself.



They walked out of the station together. Ren was going to the parking lot — he'd parked in back — Kurosawa was going to the express bus to Chitose.

At the crossing they stopped.

"See you at New Year," said Kurosawa.

"For sure."

"Give my love to Ayano."

"I will."

Ren for a second seemed as though he wanted to add something. He stood, looked past Kurosawa's shoulder — not at him — at something behind him, or at nothing. Then he shrugged his right shoulder.

"Well."

"Well."

They did not embrace.

Ren turned, went to the parking lot. Kurosawa went to the bus.

Having walked ten steps, Kurosawa looked back. Not because he felt something — he felt nothing then — but because at the traffic light he had to wait, and the head movement was simple. He saw Ren's back, in the coat with the worn elbow, in the gray lock above

the right ear. He saw Ren slow beside an old man with a cart and patiently go around him along the curb.

It was the last thing he saw.

Two weeks later Ren did not pick up the phone.

Three — Kurosawa began to worry.

Four — the call came from the Asahikawa police: Ren's car, off the highway into snow, burned down to the frame. Inside — a body, identified by the teeth. Formal examination. Formal conclusion. Formal funeral a week later, at which Kurosawa stood beside his uncle and listened to the priest and could not recall anything from that morning in Otaru except one phrase — "heart giving warnings" — and one more, which he never recalled as a phrase, only as an intonation, as something about doors.

He did not recall it on the ninth day. Nor on the fortieth. Nor on the anniversary.

He would recall it now, on the night after Endo would set before him the DNA report with the non-matching mitochondrial.

He would sit in the kitchen. Brew coffee in the pot — twenty-two grams, three hundred and thirty grams of water — and drink it standing at the window. And between two sips the phrase would surface on its own from beneath the gray years, clearer than when it had been spoken.

I think I have someone who listens to me differently.

The night in Sapporo would hold its shape. Kurosawa would set the cup on the windowsill and not wipe it.

The road to Shiribetsu

In a car of four people — the fifth is always the one not named.

The minibus was brought out of the department's service bay at four in the morning. A Toyota *HiAce*, steel-gray, with chains on all four wheels and two spare cans beneath the floor of the rear row. Sasaki checked tire pressures by flashlight, crouched down; the vapor of her breath rose briefly over her shoulder and vanished in the blue light beneath the bay lamp.

Kurosawa stood by the open rear doors. Counting silently — thermos, first-aid kit, winter blankets, two coils of rope, flashlights, spare batteries for the radios, Kenji's laptop in the yellow waterproof bag. Kenji stood beside him, hands in the pockets of his hoodie, not reaching for the vape. He kept a distance.

Toshi came up in a taxi at four-ten. Got out without a bag — only one strap over the shoulder, a thin backpack in which, it seemed, were two jumpers, two pairs of socks, and a tin of tea. The electronic bracelet under the trouser cuff made a thin thickening. He went to the minibus, stopped a meter from Kenji. Kenji stepped back half a pace.

"Good morning," said Toshi.

"Morning," said Sasaki, without rising from the wheel.

Kenji said nothing. Kurosawa looked at him.

"Kenji."

"Morning."

Kurosawa seated them briefly. He and Sasaki — up front; Sasaki at the wheel (Kurosawa bore long stretches badly, everyone knew), Kurosawa in the passenger seat. Kenji and Toshi — on the middle row, backs to the doors. The rear row — free, for bags and for anywhere anyone had to be moved if he became unwell.

Kenji lingered at the minibus door two seconds longer than needed. Then he got in, sat by the window, on the left. Toshi got in after him, sat on the right, leaving half a meter between them. Did not lean against the door.

Sasaki closed the rear. Walked around the vehicle. Sat behind the wheel. Belted in. Turned the key. The warmed engine hummed evenly.

"We move," she said.

Kurosawa nodded.



Sapporo at four-forty was empty. The Eneos station at the exit still burned in the black air with a yellow lamp, but no attendant was visible — sitting in the booth somewhere, warming up. The chains rumbled softly on the asphalt. In forty minutes they came out onto Route 274, heading southeast, toward Taiki and beyond, over the pass, into the Tokachi mountains.

The sky began to gray at half past five.

The first two hours they drove in silence. Kenji switched on his laptop on his lap, tapped quietly at the keyboard — Kurosawa saw from the mirror how his pale face was reflected in the screen — then closed it. He took out an apple vape from his pocket, spun it in his fingers, did not draw. Put it away.

Toshi did not shift his pose the whole time.

Kurosawa looked in the rearview mirror once. Toshi sat straight — not leaning into the seat — and stared into the back of the driver's headrest, as though at some point in it. Not out the window. Not at Kenji. At the point.

Sasaki saw this too. She said nothing.



Past the Hidaka pass the road grew narrower and the snow thicker. The chains left asphalt for compressed pack. The speed dropped to forty. Kenji coughed — a dry cough — pressed a fist to his mouth, endured, asked for water.

Kurosawa passed a bottle back over his shoulder.

Kenji drank, holding the bottle in both hands. A long time. Lowered it.

"Kenji-san," said Toshi quietly, without turning his head.

"Yes."

"Breathe through your nose. The bus is long. Do it three times — inhale four counts, hold four, exhale seven. Don't count more."

Kenji did not answer. Kurosawa looked in the mirror. Saw Kenji glance briefly at Toshi from the side, and after a pause nod. He began to breathe.

In a minute he evened out.

Kurosawa turned back to the road.

"Thank you," Kenji said. Quietly.

"You're welcome," said Toshi. As quietly.

Sasaki glanced at Kurosawa. Kurosawa at Sasaki. Not a word.



They stopped at a small lot by a closed village shop — about the middle of the road — to change drivers, refill the thermos with boiling water from a carried thermos-kettle, and take both bodies from the middle row out of the minibus for ten minutes while Sasaki checked the chains again.

Kenji stepped out first. Stood, stretched his shoulders, inhaled the cold air through his nose, exhaled briefly. Took out the vape. Drew.

Toshi stepped out slowly, holding the door frame. Stretched — a short movement of both hands over his head — and lowered them. Did not move on. Stood by the front fender, looked at the slope beyond the lot: snow, black trunks, mist behind the trees.

Kurosawa got out last. Came over to Sasaki.

"How is she."

"The chains on the rear loosened by half a turn. Tightened them."

"Three more hours."

"Three and a half. With lunch — four."

"We don't eat here."

"Not here."

He nodded. Turned to Toshi. Toshi did not move.

Kurosawa came and stood alongside him. Not close — a meter.

"Toshi."

"Yes."

"You've been down this road."

"Once."

"When."

"Twenty twenty-three. Summer."

"With whom."

Toshi turned his head. Looked at Kurosawa. Did not answer at once.

"Not with whom. Where."

"Where."

"To the village of Kotan. To Nabesawa Sae. I was sent with the photograph of a haiku. She received me. I stayed the night, left in the morning."

"Who sent you."

"You know who."

Kurosawa nodded. Looked again at the mist behind the trees.

"Does she remember you."

"I think so."

"That complicates it."

"I don't think so."

"Why."

"Because your visit and my visit will become to her two different visits. She's older. She knows how."

Kurosawa looked at him from the side. Toshi stood straight, thin, in the gray sweatsuit, with the shaved head, in the winter morning light that made his face ten years older. He did not take his eyes off the mist.

"Toshi."

"Yes."

"You understand that someone is waiting behind that lake in case you get further than you should."

"I understand."

"You won't get through."

"I won't."

"That isn't a question."

"Not a question."

Kurosawa turned back to the bus.



Sasaki took the wheel for the second shift. Kurosawa glanced once more in the rearview mirror when the bus pulled off — and saw Toshi already inside, again in the same pose: back not leaning, gaze on a point on the driver's headrest. Sasaki did not see this. Kurosawa did not say.

They drove another hour.

Then Sasaki, not looking at him, said:

"Kurosawa-san."

"Yes."

"Endo."

"I know."

"You haven't spoken to the team yet."

"No."

"You will."

"I will."

"When."

"Not today."

She nodded. He looked in the mirror. Kenji was tapping the keys again. Toshi was looking at the same point.

"Kurosawa-san," said Sasaki, quieter still.

"Yes."

"If the body in the grave — is not him — then he is either alive or killed later. Yes?"

"Yes."

"Both options mean that between us and the one we're chasing — there is not only Toshi and not only Ayano. There is also your brother. Or the memory of him."

"I know."

"I won't tell you 'hold on.'"

"Don't."

"I don't."

She shifted the gear. The engine whined briefly on the climb, then evened out. The mists in the valley below lay in layers — the lower one white, the upper one dun — and in the breaks between them was visible the black water of one of the Tokachi tributaries.

"Sasaki."

"Yes."

"Thank you."

"For what."

"For not saying it."

She squeezed the wheel a little tighter. One second.

"You're welcome."



They ate at a roadside *kaiten-soba* before the village of Shikaoi. Three bowls of hot soba with daikon, one portion without buckwheat — Toshi said his stomach after the detention center wouldn't take cold buckwheat, asked only for broth with thin slivers of yellow radish. The proprietress — a woman past sixty, in a blue kitchen apron — brought a bowl without comment. Toshi bowed to her a little deeper than needed. She noticed. Did not show that she noticed.

Kenji ate his portion quickly. Kurosawa watched him — and saw that a little color came back into Kenji's cheeks — and thought that it mattered to him, that they were eating together at one table; that this was, perhaps, the first joint meal in the team in eight months, since he had joined — and it would need to be repeated in Sapporo when they got back.

If four of them got back.

He pushed the thought aside. Did not hold it.

Sasaki paid with the department card. The proprietress printed the receipt, folded it carefully, put it into a paper envelope with an advertisement for her own place — and, handing it to Kurosawa, said quietly:

"Careful past Shikaoi. The road to Shiribetsu after the fifth turn — black ice under fresh snow. That's how it was yesterday for my son-in-law."

"Thank you."

"You're welcome."

They went out. In the time they'd eaten the snow had fallen thicker again. The minibus was white on the roof; Kurosawa passed a palm over the windshield, scraped a curve with his sleeve. Kenji cleaned the sides.

"Who drives on," said Sasaki.

"I do," said Kurosawa. "The last stretch."

"Then I'll listen to the road."

"Listen."

He sat behind the wheel. Belted in. Turned the key. The engine hummed evenly, as it had at four in the morning in the bay.

He looked in the rearview mirror. Kenji and Toshi sat in the same poses. Kenji — by the window, hands over the laptop, gaze on the white road beyond the glass. Toshi — straight, on the point on the back of Kurosawa's headrest.

Kurosawa for a moment met Toshi's gaze in the mirror.

Toshi briefly lowered and raised his eyelids. The same as in the courtroom.

Kurosawa looked away.

They pulled onto the highway. The village of Kotan was still an hour and forty minutes to the northeast, past three passes. Beyond the window, evenly, without wind, the snow fell — the sort of snow that in Hokkaido in winter falls without beginning and without end, and to a person in a vehicle it begins to seem that it is she who is standing still, and the snow is moving toward her in a single white sheet.

Kurosawa held the wheel with both hands. The right brow, with the old scar, stood a little higher than the left. He knew this now.

He thought about Ren, briefly, and pushed the thought aside too, because on this curve one had to watch for the ice.

The chains rumbled evenly on the pack.



CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO

Nine doors

Three behind the doors. One — behind the paper.

Lake Shikaribetsu lay under the morning light like something that had learned not to move. The ice on it was not white but of that dark glass through which one sees the next layer of ice and, deeper still, a third — there, where the water had forgotten how to be water. The cedars on the southern bank stood in a row, motionless, with the Hokkaidan attitude in which old things stand together when there is nothing left between them to talk about.

The road from the village of Kotan to the ryokan — four kilometers of gravel. The minibus they left half a kilometer short, among the trunks. Kenji slung the waterproof bag with the laptop over his shoulder. Sasaki checked the magazine once, slid it back, patted the holster with her palm — not to make sure, but because

that was what she always did when it was time for the hand to know where things were. Toshi got out last. Stood at the minibus door, glanced toward the lake, then toward the house. Did not walk on.

"From here — it's you, inspector."

Kurosawa nodded. He did not ask again. He already knew the answer: *I don't want to forget more than I remember*. Toshi had said it back in Kotan, in the light of the elder Nabesawa Sae's lamp, and Kurosawa had set it away in the part of memory from which he did not burn.

He laid on the stump at the gate the *ikubasui* tag Nabesawa had given. Wooden, darkened on one side — the one that remembers the place. Not for the house. For the one who one day returns to the house and does not find it.

The gate was ajar. The yard — empty. The snow lay in an even layer without tracks, save for a single trail from the back porch — narrow, like a person who knew where to step so his print would not be seen at once.

"Kenji — here, at the genkan. Keep the link. Sasaki — the back slope, then down, into the cellar. Do not come up here without a signal. I take the corridor."

Kenji nodded, pressed the bag with his shoulder.

Sasaki did not nod. She looked at him for half a second — that look of hers that made him hesitate a small hesitation each time he was to go first — and set off to the right, into the snow, around the corner.

Kurosawa slid the ryokan door open with his shoulder by one palm's width.

The house did not answer.



The *genkan* smelled of old damp cedar and tea. The earthen floor beneath the feet was dry at the steps and damp at the threshold. The shoe shelves — empty. On a wooden peg to the left — one felt jacket, dark, a man's, one size smaller than his own. He did not touch it.

Kenji sank onto his heels at the entrance, opened the laptop, connected the cord to a small battery. The screen lit his face from below.

"Kurosawa-san, link's up. I'm not going farther."

"Don't."

Kurosawa took off his boots, set them against the wall toes to the exit, took two steps onto the tatami.

The *zashiki* lay before him in the gray pre-dawn light. Seven tatami. A low table — not at the center, shifted to the far wall. The *tokonoma* alcove — with a scroll bearing one wide inked ideogram:

待

"*Wait.*" He recognized the hand — the same that had hung in Kamishiroi — the same by which the Doll Maker held his objects under control. The vase beneath the scroll — with water, poured today. Empty.

He walked to the kitchen.

The kettle stood on the stove. Metal, plain. He set a palm against its side — hot. Above the spout held a thin stream of steam. Ten minutes. Maybe less. On the thin cherry cutting board — the same batch — a crumb of dry tea at the edge. The magnetic rail empty. The knives had gone somewhere.

In the corner of the kitchen, on a low stand, stood a tray. Black lacquer, corners rubbed. On the tray — a white cup with a thin crack in the base, a clay teapot the color of wet slate. Steam was rising.

He did not touch either.

From the radio in his pocket came a rustle.

"Kurosawa-san," Sasaki, quietly. "Back entrance open. I'm inside, found the cellar. Going down."

"Watch your step."

"Yes."



He slid the partition into the right corridor.

He recognized it not with his eyes — with his body. Thirteen meters of dark cedar. Amber of *washi* lamps at knee height, set every three steps. Nine *shōji* doors along the right wall. The left — bare.

He set off.

The tatami muted the step. The rib — that old one, from Noboribetsu — was silent this moment. He did not hurry. He knew what was behind the doors. He knew whom he was looking for. He wanted to find what he found, not what he would force by his haste.

He stopped at the first.

The room was empty. Not the way it is when a person has just gone out. The way it is when a room has not been activated. Fresh tatami. Empty corner. A lacquered tray with a teapot — yes, contrary to logic, stood here too — but the teapot was cold, the cup dry, and no tea was in the teapot. A prop without a show.

He closed the door.



The second door.

He slid it open slowly.

The room was a clinic cubicle. White walls, a fluorescent lamp under the ceiling — flickering once every four seconds with the lazy uneven tremor a lamp has just before it gives up. A gurney with paper covering. A folding screen. A small table with a metal tray.

On the gurney sat a woman.

Thin, in a white hospital gown, feet bare. Chestnut hair to the shoulders, cut evenly, without styling. Glasses in a thin frame — not hers, someone else's, with the look a person has who is used to wearing her own pair for five years. Fingers rested on her knees, backs of hands up.

She raised her eyes to him.

Calm. Not sleepy. The kind with which people look who have long been waiting for someone to come in — and had somewhat stopped counting when.

"Nakamura-san," he said quietly. "Aoi. I'm Kurosawa, from Sapporo."

She tilted her head half a finger to one side.

"Where is Haru?"

He did not answer at once. He knew this name from the file — from a private *mixi* entry of 2011, from one word in a diary margin. Haru. The name that had not been. The name the Doll Maker had put in her head in place of a child that had not been.

"At home," he said. "Waiting."

He knew he was lying. He knew he would remember this lie all the coming days. He said it evenly, because otherwise he could not have said it.

Aoi closed her eyes for a second. Then opened them.

"Thank you."

He extended a hand — not grasping, only placing a palm alongside. She placed her elbow in his palm. Stood. Came with him into the corridor.

He sat her by the far solid wall, in the corner between the ninth door and the blind wall.

"Stay here. Don't move."

She nodded.



The third door.

He slid it open more slowly than the second.

The room smelled of sea salt and wet wood. Walls dark, without detail. The floor — actual decking of wet boards, slightly tilted. One wall lantern to the right, imitation kerosene. In a corner — a heap of dry kelp. The sound of a wave came from a hidden audio system, quietly, from the direction of the decking.

At the center of the decking stood a rag figure — a mannequin in navy work clothes, hands gripping a metal rod that came up through a slit in the boards.

At the edge of the decking sat an elderly man. Squat, hunched, with a bald crown. A white cook's shirt, buttoned at the throat by two buttons. His right leg tucked under, like a man who is used to carrying his weight on the right. Right cuff — with a thin white scar

from an old cut. He was smoking *Peace* — without a filter. Deep draws. The smoke hung in the room in an even layer.

He did not turn to the doors at once.

He kept looking at the mannequin. At the rod.

"Kenta?" he said.

The voice — low, with that dry aftertone in the exhalation that stays in the chest when a man has worked fifty years by the open fire of a small kitchen.

Kurosawa did not answer at once.

He took a step onto the decking. The boards under his feet gave two degrees — the Doll Maker's cradle. He placed a palm on the decking to hold himself, then took it away.

"Sato-san. It's me."

Sato slowly turned his head.

He recognized him not at once. A second — his face was neutral, then — the empty face with which a man searches memory for the shelf where he once placed this thing. Then — he found it.

"Kurosawa-keibu," said Sato quietly. "You are late."

He did not look at him in reproach. He said it as a regular guest would say: *you're late, the counter's been wiped, I'll find you something.*

Kurosawa held out his hand. Sato looked at it a long time. Then he laid his callused palm on it — not to grip, but to touch. Then he stood himself, slowly, with the caution people use who rise after a long shift behind a counter.

He did not look at the mannequin when he went out.

Kurosawa seated him beside Aoi — at one meter — so they did not touch.



The fourth door.

He slid it — and inside the room something was humming. An engine. Wipers. Low vibration — of a platform.

An *Isuzu* truck cab stood on a low platform. The windshield looked into an LED panel with a looped video of a winter pass. The wipers went. The seat vibrated at low frequencies.

In the cab sat a man. Stocky, broad shoulders, short graying hair, in a JR Hokkaido bomber jacket. A thin scar along the right cheekbone. One hand on the wheel. The other on the gear lever.

He did not look at Kurosawa.

Kurosawa came to the open cab door.

"Ito-san."

Ito turned his head — not fast, like a man torn from the road for a second who knows the road will not drive itself until he looks back at it.

"I didn't hit you, inspector."

The voice calm, precise. A plain assertion.

"I know," said Kurosawa. "Come."

Ito looked at the LED panel another long second. Then he reached with his right hand to the dash, took from the magnetic mount a small lacquered miniature tray with the tiny teapot and one cup — and placed it in the breast pocket of his jacket.

"I'll take this. If I may."

"You may."

He climbed down from the cab himself. His feet knew how to descend from height.

Kurosawa led him into the corridor. Sat him beside Sato. Three at the blind wall. No one looked at anyone.

He stopped one step from them. Placed a palm on the shōji board. Three sat behind his back and did not move — Sato in a white cook's shirt, Aoi with her silence, Ito with the trace of the wheel on his palms. Three living people with other days inside them. He did not know where to take them after this.

He took the palm from the board.



From the radio came a rustle.

"Kurosawa-san," Sasaki, quieter still. "I found it."

"What."

"A thin notebook. Leather cover. Dates. Codes. Listen: P-3, C-5, H-1... and W-2."

He froze in the middle of the corridor.

"Repeat it."

"W-2. And a list of ryokans. And notes of resettlements. I'm photographing."

"Keep it on you. Do not let it out of your hands."

Something drummed somewhere in his temples. W. *Wood, two*. The Doll Maker gives a code by type of room. In the forest, the second. Ayano.

He made his feet go on.



The fifth door — empty. Fresh tatami. Empty corner.

The sixth door — dust in the corners. Months, perhaps a year.

The seventh door.

He slid it — and for a second hesitated.

The room was half assembled. In the corners stood cardboard boxes — three — neatly closed, twine-tied. Against the wall lay a rolled thin mattress. On the low table lay one book with a bookmark at the middle.

In one of the boxes, the nearest to the door — the box unsealed — the sleeve of something small showed. He bent. Dark blue. He opened the lid.

Inside was a folded child's backpack. Small, school-sized, dark blue, with a short orange trim. On the front pocket — a rectangular fabric badge. Through the badge someone had stitched a new patch — white — and on the new patch a new name was to have been embroidered. It was not. Or was, and had been scoured off with some abrasive cloth to the ground where only hints of two or three vertical lines remained.

Nothing was legible.

He stood over the box one second longer than he should have.

He had seen this before.

Kamishiroi. The seventh door. The same backpack — not the same, but the same — with the same stitched patch, with the same scoured name. The Doll Maker had known Kurosawa would come here. The Doll Maker had known Kurosawa would recognize.

The Doll Maker had signed.

He lowered the lid. Did not touch the book. Went out, closed the door.



The eighth — empty, clean, with the faintly sweet smell of dried grass that new tatami has. Ready to receive.

The ninth.

He slid it slowly.

The room almost empty. Only — on the futon, at the center, neatly folded and laid — one object. A woman's scarf. Silk. Light-gray.

Folded in three.

The same scarf.

He did not enter. He stood on the threshold. Looked at the scarf.

Did not take it. The Doll Maker wanted him to take it. The Doll Maker wanted him to put it once again in the pocket over his heart. The Doll Maker wanted the repetition.

Kurosawa closed the door.

Nine. Three living. Three he had taken. One box with a backpack. One scarf. Three empty. One lamp under the ceiling flickering once every four seconds.

He went back to the far wall.

Aoi sat. Sato sat. Ito sat. No one looked at anyone.

"Kenji," he said into the radio. "Ambulance. Three. Careful with them."

"Three minutes."

He set off back along the corridor — to the zashiki — to the kitchen — to Sasaki — to the cellar — to the way by which the Doll Maker had gone out.

He got halfway.



Behind the fourth door — the one with the *Isuzu* cab — a board creaked.

Not inside the cab. Behind it. In the narrow gap between the room wall and the back of the cab — there, where in such a room there should have been a solid wall — something had shifted by five grams.

Kurosawa froze.

Then — quietly, of the sort that comes when a person holds his breath — through the shōji paper reached him a man's voice. Not from inside the room. From that side. From behind the back wall. From a passage that should not have been in the ryokan's plan.

"Kurosawa-keibu."

Quietly. Level. Without pressure. The kind of voice with which a man who has been waiting for someone a long time says: *you have come* — and adds nothing more.

Kurosawa slowly turned his head toward the door.

He did not draw the pistol. Both his hands remained free.

"Yes," he said.

Pause. The voice on the other side was in no hurry.

"You've come closer."

Kurosawa took a step. Another. Stopped at the paper — at a meter — as close as one could stand without touching. On the paper he saw a shadow — not a silhouette, but a hint of something standing on the other side — a shoulder, perhaps — the top of a head — a figure lower than himself and a little broader in the shoulders than he had expected. The shoulders did not move.

"You won't find him today," said the voice.

"I know."

"You won't find him tomorrow."

"I know."

"But you're going the right way."

Toshi had said the same, word for word — in the *zashiki* of Kamishiroi, three years ago. Kurosawa heard it and did not show that he had heard.

He allowed himself one even breath.

"I know who you were at Reisen-ji."

On the other side — not at once. The silence was not empty; it was the kind of silence with which a person wipes his palms on his trousers and considers whether to smile.

"Ah."

One sound — not a word, but an exhale — from which Kurosawa could pull nothing more. Neither recognition nor denial.

Then, just as evenly, without pressure, in that same voice that held something deeper than voice:

"You know one of me. I have others."

Kurosawa did not move.

He looked at the shadow on the paper. The shadow lingered a second — the shoulders lifted slightly and lowered, the way the shoulders are when a person makes one short bow — and vanished.

A board creaked. Once. Then — nothing.

Kurosawa still stood.

Then he slid the fourth door aside — with the care with which one slides a door behind which there is already no one.

The cab stood. The LED panel looped. The wipers went.

Behind the cab — a narrow passage. In the room's blind wall — where there should have been a blind wall — a plank panel had been slid aside. The passage went into blackness, downward, at an incline. A thin current of cold air came from it. It smelled of damp earth and lake.



From the radio rustled again.

"Kurosawa-san," Sasaki, quieter still. "In the corner of the cellar — a hatch. Metal. Unlocked. Goes down. Smells of the lake."

"Tunnel. He passed there."

"Do you want me to go."

"No. Not alone. I'm coming to you."

"Kurosawa-san."

"Yes."

"One more. In a niche by the wall — a small cabinet. I opened it. Inside — nine photographs. Nine. Polaroids. Small. Each — with someone's face. Three of them — Sato, Aoi, Ito. One — Hiroshi

Maeda. That's Book 1. One — a woman I don't know. One — a man I don't know. And one — Ayano."

Kurosawa closed his eyes. For one second. Then opened them.

"Take them all. Do not describe them on site. We describe in Sapporo."

"Yes."

"Wait for me."

He set off farther down the corridor — to the *zashiki* — to the partition — to the kitchen — to the cellar doors. He did not look back at the fourth door.



Kurosawa descended.

The tunnel was low — he walked with head bent. Walls — clay, reinforced with old wooden beams. He counted fifteen steps. Twenty. Thirty. The earth went down, then — even. Then — up.

He came out through a hatch in an abandoned boathouse on the southern shore of the lake.

The door of the boathouse was ajar. He looked out.

On the ice of the lake — a fresh snowmobile trail. Thin, clear. Led eastward — to the far bank, beyond which rose dark cedars, and beyond the cedars — the *Shiretoko* forest.

Kurosawa stood by the door. He did not run. He knew he would not catch up. He knew the Doll Maker had appeared and gone not so he could be caught — but so that Kurosawa would know he had been spoken to.

He took out the radio.

"Kenji. Trail. Southern shore. Log the track on the lake while it's visible. Sasaki — into the cellar. Take the notebook."

"Yes."

He stood another second, looking at the trail. Then turned and went back through the tunnel.



In the ryokan's corridor Aoi, Sato, and Ito were being lifted by paramedics. Kenji stood at the genkan, held a tablet, showed the officer the map with the snowmobile track. Sasaki was coming out of the cellar — with the thin notebook in her hand — and in her eyes was what she now knew and had not yet told him.

Toshi stood beyond the gate, past the line. Did not come in. Did not ask. Only when Kurosawa passed him toward the minibus — Toshi said quietly:

"He spoke with you."

"Yes."

"He has never spoken with you before."

"Yes."

Toshi nodded once.

Kurosawa got into the minibus. Sasaki — beside him, with the notebook on her lap. Kenji — behind the wheel, with the gray face of a man who has not slept three days and now understands he will not sleep another.

The engine caught quietly.

Behind, at the gate, Toshi still stood. He did not wave.



In Kotan, Nabesawa Sae met them on the threshold of the guest house. She looked into Kurosawa's eyes longer than she had allowed herself at the first meeting the evening before.

"You went," she said.

"I went."

"And left the tag."

"Left it."

"The house heard you out."

Kurosawa did not answer at once. He knew she was not speaking of the ryokan.

"Yes," he said. "Heard me out."

She nodded. Asked no more. One of the village women — younger, in a gray down jacket — led two of the found ones from the sled and led them to a neighboring house; the paramedics from Obihiro already stood by their van and waited.

Kurosawa went into the guest house, into the same room with the *irori*. Sasaki laid the notebook on the low table. Kenji set the laptop beside it. He sat between them, not taking off his coat.

Aoi sat in another room of the guest house, in the elder Nabesawa's blanket, drinking tea in small sips. Sato lay on a futon, eyes on the ceiling. Ito sat straight, in his JR jacket, holding in the breast pocket the small lacquered miniature tray. Three paramedics from Obihiro worked with them by turns. None of the three asked anything. None of the three remembered how he'd come to be here.

Kurosawa let himself look at each of them for one minute. No more. He knew that more would already be transferring theirs onto himself, and he had no right to transfer now.

Then he came back to the room where the notebook lay on the low table.

He opened the notebook to the first page. The Doll Maker's calligraphy — the same — even, thin, with the barely perceptible slant downward to the right that the hand has when it writes quickly and yet cautiously.

Dates. Codes. Notes of resettlements. He ran his eyes to the end — the last five pages were already empty — the notebook was half full, half open.

The last entry — three days ago. The code W-2. One number. One arrow. The mark of place — only the first letter. *Sh*.

He closed the notebook.

Sasaki said nothing. Kenji did not either.

Kurosawa laid his palms on the cover. Did not move them.

The house at his back held the shape of a house without them.

CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE

Still waiting

Three characters. Three years.

The village of Kotan lay in the blue pre-dawn light. The lamp in the window of the elder Nabesawa Sae — the one about which she had said “*twelve years*” — burned quietly, as it should.

They had rented her far room in the guest house. Six tatami. A low table by the window. In the corner — an *irori* with residual coals.

Kenji had been sitting at the table for the third hour now. The laptop in front of him was open. A second machine — a small gray box with a connected disk — stood beside it, with cables running to three USB hubs. His face was lit from below in cold blue. His hair had come loose from the ponytail. The IQOS lay beside him, forgotten, with a thin red heating indicator. He had not smoked in two hours.

Sasaki slept at the wall, under a blanket, palm to cheek. Breathing evenly.

Toshi, who had reached them on a snowmobile from the direction of the old gravel track an hour after the ryokan, was sitting by the *shōji* in the next room — they could hear him shift a cup — and did not come in without invitation.

Kurosawa sat opposite Kenji. Did not drink. Did not smoke. He looked at the screen, not to read anything from it, but because he could not now look at anything else.

On the screen was one work from *pixiv*. Profile '@ayano.k.16'. Tag — "*snow room*". Date of publication — six weeks before the raid.

The interior of a small room. Tatami. A futon. A low table. A small window with ribbed glass. In the corner — a lacquered tray with a teapot. The stroke of a thin line — the same one — with that barely perceptible microtouch with which she had drawn deer in January of 2024 and sent him a phone photo from the station at Utoro.

In the foreground — a woman's hand. Long fingers. Hair drawn into a knot.

There was no face.

Kurosawa had been looking at the work since the third hour of the night. He had studied it by heart to the level where you stop seeing the whole — only the enumeration of details is left: the window with ribbed glass, the wooden beam with a scratch, the shadow on the futon, the lacquered tray.

He waited.

Kenji swallowed from a can of *Boss Coffee*, empty — with the care with which one swallows from a can in which nothing is left. Set the can into the heap of the others. Wiped his palms on his trousers.

"Kurosawa-san."

Quietly.

"Yes."

Kenji did not go on at once. He clicked twice with the mouse. Three times. On the screen a window opened with a line of code — long, of the sort that only programmers manage to befriend.

"There's an EXIF comment here. Three characters. Hidden."

Kurosawa did not answer at once. He felt his breath go deeper — not by will, but by the way the body itself takes in air when it understands it will need a lot.

"Which."

Kenji with one motion selected three characters in the line — they lit yellow — and turned the screen toward him.

「まだ待つ」

Kurosawa looked. He knew these ideograms. Each of them.
Mada matsu.

Still waiting.

He did not at once see below, in small Latin letters, in brackets, Kenji's own comment. A technical note: *"encoded in the EXIF field UserComment, UTF-8 BOM, length 12 bytes, preserved on file regeneration from Clip Studio 2.0."*

Kurosawa read the Japanese aloud.

"Mada matsu."

Kenji nodded.

"Still waiting," said Kurosawa.

He said it as one might to a person who does not know Japanese — evenly, with the care with which one translates something important. Only in this moment there was no such person in the room. He translated it to himself.



From childhood Ayano used to write him small notes and slip them under the door of his apartment in Maruyama. She did it every time he was angry with her for something — a truancy, a missed dinner,

going to Otaru for the day without her phone. The notes were short. Three characters. *Mada matsu*. Or four. *Sono mama*. Or five. *Daijōbu da yo*. He would find them when he came back late from work. He would read. He would answer with his own — also short, also under her door — and go to sleep.

He did not remember when they stopped doing this. Probably when she turned fourteen. Probably not. Probably one such note was still lying in his kitchen drawer — under the upper tray — dated the twenty-third of November, two thousand and twenty. He had not been into that drawer for years.

Three characters. *Mada matsu*. Her code.

No one in the world knew it. No one but him and Ren. Ren died on the seventieth kilometer from Tokachi in February of two thousand twenty-two. Now — after Endo — even this was no longer true.

But the code was known only to him and Ren. And, now, to whoever had made Ayano write this code into the EXIF.

Or Ayano herself.

Or Ayano herself.

He pressed a palm to his mouth. Held it there three seconds. Removed it.

"Kurosawa-san," Kenji, quieter.

Kurosawa did not answer at once.

Sasaki at the wall turned quietly in her sleep. Did not wake. Only her palm slid from beneath the blanket and lay on the tatami, back of hand up.

"Three years," said Kurosawa.

He said it evenly, as a number.

Pause.

He stood up. His legs did not move at once — for a second they did not know whether to stand. Then they stood. He stepped over the tatami and went to the window.

The window gave onto the lake. The sky was lightening by two tones. The ice glinted.

He placed a palm on the paper edge of the window. He looked at nothing. He held his palm there because his body needed something under his palm.

"I'm going," he said.

Softly at first, to himself.

Then, turning — to Kenji:

"I'm going."

Kenji did not understand at once.

"Where."

"After her."

"We don't know where."

"I know she's alive," said Kurosawa. "The rest — is a question of maps."

Kenji closed his mouth. Nodded once.

From the next room, through the thin paper partition, came a quiet, short exhalation from Toshi — the way one breathes on recognizing something one had predicted but hoped would not come to pass. He said nothing.



Kurosawa sat back at the table.

"Kenji," he said. "I need to know everything. IP of the publication. Device. Time. The stroke. Comparison with the archive. Not today. But begin today."

"Already begun."

"Give me forty minutes."

Kenji nodded.

Kurosawa stood. Walked to the kettle over the *irori*, with its dead coal. Did not pour. He understood now that for three years he had held two versions of one thing separately. One: Ayano is alive, and must be found. Two: Ayano is dead, and must be lived with. He had held both versions at once because neither could be chosen without more information than he had. Now the greater information was three characters in an EXIF field. It did not make the first true entirely. It only ruled out the second.

He took a step back to the table.

Kurosawa closed the laptop gently — the way one closes a child's notebook — and laid his palms on top of it. He sat like that a long time. Kenji beside him did not move. He knew now was not the time to move.



Kenji started to speak on — quietly, in the rhythm a person uses when he knows the listener does not need to listen right now, but continues anyway, because a human voice in the room is sometimes more useful than silence.

"File generated in Clip Studio Paint 2.0. That version came out in March 2026. Ayano didn't use one like that before she disappeared. That means the work was made after the disappearance."

"Yes."

"IP of the publication — Tor node. Amsterdam-exit. Device — MacBook Air, M3 chip. That's a heap of info that won't get us a provider. But in Clip Studio's metadata a unique license ID remains. I'm pulling it. It's not a name. It's a number. But the number's tied to the date of activation. If it was activated by purchase — there's a card with it. If a card — a city with it. If a city — that's a circle in which the device lies. A month or two."

"A month or two."

"I've started."

Kurosawa did not immediately understand. Then:

"Kenji."

"Yes."

"Thank you."

Kenji did not answer at once. He reached for the IQOS, saw the indicator had gone out, put it back.

"You don't have to, Kurosawa-san."

"I have to."

Pause.

Kenji lowered his eyes. He did not know how to receive such things and so he did not try.



Then Kurosawa opened the inner pocket of his coat and drew from it a photograph.

Old. Corners bent. Ayano at sixteen, the platform of Shiretoko station, a winter morning. Dark jacket. A backpack with a scratched festival pin. Hair fallen across one eye. A scarf — not hers, light-gray, silk, wrapped twice.

He held the photograph three centimeters from his eyes. He looked at her face. He let his memory set beside it the face of the one who was now on the pixiv work without a face. He looked for what remained the same in them. The hair — yes. The thin turn of the wrist on the pencil — perhaps. The stroke style — yes.

He knew.

He had long known.

He had not let himself believe for three years.

He exhaled one long, even breath — the one on six counts — and set the photograph face-up beside the laptop. Did not put it away.

"Mada," he said, "matsu."

Pause.

"Mada," quietly, "matsu. Aya-chan."

He held his palm alongside the photograph. Did not touch.

Kenji did not look at him.

Beyond the window the ice of the lake had taken on two more tones of blue. Somewhere toward the far shore, very far — so far that this was more a supposition of hearing than the sound itself — a cedar branch creaked under snow and shed a light white avalanche from itself, which broke apart in air before reaching the ground.



He stood again. Went to the sliding partition and pushed it aside by one shoulder's width.

Toshi sat in the neighboring room exactly at the center of the tatami, in *seiza*. Before him — a cup with cold tea. He was not drinking. He was looking at the partition. He was waiting.

Kurosawa stepped across the threshold and stopped. He did not sit.

"You knew," he said.

Toshi slowly raised his eyes to him.

"I told you, inspector," he said quietly. "In the *zashiki* of Kamishiroi."

"You said she was alive. You didn't say she was alive in a net, with a code W-2, in a room he had built for her before she disappeared."

Toshi did not answer.

Kurosawa allowed himself one long pause.

"You knew," he repeated. "How long."

"Not as long as you think," said Toshi. "And longer than I let myself. That's not the same answer. Kurosawa-keibu."

"I'm listening."

"I will not lead you to her. Not because I don't want to. I do not know for certain."

"I know."

"But I know where he will not take her. And that — is a small map. A small exception from a large one."

"Give it to me."

Toshi nodded.

"I will. Not today. Today you don't need me. Today I will only get in the way of your head putting in place what I just clarified for you."

Kurosawa did not move.

"Toshi-san."

"Yes."

"Why did you not say three years ago."

Toshi was long in answering.

"Because three years ago," he said quietly, "I was not the one who says this. And because I would have lied to you if I had said it then. And because I am still not sure I am not lying now."

Kurosawa looked at him. Long.

Kurosawa slid the partition back and returned to Kenji.



Sasaki turned in her sleep and woke.

She saw the photograph on the table. She saw Kurosawa's face. She did not rise. She only turned her head on the pillow and looked at him. Long.

Kurosawa did not look at her.

He kept his palm alongside the photograph. He knew that this was already a different photograph — the same piece of cardboard, the same grainy shot — but now it weighed differently, because from it a room had opened in which someone was still drawing.

For three years he had never allowed himself to remember Ayano's face whole. He held it in parts — the left eye in the moment she raised her head from a notebook in eighth grade; the right turn of the wrist when she held a pencil; the thin shadow of a strand on the temple in the carriage. He did not let the parts converge. He knew — as those who work with missing persons for twenty years know — that if you let the parts converge and they do not converge, then memory begins to fill in, and from the face you remembered something else remains, which never was. He preferred to leave the parts as parts.

Now — on the pixiv work, with the face that was not drawn — all the parts were opened to him at once. And he could stop keeping them separate.

He allowed it.

He allowed the left eye to converge with the right turn of the wrist. He allowed the shadow of the strand to converge with that left eye. He allowed everything. In the room it became one tone lighter — as it becomes when you draw back a curtain on a winter noon.

He smiled.

Once. Briefly. The way people smile who suddenly see a person they had considered lost at the table across from them, and in the first half-second do not know how to react; and therefore they smile, because for *"for now"* there is no other gesture.

"Still waiting," he said.

Pause.

He put his palm on Kenji's shoulder. Held it there two seconds.

Kenji — with the look of a boy on whose shoulder an older man is placing a hand for the first time in his life — froze for a second.

Then he patted Kurosawa on the back twice. Briefly, awkwardly.

Kurosawa nodded.

Then — to Sasaki:

"We go."

Pause.

「まだ待つ」

Still waiting.

Three years.

Pause.

I'm coming.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR

The forest

He will not stop.

Ashibetsu-yama received them on the second day after Shiretoko-ko with the same face it had shown the first time: gravel road, partly cleared, empty yard, kitchen with a kettle — this time cold — and a corridor with nine doors, behind not one of which was anything now.

Kurosawa walked the whole of it. He had not expected to find. He did not find. In the seventh room stood a box — sealed this time — and inside it was not a backpack. Inside were bags of grass for tatami. In the alcove of the *tokonoma* hung a scroll with the ideogram 静, quietly — and for that reason Kurosawa stood before it longer than he needed to.

The Doll Maker had taken from here everything that could speak. He left what speaks by its very absence.

In the kitchen — under the thin cherry board — Sasaki found a single scrap of paper. Palm-sized. A thin calligraphic hand. Three lines of haiku. Unsigned.

Yuki no ma ni / koe no nai koe o / dareka kiku.

Toshi, when they showed it to him, nodded once and said:

"It's his."

"He was here."

"He was always here."

He handed the paper back to Sasaki — between two fingers — and did not look at it again.



The Shiretoko forest that following week gave them a thin trail.

Kenji, who on the first night after the ryokan had pulled the data from the tunnel and the snowmobile trail, drew out of *Hokkaiden*-billing across eastern Hokkaido six anomalies over three days. Three of them lay within a day's walk from Shiretoko-ko. He filtered out two (a ski base, an emergency station). One remained — an abandoned watch hut on the slope of Mount *Rausudake*, where the last payment for electricity was in 2015. Over the past six days there had been nine hundred and forty watt-hours consumed.

It was not a ryokan. It was a portable node — the place where the Doll Maker could come to sleep two or three days while preparing the next move.

Kurosawa looked at the map. Then he said:

"Kenji, I want you working with me and Sasaki from home now. No office. Don't leave Miso alone."

Kenji nodded. Did not argue.

"Toshi."

Toshi, from the other end of the room, raised his eyes.

"I will not go with you further, inspector," he said.

Kurosawa nodded. He knew.

Toshi looked at him a long time.

"I will not be useful in the forest," he said. "I will be useful here. I will stay in Sapporo. I will read what you bring. I will not run. I have

nowhere."

"You're a consultant."

"I'm a consultant."

Pause.

"I will not see him," Toshi said quietly. "Ever. That — is your part."

Kurosawa did not answer.

"Kurosawa-keibu."

"Yes."

"Go without me. I am not holding you."

Kurosawa looked at him. He wanted to say something — not a thanks and not a reproach — but that short *I know* he usually kept in himself. He did not say it.

Toshi nodded once — for him — and lowered his eyes.



Ogawa's funeral had passed a month and a half before this. But now — after Shiretoko-ko — on the forty-ninth day — Kurosawa went to the cemetery alone.

He did not love the ritual. He knew he was coming not for Ogawa — Ogawa did not need him — but for himself, because otherwise this whole story would begin to stand in the corner of his apartment and wait until he spoke with it.

He walked in through the gates of *Hiraoka* cemetery at ten in the morning. The sky was low, snow grains fell finely, with that dry insistence with which it falls when the winter is testing itself.

Ogawa's grave lay in the third row, on the right side. The stone slab new. The name cut cleanly, without excess. Family marks — Ogawa. Dates. Two. Very close together.

He set down flowers — one white chrysanthemum — and folded his palms on his chest.

He did not pray. He stood. He let the wind set before him all the scenes in which Ogawa still was: the office balcony with that single cigarette per shift — a hand on the shoulder at the first walk out of the hospital after Noboribetsu — the soundless "*Kurosawa is leading this series*" at the meeting in January — and, last, that slip of paper with a four-digit number that Ogawa had wordlessly slid across the table. *Just in case.*

Kurosawa looked at the slab a long time.

Then, quietly:

"Sir."

Pause.

"He appeared."

Pause.

"I will catch him. Not today. But I will catch him."

He turned and walked. He did not look back. He did not need to look back.



That evening Sasaki brought bento.

She came in without knocking — she'd had the key since January — and set the bag on the kitchen table. The kitchen smelled of coffee, once-smoked, and cold rice from yesterday. Kurosawa was

washing the pot in the sink.

"You haven't eaten," she said.

"Not hungry."

"Eat anyway."

He wiped his hands on the towel and sat. She laid out the bento — two. Both alike. Vegetables, steamed salmon, rice with black sesame. She began to eat first, in silence.

He ate three spoons. Then set the chopsticks aside.

"Sasaki."

"Yes."

"The notebook."

"I'm reading. Every evening."

"What's there."

She did not answer a long time. Then:

"Twenty-eight ryokans. Of them nine — with names. Nine — with dates of entry into service, some before 2010. Nine codes of victims — active. Of these we know four. Three are now home. One — with the code W-2."

"Yes."

Pause.

"And one more thing, Kurosawa-san. The one who held the key to Ogawa's schedule — he is on our floor. We are still looking. That is a separate line."

"I know. That's not for now."

"Not for now."

Pause.

"Kurosawa-san."

He raised his eyes to her.

She sat straight. Palms on knees. Gaze lowered to the bento — on the boundary between the salad and the rice — not on him.

"I did not tell you everything about Nao," she said.

He did not answer at once. He knew. He had known since March — and in March had decided not to ask. He was not sure now he wanted to.

"I'm listening."

She took one even breath.

"Her *LiveJournal* entry — the one I told you about, with the gap — I told you it was one entry."

"Yes."

"It isn't one. It's three. One — for the third of January 2019, mother's memorial. The second — for November 2023. The third — for April of this year. In all of them — one edit. One gap. Timestamp of edit — the fifteenth of October. The same day as Sato, Aoi, Ito. The very same day."

Pause.

"He was filtering her for three years."

Kurosawa closed his eyes. Only for one second.

"You took her out of the system."

"I did. My parents and I. She's not in any service now. She doesn't have a phone. She has a new address, I don't even have her in my contacts. Father takes her out on walks by a single route. That's for

now, not forever. That's until he finds another way."

"And you didn't tell me."

"I didn't tell you."

Pause.

"I thought that if I told you — you would take me off. I thought you would say: '*Sasaki, you cannot lead a case in which your kin is a potential victim.*' And you would be right. But then we don't find him. You alone. Kenji alone. We are not enough for each other, Kurosawa-san."

He did not answer at once.

He looked at her — not in reproach. In the way one person looks at another who has just laid on the table between them a thing she has carried with her for a year.

"Sasaki."

"Yes."

"You are right."

She closed her eyes for a second.

"I would have taken you off," he said. "And we would not have found him."

Pause.

"But I have to know. Not because I will order you. Because I have to know why, when you lift your cup earlier than I do, I know why."

"I know."

"That's once."

"Yes."

"Twice is not the way it goes."

She nodded — a small nod, without posture.

He took the chopsticks. He put one piece of salmon in his mouth. He chewed a long time. She finished her bento. He finished half of his. He set the bento aside. She gathered the dishes.

She stood.

By the door, tying her scarf — the gray one from which she had not removed the tag — she turned back.

"Kurosawa-san."

"Yes."

"Ayano is alive."

He looked at her.

"Yes."

"We will find her."

He did not answer at once.

"Yes."

She went out. The door shut quietly. He heard her go down the stairs and her steps fall silent on the first floor. He sat at the table a minute. Then he stood and put the pot on the burner.



Kenji that week made a preliminary map.

Twenty-eight ryokans. Nine active — all known. Three freed. One lives in Shiretoko-ko (now empty). One — Ashibetsu-yama (empty before this). One — Rebun-jima (not reached). One — Zao-minami (Yamagata, no). One — code W-2. Location — within

the old Shiretoko forest, where the border with the national park holds a line between two old Ainu settlements. Exact coordinates — Kenji did not have. But the circle was twenty kilometers in diameter.

He printed the map. Stitched it in a folder. Brought it to Kurosawa.

"Kurosawa-san."

"Yes."

"It's not an address. It's a district."

"I know."

"Twenty kilometers — a lot."

"Yes."

"But here," Kenji opened the laptop, showed the power-consumption anomaly, "from 2024 to this year the same transformer has been giving out steadily nine percent more than it should by spec. It's a small anomaly. You won't see it unless you're looking. I was looking."

Kurosawa looked at the map a long time.

"When we go," said Kenji, "I'm with you."

Kurosawa looked at him.

"You haven't been in the forest."

"I haven't."

"Then you're home."

"I'm with you."

Pause.

Kurosawa nodded.

"You're in the minibus. You don't come out until signal. Your link with us — is you."

"Yes."

"Not the hero."

"Not the hero."



He put the map into the inner pocket of his coat, over his heart, beside the photograph.

He switched off the lamp in the room. Went to the kitchen. Sat there a long time with the cold pot from which he had not poured coffee. He listened as somewhere in the neighboring apartment Ryoko quietly moved the dishes on the shelf. He listened as beyond the window on Maruyama someone's car went past. Not in a hurry.

He knew he would not sleep this night.

He opened the kitchen drawer — the one under the upper tray — and lowered a hand into it. His fingers felt a folded twice slip of thin paper. He drew it out.

Three characters. Her handwriting. Childish, with a slight lean to the left.

まだ待つ

Still waiting.

He had read this on the twenty-third of November two thousand twenty. He had been angry with her at the time for something he no longer remembered. She had slipped the note under the door of his apartment while he slept. He had found it in the morning. He had not answered then with his own note. He had forgotten.

He now put the paper back into the drawer. Carefully. Into the same position. He slid the drawer to the end.



The next day other news came.

Aoi Nakamura had begun to talk with her mother by phone. Not about Haru. About work. About the fact that she did not remember when she had last been at Ezo Systems. About the fact that when she closed her eyes her right shoulder ached, and she did not know why.

Ito Kazuo had asked Miho to move the JR Hokkaido badge into the pocket of his old jacket. He said he wanted to go to the Kamikazu hydroelectric station — just for one day — to apologize to Watanabe-san.

Miho nodded. Did not correct.

Sato was silent. He sat in the rehabilitation ward of Sapporo Kōsei-ren, straight on his bed, in the white cook's shirt — the same one — and looked out of the window at the grain of snow. Kurosawa visited him on Thursday. Brought him one pack of "Peace."

"Sato-san."

Sato did not answer at once. He looked at the pack. His thin fingers — the same scar on the left cuff — took it carefully, the way one takes something one recognizes but does not remember from where.

"Kurosawa-keibu."

"Yes."

"You are late."

Kurosawa did not answer at once.

"I know."

Sato opened the pack. Did not light one. Only smelled it. Then closed it and put it on the nightstand.

"Kenta," Sato said quietly.

"Yes."

"He is alive."

Kurosawa did not answer at once.

He knew that Kenta the nephew of Sato-san had died underwater on the twenty-seventh of September, nineteen ninety-eight, and that Kenta the elder brother of Sato had died of pneumonia in nineteen sixty-nine, and that both Kentas now lived in Sato-san's head as some one, other, that was Kenta neither the one nor the other. He knew Endo on the balcony of the morgue had promised him not to ask him the name in the first hour. He knew this concerned Ayano, not Sato.

He did not correct.

"Yes," he said quietly. "Alive."

Sato nodded. Once. Did not look at him again. Looked out the window.

Kurosawa sat another five minutes. Then he stood, laid a palm on Sato's shoulder — carefully, as one lays it on glass. Said nothing. Went.

In the corridor of the rehabilitation ward he stood by the window. Beyond the window was the parking lot. It smelled of disinfectant and the faint smell of morning soup from the canteen. He allowed himself one cigarette — there, on the balcony for visitors — the second by the book.

He finished it. Drew once deeply. Extinguished it.

He knew that the Doll Maker now held Sato in his head. He knew that he would not pull him out of there entirely. He knew that this was not a victory — this was only a transport.

He drove to the office.



On Monday evening he went to Endo at the morgue. Not on the protocol; for the conversation. She met him on the balcony, with a cigarette, in a white coat over a gray pullover. The sky over Sapporo was black with a pink orange at the lower edge.

"Kurosawa."

"Machiko-san."

"You look bad."

"I know."

She exhaled the smoke away from him.

"The body in Ren's grave — is not Ren. I already told you that. I cannot now tell you whose. That may take a year. Or — never."

"I know."

"Ayano is alive."

"I know."

She looked at him longer than she usually allowed herself.

"Kurosawa," she said. "If you find her, do not ask her her name in the first hour. Let her recognize you without the question."

He did not answer at once. He knew she was saying this not as an expert but as a person who had held her sister's file in the morgue

already twenty-four years.

"Yes," he said.

She finished the cigarette. Extinguished it on the metal rim of the rail. Dropped it into the coat pocket.

"Go, Kurosawa. Don't sit. Don't think too much. He does this so that you sit and think."

"I know."

He went.



Toshi came to the office on Friday. Kenji that day was again working from home. Sasaki was not there — she had gone to her parents in Sapporo-Higashi.

Toshi arrived exactly at ten. He brought with him a small plastic folder with printed pages. Haiku. Thirty-one of them. All found over ten months on 5channel, under different aliases. He laid them on Kurosawa's desk.

"They are his," said Toshi. "All."

Kurosawa looked at the sheets a long time.

"You're sure."

"Yes."

"What is to be done with them."

"I don't know. I only identified them."

Pause.

Toshi sat across from him. The electronic bracelet on his ankle was visible from beneath the trouser leg. He was not hiding it.

"Toshi-san," said Kurosawa.

"Yes."

"You are staying in Sapporo."

"Yes."

"I want you to confirm it once more. Before witnesses. To Prosecutor Fujiwara."

Toshi nodded.

"I'll confirm."

Pause.

"And one more thing."

"Yes."

Kurosawa looked at him a long time.

"If you ever," he said quietly, "decide to go from us to him — I want to know first."

Toshi did not answer at once.

Then:

"Yes."

Pause.

"Kurosawa-keibu."

"Yes."

"I will not go."

"I know."

"I will not go not because I do not want to."

"I know."

Kurosawa nodded once and lowered his eyes to the sheets of haiku.

Toshi stood. Went to the door. At the door he stopped.

"Kurosawa-keibu."

"Yes."

"You will catch him."

"I know."

"Not because you are better."

"I know."

"But because you are not tired."

Kurosawa raised his eyes to him.

Toshi looked back.

"And he is tired, inspector."

He opened the door and went out.

Kurosawa sat. Long. Then he laid a palm on the sheets of haiku and did not move it.



In the corridor behind the glass partition stood Tanaka. In a coat, briefcase by his leg. Did not come in — waiting until Kurosawa lifted his eyes to him.

Kurosawa lifted.

Tanaka came in two steps. Did not sit. Did not take off his coat.

"Ashibetsu empty?"

"Empty."

"I knew."

He said nothing more. Nodded once, turned, went out. In the corridor a second later the elevator doors clicked.

Kurosawa remained sitting. Looked at the closed office door. Tanaka had not asked from curiosity; Tanaka had asked to confirm what he already had within himself. That was new — and that was bad news.

He knows more than we do, thought Kurosawa. He has known this for a long time. And he is not with us.



He stood from the desk, went to the window. Beyond the window on Maruyama the lamps still burned. One — the one by the turn to the next street — flickered every few seconds. It had always flickered like that. No one changed it.

He stood by the window a long time. Then he placed a palm on the glass. The glass was cold; the warmth of the palm on it left a mark, and the mark became clearer, until he took his hand away. The mark held another second and then vanished.

He knew that tomorrow he would put a red pin on the map in the center of that twenty-kilometer circle. He knew that it would not be an address — it would be only the center of the circle. He knew that with the same center he could sit here another six months. He knew he would not.

He lifted the pot and began to grind the beans.

He knew he would not sleep. He knew he would be at work in the morning earlier than anyone. He knew that the Shiretoko forest would be waiting.

The night, beyond the window, held the shape of the night.



EPILOGUE

The air

I knew you would come closer.

The Shiretoko forest held the winter the way one holds a bowl — with thin edges, not spilling.

The hut stood in a saddle between two hillocks, hidden by old cedar branches. The roof — of cold. The walls — of cold. Inside — the thin, hair-thin warm shaft that lays itself down in an abandoned house where in the corner stands a small kerosene stove.

He set the stove to the lowest flame. Took off his felt jacket. Laid it on the wooden crate beside him. Took from the shelf over the bed the clay teapot the color of wet slate and the white cup with the thin crack in the base. Set them on the board. Poured water from a ceramic jug — not from the tap. There was no tap here.

The radio receiver stood by the window. Old, wooden, with a needle-scale and one regulator knob with a metal notch. Batteries — fresh, inserted today. The antenna — short, pulled out by hand to its end.

He switched it on.

White noise came. Then — the thin whine of the search. Then, on the short wave — even, with those grains of the atmospheric tick-tick that had always been in the Hokkaido police ether — a woman's dispatch voice. He set the search-flame at this frequency.

"...twenty-two. Tokachi Patrol, confirm route. Over."

"Tokachi-two. Route confirmed. Segment of the three-twenty-second, from Obihiro east. Over."

"Received."

Pause. Atmospheric crackle.

"...all patrols of the eastern district. Priority three. Person search. Description without description. Style-mark: a traveling man, age forty-five to sixty, possibly with a rucksack. Particular attention — the Rausudake district, the border line of Shiretoko National Park. Kurosawa-keibu, operation head. On contact — do not approach. Call for reinforcement. Over."

He held his hand near the receiver. Did not touch the knob. He let the voice pass through the room evenly, the way one lets a guest through.

"...twenty-two, understood. Over."

"...seven, understood, over."

"...ten, understood, over."

Voices came one after another, from nine patrols, from nine points of Hokkaido. He counted them — not to know the number, but because the number kept his hands at work. Nine.

He poured water into the teapot. Set the teapot on the stove. The water took its time to warm.

He sat on the crate. Placed his palms on his knees, backs of hands up. The walls of the hut smelled of long-ago wood and the light smell of old tea that had settled in the corners. In the niche at the far wall — not a *tokonoma*, but a shelf of two boards — stood one small porcelain figurine without a face. Old. He had brought it here first, before anything else. That was the law.

The radio continued.

"...report any movement in butts above a thousand meters. Key word — 'find,' not 'detain.' Kurosawa-keibu asks: no single-man actions. Over."

Kurosawa asks.

He for a moment closed his eyes. Not from tiredness. With that brief gesture with which a person who has heard the names of other people for many years in the ether recognizes one name with which he has his own conversation.

He opened his eyes.

The kettle whistled on the stove — with the thin whistle of boiling that always begins a half-second before a person expects it. He took the kettle off. Poured water into the cup through a fine strainer. A thin steam rose in that vertical thread which is easy to break if you place the cup badly.

He set the cup on the board evenly.

The radio did not stop.

"...Abashiri patrol, report. Over."

"Abashiri-one. In the points Utoro and Rausu — silence. We are heading toward Shiretoko-yamaguchi. Over."

"Received. Keep in touch."

He took the cup. Held it in both hands. The warmth came through the porcelain into his palms — the kind that always arrives later than a person expects it — and stayed.

He sipped.

The tea was simple. Hot. As he liked it.

Beyond the window of the hut — a winter forest, gray and even, with those vertical black lines of cedars that always stand where they were placed and never where they were thought to be. Snow fell in a fine grain, without wind. The sky had that August-lead cast with which Hokkaido holds noon in the second week of December.

He knew how long it took a patrol to walk from Utoro to the road on Rausudake — three hours. He knew a patrol would pass the hut at half a kilometer. That they would not climb this slope today. That tomorrow, perhaps, a dog handler would be sent.

He knew this and did not move.

He knew that when they came, he would go on — to the second hut, to the third, to the six points between Memuro and Cape Erimo, in each of which lay a single steering clavicle. He knew that all of this had been prepared twenty years ago.

He also knew that Inspector Kurosawa Yukio now knew his voice.

For twenty years he had held his "I" one paper-shōji further away. For twenty years he had not entered the room Inspector Kurosawa

had entered. Now — as quietly as he held himself — he had entered it himself, not by body, but by voice, and now that voice could no longer be taken off the tape.

He did not regret it.

He allowed himself one thin gesture — with the index finger of his right hand he touched the porcelain figurine on the shelf. Very briefly. The way one touches a photograph of a child one hasn't seen in years.

Then, with the same evenness with which one pours water into the teapot, he spoke into the empty room one sentence. Not to the receiver. Not to a sleeping man. Not to himself. Into the air of the hut, which he trusted more than people.

"I knew you would come closer."

THE DOLL MAKER FILES CONCLUDES IN THE NEXT BOOK

THE LAST ROOM

Cape Erimo held the wind like a taut string.

Kurosawa stood beside the eighth of nine pillars of the old fishing pier. It was meant to be empty. He set his palm against the inner face, where the bronze clamp entered the wood, and the clamp gave.

Behind it was a niche.

In the niche — one child's clavicle, with a fine crack down its center. And one sheet of paper, folded in fours, with one word written in black ink.

Kurosawa.

He put the clavicle back.

He kept the paper.

The road to the last room began here.

About the Author

Yehor Selin is the author of «The Doll Maker Files».